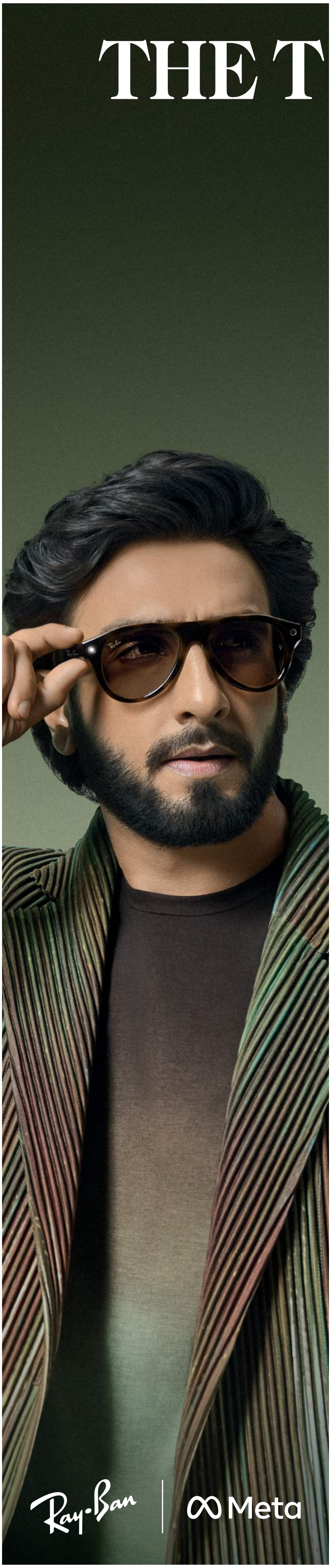
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**Adam Milne's 4-wkt haul & half-centuries from Tim Seifert and Glenn Phillips give NZ a 7-wkt win over India in final T20I. India wins series 3-2, P 15**

SHRI. D.K. SHIVAKUMAR
Hon'ble Chief Minister
Government of Karnataka

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Government of Karnataka

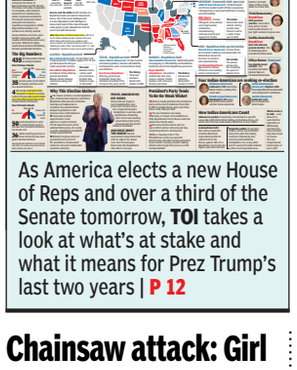
## PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen bag Hylo Open titles

PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen made it a double delight for India, claiming the women's and men's singles titles with straight-game victories in the finals of Hylo Open Super 500 badminton tournament on Sunday. **P 14**

## Commercial LPG, ATF rates hiked

Oil marketing companies Sunday raised commercial LPG prices by Rs 10. A 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder used by hotels and restaurants will now cost Rs 2,820 in Delhi. ATF rates rose by Rs 1.37, and now stand at Rs 138.5 per litre. **P 5**

## US MIDTERMS: WORLD WATCHES




As America elects a new House of Reps and over a third of the Senate tomorrow, **TOI** takes a look at what's at stake and what it means for Prez Trump's last two years | **P 12**

## INDIA Bloc Allies In Full Strength At 'Vote Bachao' Rally, BJP Calls It A Flop

# Gyanesh has to go, PM & Shah next, says Rahul

Tarun Rawat

Around 50,000 people turned up for INDIA bloc's rally in Delhi on Sunday, according to Delhi Police estimates

**Subodh Ghildiyal & Ambika Pandit**

**New Delhi:** In a Ramlila Maidan packed with protesters and ringing with anti-BJP and anti-CEC slogans Sunday, Congress MP Rahul Gandhi said the opposition will confront the top BJP duo of Narendra Modi and Amit Shah after Gyanesh Kumar's removal as chief election commissioner. The trio was losing sleep over agitation, he claimed, and said the CEC's exit would be the first step in putting the country back on track.

With opposition biggies Mallikarjun Kharge, Sonia Gandhi, Akhilesh Yadav, Mamata Banerjee, Tejashwi Yadav, Dipankar Bhattacharya, MA Baby, Farooq Abdullah and Mehbooba Mufti on the dais, the leader of opposition in Lok Sabha said the "voice of the people of India" is greater to him than even religion, and he will brook no assault on it.

Mocking BJP's catchphrase – "Modi kahin nahin jayega" – coined in response to Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge's comment, Rahul said the PM won't be allowed to go anywhere. "You cannot flee... You will stay here and face action."

With a "vote bachao, desh bachao" banner forming the backdrop of the dais, the speakers focused on "vote chori" allegations.

▶ **People's voice, P 7**

### EC to tweak portal on tribunal demand

Following objections and demands from judges of SIR tribunals, Election Commission is likely to modify its portal to allow them to consider documents beyond the 13 listed for voter inclusion, and record their observations while disposing of appeals. **P 9**

## Rahul can be PM only in mock Parliament, says home minister

**Munieshwer Sagar & Manash Gohain** | TNN

**Chandigarh/New Delhi:** BJP derided INDIA bloc's rally against 'vote chori' as a "flop show", while Union minister **Amit Shah** said Rahul Gandhi could hope to be PM only in a 'mock parliament', referring to Congress's mock CEC impeachment.

Addressing a gathering on Chandigarh Police's 60th Raising Day on Sunday, Shah said Sonia Gandhi had resorted to the move since her dream of Rahul as PM was not fulfilled. "You (Rahul) want to become PM, stay in mock parliament your entire life; your turn won't come," Shah said.

▶ **1984 survivors, Sikh groups question timing of rally, P 7**

His remarks highlighted BJP's counter-punch to the opposition's campaign against EC and govt over SIR, with BJP functionaries, including CMs, participating in 'Save Democracy, Defeat Anarchy' marches across the country.

BJP president Nitin Nabin, who travelled to Rohtak, accused Rahul of deliberately destroying the credibility of constitutional bodies as part of his plan to sow anarchy.

▶ **'Salt into wounds', P 7**

# Govt mulls official status for Kannada flag, will discuss in B'gavi session

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Bengaluru:** CM D K Shivakumar Sunday said Karnataka govt was considering granting official recognition to the yellow-and-red Kannada flag as the state's flag without affecting the dignity of the Tricolour.

"The yellow-and-red flag has become an integral symbol of the state's identity. We'll discuss the matter and explore legal options in the upcoming Belagavi legislative session," the CM said at the 71st Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations here. He said the state had earlier passed a cabinet resolution and submitted a proposal to the Centre, but approval was awaited.

▶ **Cases against pro-Kannada activists to be withdrawn, P 4**

CM DK Shivakumar interacts with a child in Bengaluru on Sunday

▶ **Govt tried in 2018, P 3**

## Mahadev betting app promoter brought back from Oman: CBI

**Raipur:** Mahadev betting app promoter **Sourabh Chandrakar**, accused of running an illegal online betting network and paying protection money to public servants, has been extradited from Oman, the CBI said on Sunday.

A special team escorted him to India, and he is scheduled to be produced before a special court in Raipur on Monday. He is wanted in two CBI cases in which chargesheets have been filed, as well as an ED case in which a prosecution complaint has been submitted. TNN

▶ **Syndicate abroad, P 6**

# After milk and curd, bus fares will go up on Nov 5

**Bengaluru:** Transport minister **Byrathi Suresh** on Sunday confirmed that the proposed bus fare hike by Karnataka's state-run transport corporations would come into effect on Nov 5, adding to the financial burden on commuters after govt increased milk and curd prices.

Suresh, who made the announcement in Chikkaballapur, said the quantum of hike would be decided at a meeting on Nov 4. He alleged that the BJP-led central govt had increased diesel prices five times in the past year, resulting in an annual loss of Rs 2,000 crore for the four transport corporations. Their cumulative losses have already reached Rs 9,000 crore, he said.

The issue was discussed at a recent cabinet meeting, which entrusted CM DK Shivakumar & the transport department with the responsibility of deciding on the fare revision, he said. TNN

## GST mop-up rises record 23% in Oct, hits ₹2.3L cr

**New Delhi:** GST collections grew 22.9% in Oct – the fastest pace of expansion since the revamp of the tax regime in Sept 2025 – to reach Rs 2.3 lakh crore, the second-highest monthly mop-up since the rationalisation exercise. While consumption remains strong, the numbers indicate a bunching of quarter-end demand and the base effect as sales had slowed in Sept 2025. TNN

▶ **Meghalaya, HP top, P 13**

## Chainsaw attack: Girl undergoes 20-hr op

A girl, 14, injured in a chainsaw attack by cousin in AP's Raptadu Saturday, underwent 20 hours of surgery, received six units of blood and four units of plasma in Anantapur and Bengaluru. A second survivor is on ventilator. **P 4**

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## Bodies of 2 missing Kukis found in bags

Bodies of two Kuki youths allegedly abducted by Naga militants in Manipur were found in gunny bags Sunday, triggering protests and an extension of a shutdown in the Kuki-majority Kangpokpi district. They had been missing since Oct 28. **P 6**

## Top court upholds Delhi HC order to reassess income of ex-CJI's sons

**New Delhi:** Holding that Income Tax department is not precluded from conducting reassessment upon discovering evidence suggesting income had escaped assessment, SC upheld a Delhi HC order allowing the agency to reassess the income of the sons of former Chief Justice of India YK Sabharwal for 2008-09 and 2009-10.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran dismissed the appeal filed by the Sabharwals and said the notice issued by the department in 2015 was valid as it was based on reasons duly recorded and on tangible material of a report of its investigation unit.

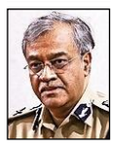
"We are of the firm view that the impugned notice dated March 31, 2015, issued by the assessing officer under Section 148 of Income Tax Act, for initiating reassessment for 2008-09 and 2009-10, was issued on reasons duly recorded and is valid," it said.

▶ **DGIT report, P 6**

# Phone used in sting op exchanged at HDK's Delhi home, says top cop

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Bengaluru:** The mobile phone allegedly used to upload a video targeting a former Karnataka CM was exchanged at the official Delhi residence of Union minister **HD Kumaraswamy**, according to Bengaluru City police commissioner **Seemant Kumar Singh**.



On investigations into alleged sting operation being probed by Cyber Crime Police Station, Singh said: "Accused Ritesh Pandey, arrested in connection with the case, had confessed the phone was exchanged at Kumaraswamy's residence. However, investigators are yet to establish who else was involved in the exchange and the extent of their roles in the alleged conspiracy."

A senior officer clarified they had only stated that the minister's residence was used for the exchange of the phone.

According to preliminary probe, Pandey allegedly worked in coordination with Vinod Sharma, a freelance social media content creator, and Prajwal Prasad, an alleged member of JD(S) social media wing, to procure the phone.

▶ **Police widen probe, P 3**

### 'Police chief's remark worse than head clerk'

HD Kumaraswamy questioned police commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh's conduct, accusing him of acting under someone's influence to protect his position. "People need not panic. I'll explain (on Monday) whom this sting operation will boomerang on, how far the probe has progressed and how the state govt is functioning," he said. "The commissioner's statement was worse than that of a head clerk. They cannot touch me. They cannot take me on so easily." TNN

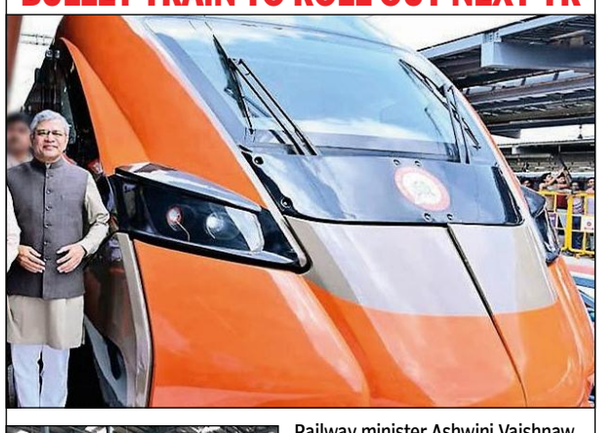
## Footage flags electrical fault for pool deaths

Two days after two guests were electrocuted at Conrad Hotel's swimming pool in Bengaluru, CCTV footage suggests suspected electrical fault may have originated near the entrance railings and steps, where LED lights are installed. German national Alexander Maximilian Theiss and Slovak national Juraj Horvat died in the pool accident. **P 3**

## Director inked over 'biased' Mahatma play

Former Mysuru Rangayana director Addanda Cariappa was ink-attacked during the staging of a play on Mahatma Gandhi in Bengaluru on Saturday night. Protesters identifying themselves with Congress alleged the play portrayed Gandhi in a negative light, depicting him as anti-national. They roughed up Cariappa and sprayed ink on his face, a complaint said. **P 3**

## B'LURU-MUM VB SLEEPER LAUNCHED; BULLET TRAIN TO ROLL OUT NEXT YR



Railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Sunday flagged off South India's first Vande Bharat Sleeper Express, connecting Bengaluru and Mumbai. The train will run six days a week, except Mondays from B'luru. It will depart from SMVT at 7.45pm & reach CSMT at 11.55am the next day. Commercial services will begin on Tuesday. (Left) The minister, who inspected BEML's Aditya plant, said the design of India's indigenous B-28 bullet train is ready and the first train will be rolled out in 2027 | **P 3**

# Over ₹960cr scam? 127 plots sold, then mortgaged to scam-hit bank

**Sandeep.Moudgal**
@timesofindia.com

**Bengaluru:** More than five years after Sri Guru Raghavendra Sahakara Bank Niyamitha in south Bengaluru went bust leaving hundreds of depositors in dire straits, fresh allegations of fraud have come to light, with properties already sold to unsuspecting buyers having been mortgaged with the bank.

In one case, the outstanding amount against the mortgaged property is Rs 961 crore even though the value of the collateral is not known.

According to officials, the bank does not have accurate information about the value of these properties, which are spread across the city and cover 45 to 50 acres. The farthest property mortgaged to the bank is in Chintamani, Kolar.

### Bidadi project: Govt issues final notification

State govt has issued the final land acquisition notification for 1,895 acres in Bidadi's Kanchugaranahalli and Byramangala for the proposed Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township, **reports Sanjay Murty**. The project has faced opposition from farmers, who have been protesting for over 18 months. **P 4**

Documents in possession of **TOI** show a Bangalore Development Authority-approved Sri Shankara Layout in Kambipura village, Kengeri hobli of Bengaluru, was mortgaged along with 127 plots that had already been sold to innocent individuals.

The layout has a registered residents' welfare association, whose members say they learnt of the mortgage only recently. On July 16, 2026, the layout owners' welfare association wrote a letter to the administrator of Sri Guru Raghavendra Sahakara Bank Niyamitha and said that between 2011 and 2015, there was an absolute sale deed executed by the developers of the layout with each of the 127 individuals.

The letter acknowledged as received by the bank administrator said two mortgage deeds registered and dated Oct 31, 2019, and two rectification deeds of Nov 28, 2019... along with residential plots formed on them in entirety, were shown as collateral security to your bank which was then represented by then chief adviser M Vasudev Maiya to obtain huge amounts of loans from the bank.

▶ **Notice to developers, P 4**

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# Lecture on the Rocks

## Now you can nerd out with a notepad in one hand and a martini in the other

Jahnavi.Sanjeev@timesofindia.com

Political and philosophical debates during the French Revolution often unfolded in taverns, cafés and pubs. Alcohol consumption was central to social life, and these establishments became spaces where ideas were exchanged and debated. In Bengaluru, where alcohol remains a familiar social lubricant, some bars and pubs are now serving a purpose beyond the weekend pub crawl.

In a country where education is often associated with academic requirements, grades and cut-offs, a growing number of people are exploring learning for its own sake. Events such as 'lectures over drinks' offer an anti-utilitarian approach to education — the kind of learning pursued simply for the joy of discovering something new.

### THIRD SPACES FOR A BUSY CITY

"For a city like Bengaluru, I think bars and parks are the only third spaces," say the co-founders of Pint of View, Shruti Sah and Harsh Snehanshu, who also founded Cubbon Reads. "The city works almost around the clock, and a huge part of people's remaining time is spent commuting between work and home. With the pressure of work and infrastructure that doesn't always give you enough time or space for yourself, communities like Pint of View can give you some time off from active participation."

Bengaluru is home to some of the country's leading institutions in science, the arts and public policy. But the founders of Pint of View believe there is a disconnect between these institutions and the wider public. "These institutions produce incredible work, but they can often feel quite gatekept. It can be difficult to simply walk into a lecture at an institution when you need an ID card or have to be affiliated with it," they say. Inspired by the US-based Lectures on Tap series — and tired of waiting for it to come to India — they decided to create their own version.

### LEARNING BEYOND THE ORDINARY

These are not the conventional classrooms where students once had to ask permission even to drink water during a lecture. Bars are strategic venues for such events: they are centrally located, close to where much of the working population spends time and convenient for those looking to unwind after work with a beer or a Cosmopolitan while learning about artificial intelligence, geopolitics, the human brain or almost any subject imaginable.

Ronit, an independent filmmaker who has attended lectures over drinks, says the events have helped him meet new people and build connections. "You can watch videos online about different topics that might interest or challenge you. But the offline experience is a whole lot better. You get to ask questions, the speakers respond, and that creates a kind of bond for the duration that you're in the room," he says.

Another attendee, Aditi, draws a distinction between these events and typical classroom lectures. "The speakers are also there because they want to be, not because a job compels them to. They know there'll be questions from people with diverse backgrounds, so they're ready for it," she says.

"At Brydge, we wanted to go beyond the ordinary events that happen," say Siya Pravin Sarnaik and Atharva Atul Rampure, the co-founders of Brydge, which started Intellect on Ice.

The duo were studying in the UK when they noticed people gathering around niche interests — from specific cuisines to books — something they felt was missing back home. Intellect on Ice began in Mumbai and has since expanded to Bengaluru, Delhi and Pune. "We felt offline experiences had the potential to be more enriching and that people needed to come together in a more meaningful way. We wanted to create a space to get your thoughts going," says Siya. The events do not follow a fixed format. The team decides which topics to explore, conducts research and then reaches out to people with the expertise and ideas to share. "It's not a very structured event, but that is the whole point. The experiential economy is booming, and it is in need of infrastructure," she says.

**TALK TO ME!** (Clockwise from top) Attendees at lectures of Pint of View, Intellect on Ice and a Contrarian Club debate

### A ROOM WHERE IDEAS CAN BREATHE

The Contrarian Debate Club, co-founded by school friends Sudarshan Senthil Kumar and Srinthan Hampi, has also taken intellectual pursuits to Bengaluru's bars and pubs, including Woodside Inn and Big Pitcher.

The founders wanted to recreate the old British aesthetic of institutions such as the Oxford Union Society. Sudarshan wanted to continue participating in debates after college, while Srinthan had been involved in debates and Model United Nations conferences throughout his life. Together, they wanted to create a space where people could express their thoughts freely and engage in meaningful discussion.

"One of the few rooms in Bengaluru where no one is going to scream at you," says Sudarshan. He believes good ideas often emerge only after several bad ones have been aired. "To arrive at a good idea, you must go through six or seven bad ones," he says. Participants are welcome to bring their ideas to the table, as long as they are willing to keep an open mind and listen to others.

The club was initially meant to be a gathering of seven or eight friends. But the venue needed a larger crowd for the event to be viable. When the founders invited people on social media at short notice, the idea took off, attracting more than 100 entries.

### FINDING THE RIGHT SCALE

For Intellect on Ice, one of the initial challenges was finding bars willing to allocate their entire space to a single organiser. Word of mouth, however, proved powerful. The first event, featuring a philosophy professor in a small Mumbai bar, took off immediately.

"Lectures on Tap was also very visible on social media around the same time, so it was the right place at the right time," says Siya. The organisers are taking different approaches to scale.

Pint of View plans to expand its lectures to audiences of between 100 and 300 people. It is also organising what it describes as Asia's first Lecture Festival, a two-day event at Jayamahal Palace Grounds on Dec 19 and 20, featuring a series of lectures and an expected audience of up to 5,000.

Intellect on Ice, on the other hand, plans to remain a more intimate gathering, with between 40 and 60 participants.

There is also a shift in the way bars and pubs position themselves, now branching out into more than just drinks. Shane Mannas, general manager, Big Pitcher Indiranagar, says that for them, it is about marketing, and people getting to know about the brand. "After such events, we also get repeat guests, who later come with their families and friends as well," says Shane. "To make profits, especially on a usually busy time for us like weekends, we put a cover charge per head, giving the attendees a coupon they can redeem on food and drinks." They hold a lot of other events as well, like kitty parties and corporate events.

The ticket prices for these experiences range from early bird tickets starting at Rs 599 that go live first, going up to Rs 1,299. The attendees are mostly people from 25 to 40 years of age, including academics, working professionals, VCs, founders, doctors, lawyers, engineers and CAs.

> We felt offline experiences had the potential to be more enriching
>
> **Siya Pravin Sarnaik,** CO-FOUNDER, BRYDGE AND INTELLECT ON ICE

> We wanted to be one of the few rooms in Bengaluru where no one is going to scream at you
>
> **Sudarshan Senthil Kumar,** CO-FOUNDER, CONTRARIAN DEBATE CLUB



> For a city like Bengaluru, I think bars and parks are the only third spaces
>
> **Shruti Sah,** CO-FOUNDER, PINT OF VIEW AND CUBBON READS

# A SWEET PIVOT ON MYSORE PAK

*How the classic Karnataka dessert is showing up in cheesecake, chocolates, cookies and date-and-nut bites — without losing its golden, ghee-rich soul*

Ileena Dutta & Milton Lawrence | TNN

In the royal kitchens of the Mysore Palace during the reign of the Wadiyar dynasty, it was Kakasura Madappa who created Mysore pak by mixing roasted gram flour (besan), boiling sugar syrup, and clarified butter in copious amounts for the first time. Now, this delicious sweet meat has become a cultural icon.

When autumn air turns brisk and the festival of lights draws near, sweet shops across the state prepare vast sheet trays of this golden confection. But something else is also cooking on the side. Just like how Dubai got its 'kunafa chocolate' in 2021 — when a chocolatier decided to craft a bar with a filling of pistachio cream, tahini and crunchy kataifi, the shredded pastry used in kunafa — the venerable 3-ingredient sweet is undergoing a vibrant, inventive culinary transformation. The classic buttery fudge is showing up as craft chocolate, baked cheesecakes, cookies and date portions.

### Pushing the traditions' limits

For legacy establishments, retaining Mysore pak's authenticity while catering to the modern urban consumer is an exciting creative frontier. Explaining his brand's pivot toward re-imagining Mysore pak two years ago, Sunay Bhasin, CEO of MTR Foods, notes that shifting consumer dynamics prompted the expansion: "There are a lot of people wanting to try out different kinds of sweets which they were not earlier either aware of or just couldn't access."

MTR has added a range of different Mysore pak varieties that Sunay prefers to call "inclusions" — milk Mysore pak, kesar badam Mysore pak, kaju Mysore pak, coffee Mysore pak, chilli Mysore pak, and a portion-controlled Mysore pak date bites.

At Sweet Karam Coffee, member concierge Rohit notes that while traditional bases remain sought-after, infused varieties spark regular customer inquiries: "We have mango Mysore pak, and paks based on cashew and filter coffee."

At sweet houses across the city, managers point to time-honoured mainstays. At A2B, the core festive lineup includes ghee Mysore pak, and kaju, badam and special paks.

Managers say requests for horlicks-flavoured and sugar-free Mysore paks surface occasionally, but demand during the festive rush is usually for the ghee rich, OG pak. Rather than turning to artificial sweeteners, customers seeking lighter options are actively gravitating toward jaggery-based preparations, says Sai Ganesh, a marketer at India Sweet House.

### Cheesecake & cookie infusions

Step inside Bengaluru's flourishing café culture, and the fusion turns even more daring. At White Teak Roastery in Yelahanka, owner Vasant has introduced Mysore pak into the café's pastry vitrine by pairing it with classic Western baked desserts. "Right now, we've begun with the Mysore pak cheesecake," Vasant says. "We are currently testing a Mysore pak French toast and a Mysore pak infused ice cream." The cheesecake marries creamy dairy tang with the nutty, roasted sweetness of gram flour and ghee.

The reinterpretation of the pak has also caught fire in Bengaluru's cloud kitchens. At Hazel Pâtisserie, co-founder Amrita has tackled Mysore pak from a textural angle by capturing the roasted aromas of gram flour and ghee inside a crumbly, crisp tea-time biscuit.

### Cocoa meets royal heritage

In Nagarabhavi, artisanal chocolate startup Modello Chocolates — a women-owned bean-to-bar venture founded by Annie — is paying homage to both Karnataka's agriculture and its confectionery legacy. Modello sources its cocoa beans directly from plantations in Hassan and makes small batches of chocolate bars. For their festive range, Modello developed the Mysore pak bar, bringing local ingredients into smooth harmony: "We make our own Mysore pak basically, and then we incorporate it into our milk chocolates."

SR Madhusudhan

**YES TO MAKEOVER:** Proprietor Shivakumar oversees Mysore pak preparation in the kitchen of Mahalakshmi Sweets in Mysuru; (left) Mysore pak cheesecake and cookies

### Meanwhile, in Mysuru...

Mysuru is ahead of its peers in the pak pivot. Mahalakshmi Sweets proprietor Shivakumar claims to have been among the first to introduce flavoured Mysuru pak, way back in 2000. The initial offerings included kaju, badam and milk flavours, he says. Today, the confectionery sells more than 2,000kg of mysuru pak daily through its 49 outlets across Karnataka, including in Bengaluru, Mysuru, Tumakuru, Shivamogga and Kodagu.

Among its 14 varieties, World of Mysore Pak in Mysuru has incorporated one based on kunafa chocolate, says store manager Rajesh. The store attracts an average of 2,500 customers daily. It also has an assorted half-kilo Mysore pak box, featuring 10 varieties.

At Guru Sweet Mart, proprietor Shivananda notes that flavoured Mysore pak requires more preparation time than the traditional version. The store sells 10 varieties of Mysore pak.

# 'Now kids want to know why they are learning something'

**You've lived and worked in several cities abroad. What did you miss most about Bengaluru—and what surprised you when you returned?**

■ What I missed most about Bengaluru varied depending on when and where I lived. When I was in London (1991–93), it was just about everything, starting with people and food! It took me a while to come to terms with the fact that I had chosen to leave India to learn more about the world, and myself.

While living in the desert sands of Dubai and Abu Dhabi, it was Bengaluru's greenery and weather that I missed most.

What surprised me most when I returned was how much Bengaluru had transformed. It had been my small, friendly city, where I couldn't move an inch without my parents somehow finding out where I was (this was pre-mobile era!). I returned to a larger, bustling IT city that was home to people from across India, and increasingly, expats.

As much as I loved Bengaluru's new energy and diversity, I was disheartened to see a city racing ahead in growth while falling behind in livability — its lakes and greenery giving way to concrete and glass structures, and its public infra struggling to keep pace.

**You represented Karnataka in cricket and basketball...**

■ My sporting journey began on the fields of Clarence High School—one on campus, the other 2–3 km away on Assaye Road. Getting to the latter was an adventure in itself! We walked or cycled, crossed railway tracks on foot, and then cleaned the field before marking it for Sports Day. Can't imagine middle- or upper-middle-class school kids being required by the school to do that today—would probably make for a viral post or two on social media! It was on those fields that I discovered my potential as a sportsperson.

I had just joined Clarence and very quickly found myself selected as the school hockey goalkeeper. All of 11 years old (and pretty short then!), I was keeping goal for the senior school team, with cricket pads, fast reflexes and lots of courage (or was that stupidity?!) as my armour. And then, of course, came Mount Carmel (which I absolutely loved for the sports and leadership opportunities), KSCA, IISc, Kanteerava, MICO, and the courts at Malleswaram and Jayanagar.

**Where do you go when you want an unhurried afternoon in the city?**

■ Nandi Hills! It was my favourite getaway growing up. I cycled there as a pre-teen and graduated to a motorcycle as a teenager (err, yes, I may have been underage!). And it remains a favourite to this day.

**Which Bengaluru dish would you happily cross the city for?**

■ Mom's Kutchi Biryani — by far the best in the world! (And anyone who has tasted it will vouch for that!) No restaurant in Bengaluru comes close. And I do cross from the Republic of Whitefield to head to my parents' home in Fraser Town regularly for it!

**From Gen Z to Gen Alpha, how different are Bengaluru's children?**

■ Children increasingly want to know why they're learning something. What's the relevance? Why memorise what they can look up in seconds? There's a greater appetite for hands-on, experiential and project-based learning, and for exploring interests beyond academics, particularly the arts. They're also spending far more time online—learning, creating, connecting and, yes, playing video games!

At the same time, they're increasingly competitive, with getting into a great college seen as the pathway to success. Their lives are packed with tuitions, activity classes and organised schedules, leaving little time for spontaneous play and informal learning.

What worries me is that children have fewer opportunities to navigate friendships, disagreements and failures without adult intervention. That's where so much social-emotional learning happens! I also worry that children play far less sport. Of course, neither generation is homogeneous. These shifts also reflect the environments we, as parents, educators and society, have created.

**Do you have a message on early learning for young parents?**

■ Let your children be children!

Give them the freedom to explore, experiment and mess up sometimes, with a safety net and sensible guardrails, rather than trying to protect them from every disappointment or difficulty. Children need love, trust and guidance, but also the space to figure things out for themselves. We can't live their lives for them, nor should we try to.

**BEST OF OORU**

**NOORAINE FAZAL**

is founder, CEO and managing trustee of Inventure Academy, established in 2005, with two Bengaluru campuses, a third on the way, and four govt schools run through public–private partnerships. An educationist, entrepreneur and former Karnataka women's cricket and basketball player, she holds an MS in Management from Boston University

STREET VIEW

# *Nagarathpet: Where city's trading heart meets its midnight appetite*

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Bengaluru's street food scene offers something for everyone. While Thindi Beedi in VV Puram is a delight, serving everything from chats and dosas to North Indian favourites, areas such as Shivajinagar, Mosque Road and the Burma Bazaar stretch in Frazer Town are magnets for meat lovers, known for their Mughlai dishes, kebabs and rolls.

Gandhi Bazaar continues to draw crowds with its traditional snacks and sweets, while pockets around Avenue Road and Chickpet cater to shoppers looking for a quick bite. Spread across different neighbourhoods, these food streets reflect the city's diversity, blending old culinary traditions with new tastes and making food an integral part of Bengaluru's cultural identity. Yet any discussion on Bengaluru's street-food culture would be incomplete without a visit to Nagarathpet, one of the city's oldest and most enduring culinary hotspots.

Nagarathpet, as its name suggests, is a busy market area, where both traders and shoppers compete with each other for space on the narrow lanes and footpaths. So, a street food business in such an area may sound improbable. But, here, the eating begins after almost all the shops close for the night.

While the shops sell their textiles, gold and silver in the day, food carts and eateries take over Nagarathpet once the shutters are down. That is when you will see several carts dishing out masala dosa, podi dosa, bath masala dosa and soft idlis well past midnight.

**A MELTING POT**

**While the shops sell their textiles, gold and silver in the day, food carts and eateries take over Nagarathpet once the shutters are down**

While potato filling is common, many food enthusiasts credit Nagarathpet with popularising bath masala dosa, where lemon rice is also folded inside a dosa. This dosa has a fan following of its own.

Some say Nagarathpet is also associated with Khali dosa, a soft spongy variant that predates many of its modern iterations.

Bengaluru has been a trading hub since its founding years. It has attracted traders from across the country and many of them now call the city home. As they came here, they also brought their food culture. So, in Nagarathpet, you can also enjoy some fafda, jalebi, kachori and kadhi kachori.

Many who take a food walk through Nagarathpet prefer to end it with a glass of hot badam milk sold along the lanes.

Walking through Nagarathpet is as much a journey into old Bengaluru as it is an exploration of its food culture. The eateries are spread across centuries-old trading lanes, wholesale markets and heritage structures. One of them is the Annapoornamba temple, which has become a landmark amid the bustling crowds and food carts.

Between gulps and sips, you can also take a stroll in the Chickpet market, famous for its textiles and sarees. Nagarathpet is not merely a food street. It is where Bengaluru's centuries-old trading heart meets its enduring appetite, creating a culinary corridor where shoppers, traders and food lovers have shared the same narrow lanes for generations.

# Yellow, red & pride mark Rajyotsava

## NAMMA OORU 2k Students Showcase State's History, Heritage & Cultural Icons At Kanteerava

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Pics: Muthu P

**COLOURS OF KARNATAKA:** The 71st Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations at Kanteerava Stadium in the city Sunday proved to be a spectacular showcase of the state's vibrant cultural legacy

**Bengaluru:** Love and pride for Kannada and Karnataka defined the mood at Kanteerava Stadium Sunday. Dominated by the red and yellow colours of the Kannada flag, the venue hosted hundreds of students, teachers and education officials as Karnataka marked its 71st Rajyotsava.

The event, organised by the department of school education and literacy, drew a large crowd, with students forming its backbone. Kannada echoed across the stadium, from the speeches and announcements to the songs and cultural programmes that followed. The proceedings began with chief minister DK Shivakumar hoisting the national flag and the Karnataka flag with the rendition of 'Jaya Bharata Jananiya Tanujate,' 'Vande Mataram' and the national anthem. Students joined in enthusiastically, while march-past contingents and school bands paid tribute to both the national flag and the Kannada flag.

The celebration then moved to a visual showcase of Karnataka's history and cultural legacy. Students dressed up as literary icons, saints and other prominent figures associated with Karnataka's rich tradition, while cultural tableaux highlighted the state's heritage.

One of the major attractions was a large-scale dance performance featuring hundreds of students. Through music, costumes and choreography, the performance showcased Karnataka's diverse culture, traditions and landmarks. Another segment shifted the focus to education, using song and dance to highlight govt initiatives, including free textbooks, uniforms, midday meals and efforts to promote sports and develop skills among students. Loud cheers and applause were a sign of how the performance took the audience to the rich culture of Karnataka. Around 2,000 students danced in the two performances. In his speech, the CM urged students not only to learn Kannada but also to use it in their everyday lives.

> It's up to children and the younger generation to preserve the language & culture. Karnataka's culture can flourish only when Kannada continues to be spoken, practised & celebrated beyond formal occasions
> **DK Shivakumar** | CM

### 71 honoured with Rajyotsava Awards

Karnataka govt Sunday conferred the prestigious Rajyotsava Awards on 71 achievers from various fields, including literature, education, agriculture, sports, healthcare, public service, art and culture. Chief minister DK Shivakumar presented the awards at a ceremony held at Ravindra Kalakshetra in Bengaluru, as part of the state's 71st Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations.

## Govt tried to get official status for flag in 2018

▶ Continued from page 1

This is not the first time the Congress govt has attempted to secure official status for the Kannada flag. In 2018, the Siddaramaiah-led govt proposed a redesigned state flag and sought recognition for it. Asked whether govt would consider the new design, Shivakumar said, "The flag we are proposing is the plain yellow-and-red that is widely used across Karnataka."

Shivakumar said govt was considering making the hoisting of Kannada flag mandatory at govt offices and institutions receiving govt support. The announcement comes amid renewed discussions on Kannada identity and language promotion.

A long-pending demand for extending grant-in-aid benefits to Kannada-medium aided schools established after 1995 found mention on the day. The CM said govt would soon call representatives of Kannada-aided schools and discuss the matter with the finance department on grants.

## 2 abscond as police widen video probe

▶ Continued from page 1

Notices have been issued to both Sharma, a Delhi resident, and Prajwal, who is from Bengaluru. However, neither has appeared before the investigating officer and both are absconding. Police said they had also approached legal channels seeking anticipatory bail.

Sharma and Ritesh were instructed by Prajwal to purchase a device using

**STING OPERATION**

Aadhaar credentials in Delhi's Karol Bagh area. The phone was subsequently handed over to Prajwal, Singh said. The questioning of Prajwal is expected to provide further leads.

Investigators are also examining suspicious financial transactions between Prajwal and Ritesh, the duration of the trio's stay, and their alleged collaboration.

Ritesh was arrested in Delhi on Oct 24 for his alleged role in procuring the phone. After being questioned over several days, he left Bengaluru with the investigating officer's permission, a senior officer said. While his initial statements have been recorded, police are verifying details of the purchase in Karol Bagh and are awaiting further interrogation reports.

The investigation is being supervised by deputy commissioner of police (crime-2) Raja Imam Kasim P. On Oct 29, police had said the evidence gathered so far indicated that the allegations of sexual abuse portrayed in the video were part of a "fabricated and deliberately constructed narrative".

Statements recorded and evidence collected during the investigation had not substantiated the occurrence of any incident as depicted in the video, police said. Significantly, the video was allegedly recorded in 2023 and purportedly related to an incident dating to 2011.

Police are investigating why it was recorded 12 years after the alleged incident.

They are also examining how and why it was circulated on the internet in Sept-Oct 2026, the identities and roles of those involved, and their possible motives.

Police have closed the entrance from Ali Asgar Road and deployed additional manpower at the city police commissioner's office. The main entrance on Infantry Road also has additional police deployment. Officials said the move was to prevent any protests and any persons trying to enter the office. "Late Saturday night, a group of people had come to protest at the commissioner's office in connection with a case involving former Rangayana director Addanda Cariappa. We don't want such incidents to recur," an official said.

# Apartment residents bring folk traditions alive

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Pics: TOI

After the flag-hoisting ceremony and a Karnataka-cuisine lunch, a grand procession wound its way through Adarsh Palm Retreat complex

**Bengaluru:** Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations at Adarsh Palm Retreat (APR) in Bellandur went beyond the customary flag-hoisting ceremony this year, as residents transformed the apartment complex into a showcase of the state's folk heritage.

Organised by the APR Kannada Sangha, the event brought together more than 100 folk artists from Ramanagara, Dakshina Kannada, Udupi, Vijayapura, Mandya, Chikkamagaluru and Haveri districts. The day began with the traditional flag-hoisting ceremony and a Karnataka-cuisine lunch before a colourful procession wound through the apartment complex.

Towering Chilipili Gombe puppets, Mangaluru's Hulivesha dancers, Sattige Kunitha and Puravanthike performances offered residents a glimpse of the state's diverse cultural traditions. A special attraction was an all-women Mahila Veeragase troupe from Chikkamagaluru, challenging traditional gender barriers in the Shaivite warrior dance form. "We wanted to create an authentic festival atmosphere for the entire neighbourhood," said Bhagath Reddy, trustee of APR Kannada Sangha.

Organisers said the event was also aimed at introducing children and young residents to art forms that are increasingly struggling to survive. "Many of these folk forms carry centuries of oral history, preserved against modern economic odds. Giving rural practitioners a platform right in our neighbourhood enriched our celebrations and instilled cultural pride in our younger generation," said Chetana Prasad, trustee of APR Kannada Sangha.

The event was coordinated by resident volunteers Srinivas, Arun, Deeksha, Suhas, Smitha, Dr Aravind, Beena, Arun H, Girish, Shaila, Mohan, Gowri, Mahesh, Rashmi, Shweta, Hemanth, Navina, Chaya, Sandeep Reddy, Sampada, Vijay Raghavendran and Ravi S. The participating artists received support through Janapada Siri, a CSR initiative backed by Benaka and Tekion. "Indigenous folk traditions require sustained backing to remain viable, and this initiative provided a direct way to support rural artists and preserve their crafts," said Aravind Gowda, senior director of communications at Tekion.

## Gandhi play row: Ink smeared on ex-Rangayana director

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Bengaluru:** A theatrical performance titled 'The Truth Behind Freedom Fighter Mahatma Gandhi's Assassination' sparked a controversy at Suchitra Cinema and Cultural Academy in Banashankari after former Mysuru Rangayana director Addanda Cariappa allegedly had ink smeared on him **(in pic)** during a confrontation with Congress workers. Two complaints have been filed at Banashankari police station.

Organised by Kodagu Rangabhoomi Trust and directed by Cariappa, the play came under fire from Congress workers and members of various organisations over alleged objectionable remarks about Mahatma Gandhi.

In a complaint, a Congress worker alleged the play spread misinformation about Gandhi's assassination and portrayed him as anti-national. The protesters also accused Cariappa of blaming Gandhi and Congress for the Partition of India.

Protesters entered the academy and confronted the organisers. A heated exchange followed, during which Cariappa was allegedly manhandled. The complainants sought action against Cariappa and the performers. In his counter-complaint, Cariappa alleged the protesters had disrupted the performance, assaulted him and threatened to kill him. He maintained that the play was based on references from books.

At 10pm, around 15 Congress workers attempted to enter the police commissioner's office on Infantry Road.

## CCTV suggests fault near pool entrance

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Bengaluru:** CCTV footage examined by Halasuru police investigating the death of two foreign nationals at Conrad hotel's swimming pool suggests that the suspected electrical fault may have originated near the entrance railings and steps, where LED lights are installed.

**CONRAD TRAGEDY**

The footage offers a sequence of events leading up to the Oct 30 incident, in which German national Alexander Maximilian Theiss, 57, a Lufthansa crew member, and Slovak national Juraj Horvat, 45, a project manager with IBM, died of electrocution. Police suspect that power from the lighting system or its wiring may have leaked into the pool. **TOI** had reported Sunday under the headline, "Bigger tragedy averted? Current confined to 5m radius, probe finds."

A senior officer said he inspected the spot and examined the CCTV footage, which shows Theiss jumping into the pool from the opposite side and swimming towards the entrance. After covering about half the distance, he stopped briefly and then continued swimming. Horvat, meanwhile, collapsed in the water shortly after entering the pool, between 5.10pm and 5.15pm.

The two others injured were American tourist Mathew Desantis, 41, and hotel employee Rahul Tiwari, 28. According to the officer, Desantis, who was already in the pool, felt an electric current while swimming but managed to get out and alert hotel staff. Tiwari, who rushed to rescue the two men, also suffered an electric shock and is undergoing treatment. Desantis has since been discharged.

Electrical inspectors, Bescom officials and police visited the pool Saturday.

**Hotel staff get summons**

Police have begun compiling a list of hotel employees who were on duty on Oct 30. They have collected details of staff responsible for electrical maintenance, pool operations and other related work, and issued summons to some of them. "Based on the CCTV footage, there is no foul play in the deaths of the two men," the officer said. The body of Theiss was handed over to the German consulate general after autopsy Sunday.

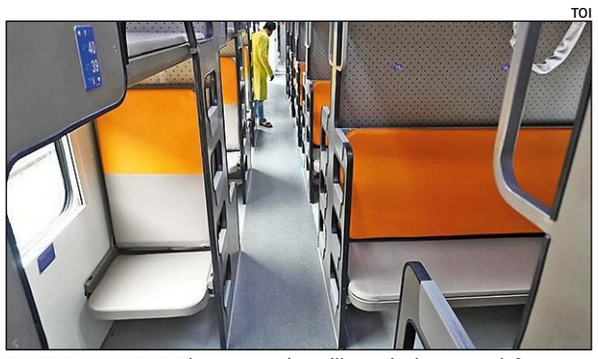
### Swimming assn to issue safety guidelines

**Bengaluru:** Following the death of two men at Conrad hotel, Karnataka Swimming Association plans to issue a comprehensive safety advisory to swimming clubs, educational institutions, hotels and pool operators.

The association intends to cover electrical safety, proper earthing, periodic inspection of electrical installations, underwater lighting, filtration and pumping systems, availability of trained lifeguards, and emergency response arrangements. It will also emphasise first-aid facilities, including CPR, regular safety audits, and proper maintenance records. KSA president and former IGP Gopal Hosur said the association was keen to work with govt to strengthen the implementation of safety norms. "Safety cannot be treated as a one-time certification. It has to be a continuous process." TNN

# Wait's over! VB sleeper train to begin Bengaluru-Mumbai service tomorrow

TOI



**FASTER CONNECT:** The new service will run six days a week from Bengaluru and is expected to cover the distance to Mumbai in 16 hours

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**Bengaluru:** Ending a long wait, Union railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw Sunday flagged off the SMVT Bengaluru-Mumbai Vande Bharat sleeper express. It is South India's first sleeper variant of Vande Bharat.

For years, passengers travelling between India's tech and financial capitals had only the Udyan Express. The new service is expected to bridge this connectivity gap, covering the distance in around 16 hours.

The train will depart Bengaluru at 7.45pm six days a week, except Mondays, and reach Mumbai at 11.55am the next day. It will have eight stops: Anantapur, Guntakal, Raichur, Yadgir, Kalaburagi, Solapur, Pune and Kalyan.

Ticket fares from Bengaluru are Rs 4,450 for AC first class, Rs 3,630 for AC 2-tier and Rs 2,810 for AC 3-tier. The 16-coach train has a total capacity of 823 berths.

The train undertook a special inaugural run Sunday morning. Commercial services will begin Tuesday. Gopal Khandre, a rail enthusiast who travelled from Mumbai for the inaugural journey, said the sub-16-hour connectivity would address a longstanding gap and expressed hope for more such services. Another passenger, Chinmay Kole, said the train's faster schedule and convenient timings could also benefit passengers travelling between Pune and Bengaluru.

**India eyeing exports: Min**

Addressing the media ahead of the flag-off, railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw called the launch a proud moment for Karnataka on its foundation day. He said the train had been designed with improvements for both loco pilots and passengers.

Vaishnaw added that India plans to export complete Vande Bharat trains in the next 3-4 years, having already begun exporting propulsion systems to Switzerland, Germany, France, Italy and the US. A future Vande Bharat sleeper service from Bengaluru will connect northern Karnataka via Hubballi to Pune and Mumbai, he said. Bangalore South MP Tejasvi Surya demanded a high-speed rail corridor between Bengaluru and Pune.

### Make in B'luru: Bullet train design done, may hit tracks by May 2027

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

TOI

Construction of the first section of the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail corridor to be over in 2 months

**Bengaluru:** Amid the country's ambitious high-speed rail push, railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw Sunday said India's indigenous bullet train B-28's design has been completed. Following an inspection at the Aditya plant in Bharat Earth Movers Ltd's Tippasandra facility, the first train will be rolled out in 2027.

The progress has been positive, Vaishnaw told **TOI,** adding that the indigenous design has already completed a squeeze test. "When the train moves at very high speed, a layer of vacuum is created around it. The entire atmospheric pressure comes onto the coach. That's why the squeeze test is important, and it has now been completed," he said.

After the squeeze test, B-28 will be integrated with interior furniture. Vaishnaw said the train will be exposed to various climatic conditions. He said a dedicated track has been created in BEML's Bengaluru facility to test the bullet train.

"It will be first tested on that track, then it will be taken to Surat depot where there are slightly longer tracks for other tests," he added.

Vaishnaw said the construction of the first section of the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail corridor between Surat and Bilimora, targeted for launch by Aug 15, 2027, will be completed within the next two months.

"This train will go onto the track somewhere around April or May next year. The construction is going on at a very good pace, both towards Ahmedabad and Mumbai," he further said.

# *250 volunteers mark Rajyotsava with green drive at neighbourhood parks*

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

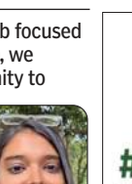
**Bengaluru:** Kannada Rajyotsava was marked with a green initiative Sunday, as citizens and students came together for Bengaluru's neighbourhood parks under **The Times of India**'s #IamBengaluru – Volunteer for Parks, presented by Multigen, in association with Adamaya Chethana, Indian Ploggers Army and Team Social Spotlight (Planeteers Foundation).

Around 250 volunteers, including students from Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences' road track team, Jyothi Institute of Technology and JSS, took part in the drive. At 10th Block Central Park in Banashankari, Adamaya Chethana volunteers carried out weed clearance, plantation and sapling care between 9am and 11.30am.

Meanwhile, many other volunteers took up sapling care at Kasturinagar lake. At MES Jayanagar playground, volunteers led a plogging drive and a waste management session encouraging a clean environment. Tejaswini Ananth Kumar, co-founder, Adamaya Chethana, said: "We are standing on the border of Bengaluru's growth and the Bannerghatta forest. Development is about nurturing nature by improving green cover, not generating waste, and working towards net zero carbon. And doing that while celebrating Karnataka Rajyotsava makes it more meaningful." Citizens can register for volunteering on iambengaluru.co.in.

> This is an initiative to encourage students to engage with society. I want them to interact with the community, understand its needs and contribute through such social activities as part of their service to society
> **Jayatirtha M Patil** | NSS COORDINATOR, JYOTHI INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY

> It's very nice to see many college students showing up. For most of them, it was their first time, and they left feeling proud, carrying a good message with them. Having been in the volunteering field for the past two years, this makes me very happy
> **Charan Teja** | VOLUNTEERING COORDINATOR, TSS



> Restoring the lake, a 200-year-old waterbody, through initiatives like this is very much needed because it lies in the heart of Bengaluru
> **K Ramanatha Rao** | MEMBER, KASTURINAGAR WELFARE ASSOCIATION

> This initiative inspires citizens to take responsibility for keeping our surroundings clean. I'm proud to be part of this movement, contributing through small actions towards a cleaner, greener, and healthier Bengaluru
> **Sudarshan** | STUDENT VOLUNTEER

> As a student-led club focused on youth leadership, we believe this is an opportunity to contribute to society beyond our roles as students and develop a sense of social responsibility. We encourage more people to register and be part of such initiatives. This one is special as it is part of the 71st Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations
> **Harrshita Vibha R** | PRESIDENT, ROTARACT RAMAIAH UNIVERSITY OF APPLIED SCIENCES

MULTIGEN
CRAFTED FOR GENERATIONS
presents
#IamBengaluru
VOLUNTEER FOR PARKS
An initiative by
THE TIMES OF INDIA

ANI

**WARM WELCOME:** CM DK Shivakumar with Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat at his residence in Bengaluru Sunday

## Cases against pro-Kannada activists to be withdrawn: CM

**Bengaluru:** The govt is preparing to withdraw cases registered against pro-Kannada activists, chief minister DK Shivakumar said.

During Kannada Rajyotsava celebrations Sunday, Shivakumar said officials had cautioned him against withdrawing these cases, pointing out that several of the activists were habitual offenders.

"I decided to go ahead and withdraw cases, but I urge activists not to take law into their hands and add to a growing list of cases," he said.

He urged pro-Kannada activists to refrain from vandalism, especially targeting IT companies, to make their demands heard. "Rather than any individual or organisation, let the govt take action," he said. "Also, no moral policing. If you have an issue, bring it to the notice of police. I assure you this govt is a pro-Kannada govt. We will not ignore issues that concern language," he said.

On Maharashtra Ekikarna Samiti (MES) allegedly violating laws in Belagavi, the CM said it is "unacceptable".

"The law is the same, be it for a Marathi or Kannada speaking person," he said. He said everyone residing in Karnataka should respect the state's culture and its Kannada-speaking population.

His outreach to pro-Kannada activists comes days after he responded to social media posts by warning IT companies against discriminating against Kannada-speaking candidates during recruitment. He also sought a Rajyotsava award for activist Vatal Nagaraj, citing his contribution to protecting the language. However, Nagaraj declined the award. TNN

# To counter MLC setback, Congress mulls early local body elections

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**Bengaluru:** Congress is exploring early panchayat and Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) elections to counter the clean sweep by BJP and JD(S) in the legislative council elections.

Sources say party brass is considering holding polls later this year or early next year to demonstrate its organisational strength. The calculation is simple. A win in rural polls could blunt the opposition's claim of rising strength, while a poor showing would hand rivals fresh ammunition. Victory could also rebuild confidence among functionaries and supporters ahead of the 2028 assembly polls.

This week's defeat does not threaten the govt's majority in the council, but it has raised pointed questions on campaign planning and voter mobilisation, especially since 19 ministers were deployed to campaign.

CM DK Shivakumar and Congress state president BK Hariprasad must now align the govt with party organisation. The polls were their first major electoral test since Siddaramaiah was eased out as CM.

**STUNNING WIN:** AP Ranganath, who defeated Congress' Puttanna in Bengaluru Teachers' constituency, was feted by JD(S) MLA CB Suresh Babu and MLC TA Sharavana at Vidhana Soudha last week

"This defeat calls for a review of grassroots network and of coordination between ministers and local functionaries," said a senior Congress functionary. "Being in govt does not bring votes unless party organisation is active on the ground."

Bengaluru Teachers' constituency result adds another dimension. Congress candidate Puttanna, who had won four consecutive elections, lost to JD(S) candidate AP Ranganath by 908 votes. The seat has a sizeable Vokkaliga and Dalit electorate, communities Congress wants to retain, and with Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga, now CM, the loss hurt its efforts to consolidate its social coalition.

### Massive challenge

Congress must also explain why it failed in seats where it felt secure. Meanwhile, BJP and JD(S) avoided contests against each other in all four seats, consolidating their respective support bases and maximising the alliance's advantage. If BJP and JD(S) carry this understanding into local body polls, Congress will have a massive challenge on its hands.

"Candidate selection, local equations and transfer of votes between alliance partners would have influenced the outcome," said Vishwas Shetty, a political analyst. "Going forward, Congress has a serious challenge. While the party is confident of taluk and zilla panchayat polls, GBA elections could be tougher given support for BJP in urban centres."

Hariprasad faces scrutiny too. His detractors have repeatedly questioned his electoral record, pointing out that he has never won a direct election. The results will intensify demands that the organisation show it can mobilise voters and deliver gains.

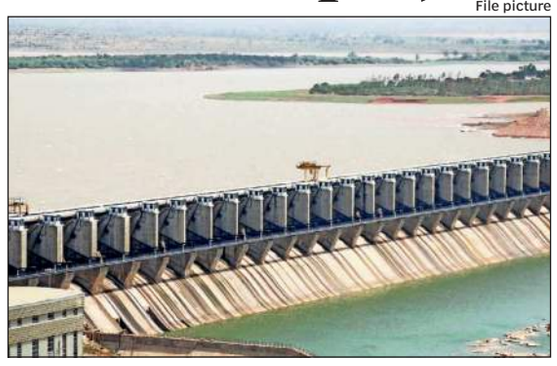
"Congress cannot treat local body polls merely as a chance to change the narrative," said analyst MN Patil. "Early elections would test whether ministers, legislators and district functionaries can work together and whether the party has corrected shortcomings exposed by the MLC defeat. Hariprasad may have to focus more on results than rhetoric now."

### Influence of ex-CM

Siddaramaiah remains influential among Ahinda voters, comprising minorities, backward classes and Dalits, but the party must convert that support into votes. The controversy over the alleged sting operation involving the former CM adds to the party's challenges and must not distract it from governance and party work.

# Min Patil objects to Maha's Krishna diversion project

File picture


**MUDDY WATER:** Minister MB Patil said Maharashtra's project will hit inflow into Almatti dam and hurt other riparian states

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Vijayapura:** Industries minister MB Patil has objected to Maharashtra's proposal to divert 40 tmc feet of floodwater from Krishna river to Bhima river in Maharashtra, saying the project would "seriously harm" Karnataka's interests.

Patil told reporters Sunday that Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis recently announced that his govt intended to pursue the project. He said the proposed diversion could alter water flows in Krishna upper sub-basin and potentially affect the volume of water flowing into Almatti reservoir. He warned that this could adversely affect not only Karnataka but also the availability of water for other riparian states.

**Patil said Centre must clarify how Maharashtra is proceeding with the project since it violates the Krishna river water dispute tribunal award**

"Union govt should clarify the legal basis on which Maharashtra had proceeded with the project since it does not fall within the scope of Krishna Water Disputes Tribunal-II (KWDT-II) award and explain how it had secured financial assistance from the World Bank," Patil said.

Playing a video clip of Fadnavis purportedly speaking in Mumbai last month, Patil said an all-party meeting chaired by chief minister DK Shivakumar would soon be convened to discuss the issue. "Information available shows Maharashtra govt sanctioned Rs 24 crore in July 2026 to prepare a detailed project report (DPR)," he said. "It is also preparing to conduct geological surveys along an 84 km route. The DPR is expected to be ready by the end of 2026, and the estimated project cost is around Rs 19,000 crore."

Patil said the Krishna water dispute tribunal had allocated an additional 448 tmc feet of water based on 65% dependability and average availability, over and above the 2,130 tmc feet available at 75% dependability. Of this additional allocation, Maharashtra received 81 tmc feet, Karnataka 173 tmc feet, and undivided Andhra Pradesh 194 tmc feet, Patil said.

He said that the tribunal's objections to the earlier proposal have raised questions about why Maharashtra is now pursuing another project to transfer water from the same basin to a different destination. He also questioned how Maharashtra received World Bank funding for the project when the central govt had repeatedly returned Karnataka's DPR for Upper Krishna Project Stage III, citing the absence of official gazette notification of the KWDT-II award. He called for appropriate measures to ensure Karnataka's interests were not adversely affected.

# ARAI facility: Land cleared, only cabinet nod awaited

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Mandya:** State govt has cleared 100 acres of land in the first phase to establish an Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI) facility in Mandya, and the proposal has been forwarded to the revenue department secretary for further action, district minister N Cheluvarayaswamy said.

He told reporters Sunday the district administration had completed all requirements for the project and that the land would formally be transferred after cabinet approval. He said the govt will acquire more land if needed.

Responding to claims by Union minister and Mandya MP HD Kumaraswamy, who in a letter to the chief secretary had questioned the state's commitment to the project, Cheluvarayaswamy said authorities had acted promptly on the proposal and there was evidence to support its position.

**AT ODDS:** N Cheluvarayaswamy & HD Kumaraswamy

Cheluvarayaswamy instead questioned Kumaraswamy's contribution to the district, while highlighting Congress govt initiatives such as a Kendriya Vidyalaya, a medical college, and agricultural and veterinary colleges besides others.

### Patil blasts HDK's Honda remarks

Refuting Union minister HD Kumaraswamy's claim that automobile major Honda was planning to exit Karnataka, industries minister MB Patil Sunday called the statement "baseless" and "politically motivated".

"Honda was allotted 135 acres of land in phases at Narsapur in Kolar since 2011. It has been manufacturing two-wheelers there since 2013 and currently provides employment to more than 7,800 people," said Patil. He said Honda also operates a 35-acre spare parts warehousing facility in Doddaballapur. "There have been no lapses on the part of govt in its dealings with Honda, nor has the firm expressed any dissatisfaction. It is inappropriate for Kumaraswamy, who is from Karnataka, to make such remarks," Patil said.

# Prior approval must to interrogate staff

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Bengaluru:** In relief for officials and staff of the department of stamps and registration, the police department has directed officers not to summon them for preliminary inquiries into alleged property fraud and document forgery without following prescribed procedure.

**REGISTRATION DEPT**

In a circular, DG&IGP MA Saleem said police must obtain necessary approvals from sanctioning authorities before issuing notices. The directive follows complaints that officials were being harassed.

In property fraud cases, victims or registration department officials lodge complaints alleging land grabbers or fraudsters used forged documents to register properties at sub-registrar offices. Police were reportedly summoning registration officials during preliminary inquiries to verify the authenticity of these documents and examine registration procedures.

The circular states that when an FIR is registered based on complaints by aggrieved persons, registration staff should be treated as witnesses. Their statements should be recorded at a place of their choice, as per prescribed legal procedure.

The directive follows a complaint by a delegation led by BH Shankaregowda, president, Karnataka State Registration and Stamps Department Employees' Association. Saleem directed all station house officers and investigating officers to follow the guidelines. The move is aimed at avoiding unnecessary complications during investigations into property fraud cases.

## Two B'lureans die, one missing at Gokarna

Two employees of a Bengaluru-based company died, and another remained missing after five colleagues were swept away by strong waves at Dubbansashi Beach in Gokarna Sunday morning. Two others were rescued.

The five had arrived in Gokarna Saturday evening. They went to the sea for a swim the following morning. Local fishermen and lifeguards noticed them and launched a rescue operation. The deceased are Shobha Das, 22, and Mohammed Akram. The injured are Nishanth DV, 26, and Mohammed Qasim. Search operations are under way for Vishwa AK, 24. TNN

## Employee steals ₹40L over 4 yrs to fund online betting

**Bengaluru**: A housekeeping employee of Shree Sai Darshanam Trust allegedly stole nearly Rs 40 lakh from a trustee's locker over five years before the theft came to light during the Dasara holidays.

The accused, **Shrinivas S Nadagoud**, 36, had worked at the trust for 16 years and had access to the locker belonging to trustee Yashodha. According to a complaint filed by trustee KN Sharath Babu, 45, Yashodha discovered the cash missing after returning from a holiday with her family. When questioned on Oct 29, Shrinivas initially denied the theft. However, Yashodha and her son found the locker key in his purse, following which he confessed. TNN

# 114 boxes of surgical threads & 7m cut: Girl critical but stable

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**Bengaluru**: A 14-year-old girl endured multiple cuts, including a 7m-long one, and hours of pain after her cousin allegedly attacked her with a chainsaw inside her classroom at a zilla parishad high school in Raptadu village, Andhra Pradesh.

She has now been shifted to Manipal Hospital in Bengaluru, where doctors have taken her for surgery. They've used 114 boxes of surgical thread to treat her so far. Addressing the media after his visit, minister for Education and IT, Nara Lokesh, said she is stable as of Sunday evening but the next 48 hours are critical. Lokesh said when she was being moved out of the school after the attack, a staff member asked her to be strong, and she responded with a thumbs-up. "Her will power to recover is very courageous." In all, she has been through almost 20 hours of surgery: eight hours at Anantapur, and 12 hours in Bengaluru.

Lokesh said the doctors were unable to count the cuts as many are so close that they touch each other in a few places, while others lie on top of one another. "In all, 114 boxes of surgical thread were used."

The move to Bengaluru was made possible by quick action from Karnataka govt."I especially thank the Karnataka govt. They supported us in taking her to Manipal Hospital through green corridor," he said.

Another girl, who tried to stop the attacker, was also injured. She has suffered a hairline fracture and will undergo surgery Sunday in Anantapur. Lokesh said the accused had entered the school under the guise of a construction worker, adding the govt would take strict action.

### Teen on ventilator support: Hospital

**Bengaluru:** The 14-year-old girl Radhika (name changed), with severe injuries to her face and upper body, had suffered significant blood loss and circulatory shock. She required resuscitation, multiple blood transfusions and ventilator support during the transfer, said Manipal Hospital.

"On arrival, she was critically unstable, with ongoing facial bleeding, and was immediately shifted to the operating room," the statement said. The surgery took 11 hours.

She has now been shifted to the PICU, where she continues to receive ventilator support.

The hospital said Radhika remains critically ill and may require further surgical interventions. TNN

TOI

Andhra minister Nara Lokesh visited the family in Bengaluru

# Bidadi township: Land acquisition notification issued for 1,895 acres

Sanjay.Murty@timesofindia.com

**Bengaluru:** The state govt has issued the final land acquisition notification for 1,895 acres in Kanchugaranahalli and Byramangala villages of Bidadi hobli in Ramanagara taluk for the proposed Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township.

Greater Bengaluru Development Authority (GBDA) plans to develop the township under the work-live-play model. The Oct 30 notification identifies 3,271 landowners whose compensation will be determined under the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013. The landowners can also opt for developed sites in lieu of monetary compensation.

File pic

The township project has faced stiff opposition from farmers

According to the notification, the project has been exempted from rehabilitation and resettlement benefits specified in Schedules I and II of the Act. A lump-sum amount in lieu of these benefits will be determined under the Karnataka Amendment Rules, 2020.

The township project has faced opposition from farmers, who have been protesting at Byramangala Circle for over 18 months against the proposed acquisition.

The township proposal received cabinet approval in Jan 2025. GBDA issued a preliminary land acquisition notification in March 2025. In May 2026, the cabinet approved a revised proposal covering 7,481 acres across nine villages. The first final notification, issued in June 2026, covered 499 acres in Kempayyanapalya, Mandalahalli and Vaderahalli villages. A second notification on July 15 covered over 4,941 acres in four villages. With the latest notification, the total land covered by final notifications stands at over 7,335 acres.

## Notice to developers says nearly ₹740cr raised by mortgage

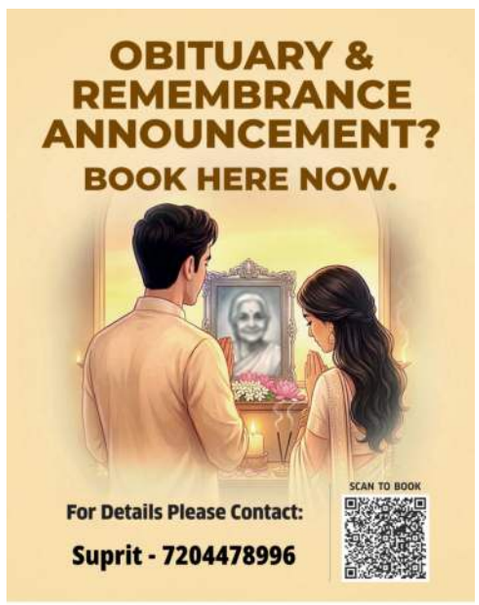
▶ Continued from page 1

The association asked how the bank could have accepted the plots as collateral when absolute sale deeds had already been executed in the buyers' favour. The association urged the bank administrator not to initiate any proceedings or take steps which may damage or dent their interest, rights and stake over the physical possession of their respective plots.

A notice issued by the bank to the layout's developers in Jan 2026 said loans totalling Rs 739 crore and 87 lakh had been raised by mortgaging the property to various persons. With interest, the outstanding amount was Rs 961 crore.

Bank officials, on condition of anonymity, told **TOI** that in as many as 10 to 15 cases of property mortgages, the then bank officials had attached "unsecured" loans to evade audit lacunae. "These accounts are being termed 'rollover accounts', wherein unsecured loans were being attached to mortgaged properties. While the actual loan recipient would have received Rs 10 to Rs 12 crore, the rest of the loan amount was given out to other people," said an official.

In the case of Shankara Layout developers, 23 people apart from the original loan recipients were given money. Bank officials said they would take a factual position on whether the plots were sold before or after the land was mortgaged in 2019. "Properties sold prior to the mortgaged dates cannot be included in the recovery process," said officials, adding that the plot owners were sending their documents individually to the bank.

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# *From Paris to Molakalmuru: Sari's odyssey revives forgotten centuries-old weaving tradition*

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**Bengaluru:** A sari displayed in a Paris museum, catalogued simply as being from south India, caught the eye of a textile revivalist and set in motion an effort to revive a forgotten weaving technique in Karnataka.

When Lavina Baldota noticed the sari, she felt it had a connection with Molakalmuru. "The language of the weave had a remarkable similarity with the region's textile tradition," she said, recounting the story at the

**NGMA EXHIBITION**

inauguration of Pampa – Textiles of Karnataka at National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) Sunday.

Lavina and her team tracked down Manjunath DS, a weaver whose family has practised the craft at Molakalmuru in Chitradurga district for generations. After studying the sari's weave, they found that it required a Jala loom, a technique once practised in the region, but which gradually disappeared. Manjunath took up the challenge, learnt the technique and set up a loom to recreate the sari. While the ikkat was tie-dyed in Telangana, the sari was eventually woven in Molakalmuru. Lavina said the idea for Pampa began with a question from fellow curator Mayank Mansingh Kaul about whether there was a book on Karnataka's textile traditions. The absence of a comprehensive account of the state's diverse textile traditions prompted a search that turned into a journey of discovery. The curatorial team, which also included Nupur Saxena, documented traditions and met weavers and communities across the state. Organised by Abheraj Baldota Foundation to mark its 50th anniversary, Pampa is presented in collaboration with the Union ministry of culture and NGMA Bengaluru. It brings together more than 150 textiles, artworks and installations, tracing Karnataka's handmade and hand-patterned textile traditions since the 18th century.

Pics: Chethan Shivakumar

**TRACING TEXTILE TALES:** Pampa exhibition at NGMA's showcases over 150 works celebrating Karnataka's textile heritage since 18th century

Union minister for culture and tourism Gajendra Singh Shekhawat described textiles as "living archives of our civilisational evolution and development". The inauguration was attended by state chief secretary Shalini Rajneesh, NGMA director-general Sanjeev Kishor Gautam, NGMA Bengaluru director Priyanka Mary Francis and Baldota Group chairman Narendra Kumar Baldota. The exhibition will be open to the public at NGMA Bengaluru until Dec 15.

# TIMES NATION

THE TIMES OF INDIA, BENGALURU | MONDAY, NOVEMBER 2, 2026

**RS BYPOLL AFFIDAVIT SHOWS HARDEEP SINGH PURI'S WIFE WEALTHIER, OWNS GENEVA APARTMENT**

**CJI: JUSTICE, INJUSTICE LIE NOT ONLY IN JUDGMENT BUT WHETHER COURT INTERVENES WHEN MOST NEEDED**

## YOU SAID IT

## Commercial LPG, ATF prices hiked

**New Delhi:** Oil marketing companies Sunday increased the price of commercial LPG by Rs 10 for a 19-kg cylinder and hiked aviation turbine fuel (ATF) rates by Rs 1.37 per litre, in line with elevated international benchmarks, **reports Atul Mathur.**

While a 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder, used by hotels and restaurants, will now cost Rs 2,820 in Delhi, ATF prices have risen to Rs 138.5 per litre. This is the third consecutive monthly increase in commercial LPG prices and the fourth straight monthly hike in ATF rates.

The price of commercial LPG varies across states due to differences in tax structures. A 19-kg cylinder will now cost Rs 2,775 in Mumbai, Rs 2,971 in Kolkata and Rs 2,994.50 in Chennai.

There has been no change in the price of the 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder, which continues to cost Rs 942 in Delhi. Petrol and diesel prices also remain unchanged.

**STATOISTICS** A slice of life in numbers

### India's rural kitchens are still waiting for the LPG upgrade

Eastern and central India continue to lag in rural LPG use. Overall, rural usage remains below 60% in two-third of the states. Telangana** is the exception, with rural LPG usage exceeding urban levels

**Rural and urban LPG usage across states (%)***

**Widest rural-urban gap**

| | Rural | Urban |
|---|---|---|
| Chhattisgarh | 15.3 | 81.3 |
| Rajasthan | 22.9 | 85.6 |
| MP | 28.4 | 90.8 |
| West Bengal | 20.5 | 82.9 |
| Jharkhand | 17.2 | 77.6 |

**Lowest rural-urban gap**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Telangana | 95.3** | 73.0 |
| Karnataka | 81.5 | 84.1 |
| Andhra | 86.9 | 89.7 |
| Gujarat | 61.2 | 65.5 |
| Tamil Nadu | 81.4 | 85.8 |

*Latest available data; Source: SBI

# Narcos NE: SE Asia cartels use barter for drug trade

## Payments Made With Fuel, Food, Meds From India, Finds ED Probe

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**New Delhi:** International illicit drug syndicates from the Golden Triangle of Myanmar, Thailand and Laos have turned to age-old barter trade under which drugs like heroin and methamphetamine are smuggled into India through the porous borders of Northeastern states and payments are made in kind through supply of petrol, diesel, wheat flour, edible oil, groceries, medicines, footwear and clothing from their Indian network.

The drug lords across the border ensure transactions are made without any money actually crossing the border, according to an investigation report compiled by Enforcement Directorate (ED) after week-long searches conducted at 38 locations across NE states last week.

Myanmar has already replaced Afghanistan as the world's largest illicit opium-producing region. With precursor chemicals moved from India to Myanmar, where the drug manufacturing units are located, finished heroin, brown sugar and synthetic drug methamphetamine tablets are produced and carried across the Tiau river at Zokhawthar, the border crossing opposite Khawmawi in Myanmar, and staged at Champhai, from where they travel down the Champhai-Aizawl road and NH-06A to Aizawl, Vairengte and then to Assam and rest of India, the report said.

The enforcement agency has also traced intermediaries who procured and supplied goods to the syndicates in Myanmar. More than 1,400 mule bank accounts have been frozen, mostly belonging to traders who procured these goods and supplied them to the network. Transactions in goods worth more than Rs 270 crore have been identified so far and six persons have been arrested. These transactions were handled by illicit money exchangers, or hawala network, in Champhai, including Rs 125 crore in cash received from Assam, Nagaland, West Bengal, Tripura and Delhi, the ED said.

Significantly, the drug money reaching the hawala accounts in Aizawl and Champhai substantially came from Delhi, Kolkata and Mumbai, the agency added. The illegal money is converted into ordinary, commercially marketable goods, which are sent to Aizawl and the border towns of Mizoram and onward to Myanmar.

"The banking system is thus used only for the Indian leg of the transaction, where the payment looks like an ordinary trade payment backed by a genuine GST invoice and e-way bill. The cross-border leg moves as goods and leaves no money trail at all. In effect, fuel, flour and groceries have become the currency," it said.

# 2-pilot rule to hit Char Dham copter services

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**New Delhi:** Chopper operations on Char Dham routes could come to standstill from Monday. Following a chopper crashing soon after take off from Badrinath on Friday (Oct 30), killing all six people on board — a pilot and five passengers, the DGCA has made it mandatory for choppers operating on Char Dham to be manned by two pilots starting Monday (Nov 2), in a bid to improve safety. However, chopper operators have termed the move unviable and threatened to suspend these sorties from Monday "until the matter is reviewed and a mutually workable solution is arrived at".

Chopper operators on Saturday sent their "collective objection to the implementation of mandatory twin-pilot operations and intimation of suspension of operations from Nov 2, 2026," to Directorate General of Civil Aviation chief Vir Vikram Yadav.

"The mandatory deployment of two pilots on every charter sortie will substantially increase operating costs, crew requirements, accommodation and logistical expenses, and overall operational commitments. Given the existing commercial structure, prevailing charter rates and limited operational margins, these additional costs cannot be reasonably absorbed by the operators," it says.

"In view of the above, we wish to formally convey that all participating operators are proposing to suspend their Char Dham charter operations with effect from Nov 2, 2026, until the matter is reviewed and a mutually workable solution is arrived at by the concerned authorities in consultation with the operators," it said.

### New airfare rules: Centre to step in only in emergencies

**New Delhi:** India has adopted new airfare rules where govt will not interfere in the process except "in an extraordinary situation (where) it considers it necessary to do so in public interest." Notified under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Niyam, 2026, that will be applicable from Jan 1, 2027, govt has continued its policy of letting market forces determine airfares without govt interference. TOI had on Oct 17 reported that India has no plans to regulate or cap airfares in the free market. However, it will keep a "strong lever" on airlines to ensure they don't resort to very sharp surges in "exceptional and extra ordinary circumstances" that see demand rising for certain routes. TNN

# 13 expelled from hostel, 66 others also face action for ragging in Rajasthan

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**Jaipur**: Govt Medical College in Rajasthan's Barmer has taken action against 79 MBBS students, barring 13 of them from hostels permanently, after many freshers alleged that seniors pressured them to keep short hair, wear formal dress and submit a "prescribed form of introduction".

Principal Anoop Gurjar underscored the institution's zero-tolerance policy towards ragging. "Ragging, indiscipline, or misbehaviour with students at any level is not tolerated under any circumstances," he said.

The Barmer case comes at a time when National Medical Commission (NMC) has received at least 12 complaints alleging ragging and harassment of first-year MBBS students.

While 13 of the 79 seniors in Barmer have been permanently expelled from the hostel, another 11 have been shut out for 30 days. Many have been barred from academic activities for 15 to 60 days. Over 50 seniors have been issued warnings that any future involvement in ragging will lead to permanent hostel expulsion. None will be allowed into cultural and sports activities for a year.

College authorities said the alleged ragging was inflicted by 2025-batch students. The matter came to light when faculty members noticed that 10 to 15 juniors had short hair. The students alleged that some seniors had instructed on WhatsApp to do so. The juniors told college officials they were going to Barmer town for books and other "necessary work" but actually trooped into a salon for haircuts. The authorities cited video footage from the salon but denied claims that seniors took the juniors to a place called "White House" for the haircuts. NMC has directed medical colleges to ensure students' safety and conduct fair inquiries under anti-ragging regulations.

## 4 die in MP hotel's waste chamber

**Brajesh Parmar** | TNN

**Ujjain:** A hotel staffer and three members of a hired sanitation team died in an overground waste chamber at a hotel in Ujjain late Saturday while it was being cleaned.

Police said water was being poured into the chamber in buckets from the upper floor of Hotel Shri Ganga when a man lost his balance and plunged into the chamber. Three other men went down to rescue him but were trapped in the muck. Another man climbed down to help them but panicked and scrambled back out.

The hotel alerted Madhav Nagar police, who rushed to the spot and arranged a cutter machine to make an opening in the side wall of the iron chamber. It took about an hour and a half to pull the four men out.

Police tried to revive the unconscious men with CPR, but to no avail. The men were then rushed to a hospital where doctors declared the four — hotel supervisor Manoj Meena (25), and sanitation team members Wahid (35), Kamlesh (30), and Nitin (22) — dead.

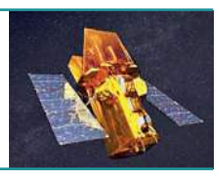
**CLOSE WATCH**

Scientists led by Stanford University oncologist Maximilian Diehn have developed a test to detect bladder cancer using urine samples. This looks at RNA rather than DNA, the molecule targeted by other tests using liquid samples

**SCIENCE OF THE TIMES**

**QUICK QUIZ**

Nasa launched this space telescope in 2004 as a two-year mission, but it worked for 22 years. Now, it is spinning uncontrollably and will soon meet a fiery end in the atmosphere. What is its name? Send your answers to **scienceofthetimes@timesofindia.com**



# CURIOUS CASE OF COOLING MAITRI

## ANTARCTIC WONDER

**Temperature and pressure changes in Antarctica can influence cross-equatorial winds and have far-reaching impacts on global weather, including Indian monsoons**

*In the time of global warming, something unusual is happening at Maitri, India's research station in the Antarctic. Temperature here is dipping while most other stations are warming up*

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For three decades, temperatures at the station in East Antarctica have fallen, while six other Antarctic research stations of other countries have been warming. Zhongshan station, about 2,450km from Maitri, is the only other station that showed a slight increase in temperature. Difference in local conditions, wind patterns and sea ice may explain the contrasting trends.

A study published in the Journal of Earth System Science analysed meteorological observations from 1991 to 2020. Maitri's average surface air temperature fell by about 0.03°C annually. It was the only station among seven where maximum, minimum and average temperatures all declined.

Maitri's maximum and minimum temperatures fell by about 0.041°C and 0.045°C annually. Wind speed, atmospheric pressure and blizzard frequency also declined. Researchers linked fewer blizzards to changes in cyclonic activity and atmospheric circulation, without directly measuring cyclone trends at Maitri.

Researchers suggested Maitri's cooling reflected interacting factors: topography, katabatic winds carrying cold, dense air downhill from the interior, radiative heat loss under clear skies and light winds, the Southern Annular Mode (a pattern of winds around Antarctica), and sea-ice extent. Terrain channels cold air, while atmospheric circulation and sea ice affect incoming weather systems. Co-author V K Soni called it a "complex interplay" of local and regional factors, whose individual contributions were not quantified.

First author Sunny Chug of the India Meteorological Department said extreme temperatures increased in frequency and intensity in West Antarctica during 1991–2020, while East Antarctica saw a slight decrease, with considerable regional variation.

East Antarctica's Davis and Zhongshan recorded weak annual warming of 0.002°C and 0.006°C, respectively; Palmer and Rothera on the Antarctic Peninsula warmed by 0.01°C and 0.03°C. In the Ross Sea region, McMurdo warmed by 0.12°C annually during 2000–2009 and Scott Base by 0.06°C during 2006–2015. Both records were shorter than Maitri's 30-year series.

A separate 2024 study investigated Zhongshan's unusually warm winter in 2018. High air pressure altered winds, drawing warmer northern air southwards and causing sinking air to warm.

Reduced sea ice increased ocean-to-atmosphere heat transfer; precipitation added warming through latent heat release, said first author Yulong Shan of China's National University of Defense Technology. That study examined a specific anomaly, not Zhongshan's long-term trend.

Earlier studies also found cooling at Maitri.

A 2006 study by RP Lal, using 1990–2005 observations, found annual mean temperature declining by about 0.26°C per decade, alongside decreases in pressure, wind, precipitation days and blizzard days. Lal noted differences from West Antarctic findings.

In 2011, KS Hosalikar and colleagues also reported cooling, driven mainly by winter. They observed that Antarctica appeared to be "warming around the edges and cooling at the center at the same time".

A 2014 India Meteorological Department climatology report, covering 1990–2012, recorded cooling of about 0.04°C per decade and discussed possible effects of the Southern Annular Mode on winds and regional weather.

These studies cover different periods. They neither establish sustained cooling across East Antarctica nor isolate the causes at Maitri. Thamban Meloth, director of the National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research, cautioned that the latest cooling trend was not highly statistically significant.

"The weather conditions you record in one place may not be the same in another if you go about 100km away because there will be local factors influencing it. So, Maitri's trend may not reflect conditions across the wider region," Thamban said.

What does this cooling mean in a warming world?

Maitri's cooling does not establish an effect on India's monsoon. Antarctic sea-ice changes, however, can influence distant atmospheric circulation and rainfall.

A 2024 IIT Delhi climate-modelling study found Antarctic sea-ice loss could warm tropical sea surfaces, weaken monsoon circulation and reduce Indian rainfall. It did not link Maitri's local cooling to monsoon changes.

M Ravichandran, former secretary of the Union ministry of earth sciences, said Antarctic and Southern Ocean temperature changes can alter atmospheric pressure patterns and the gradient between Antarctica and the Mascarene High, a high-pressure system over the southern Indian Ocean. That gradient helps drive moisture-bearing cross-equatorial winds towards India.

"If the pressure gradient between Antarctica and the Mascarene High weakens over time, the cross-equatorial winds will also weaken. This could reduce the flow of moisture towards India and, in turn, weaken the monsoon," Ravichandran said.

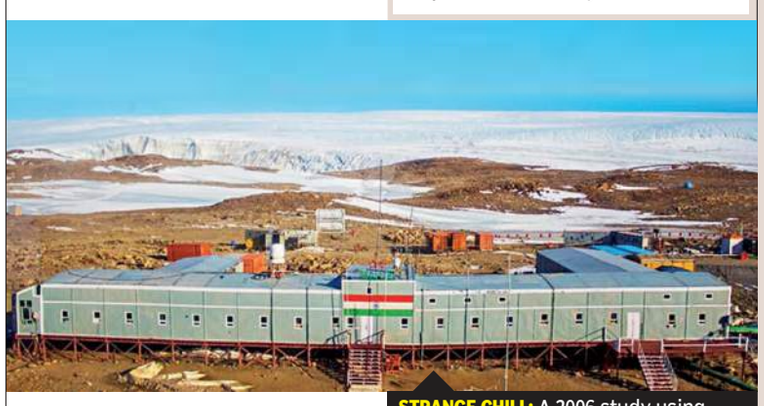
### MAITRI: INDIA'S ANTARCTIC OBSERVATORY

**1989** | Station established

**1990** | Continuous weather observations began

**−9.5°C** | Approximate annual mean temperature reported in the study

**−17°C** | Typical July–August temperature reported in the study



**STRANGE CHILL:** A 2006 study using observations between 1990 and 2005 also found Maitri to be cooling

### SIX STATIONS WARM. MAITRI COOLS

Temperature trends (1991–2020, except where specified)

- **Maitri | India** (− 0.030°C/year)
- **Davis | Australia** (+0.002°C/year)
- **Zhongshan | China** (+0.006°C/year)
- **Palmer | US** (+0.010°C/year)
- **Rothera | UK** (+0.030°C/year)
- **McMurdo | US** (+0.120°C/year) (2000–2009)
- **Scott Base | New Zealand** (+0.060°C/year) (2006–2015)

### RESEARCH AT MAITRI

- Meteorology and atmospheric sciences
- Glaciology and earth sciences
- Biology and environmental sciences
- Cold-region engineering
- Human physiology and medicine

### ANTARCTICA: CURIOUS FINDS AND CLUES TO A CHANGING PLANET

**COSMIC DUST TRAPPED IN ICE**

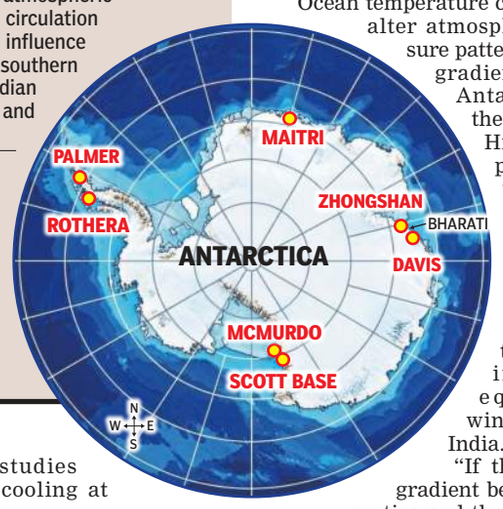
- Thousands of micrometeorites recovered from blue ice near Maitri
- About 50 tonnes of ice melted and sieved
- Extraterrestrial particles offer clues to material from asteroids and comets reaching Earth

**TRACKING THE ANTARCTIC OZONE HOLE**

- India began measuring Antarctic ozone profiles in 1987
- Observations later continued at Maitri
- Data help track severe springtime stratospheric ozone depletion and long-term changes in the ozone layer

**ANTARCTICA'S INDIAN OCEAN CONNECTION**

- Antarctic climate and atmospheric circulation influence southern Indian Ocean winds and currents
- Polar observations help scientists understand links to weather and ocean systems farther north




## Goa lab develops fish-like robots for deep-sea studies

*National Institute of Oceanography, Goa, Is Developing Robots That Mimic Marine Animals To Explore Deep Sea*

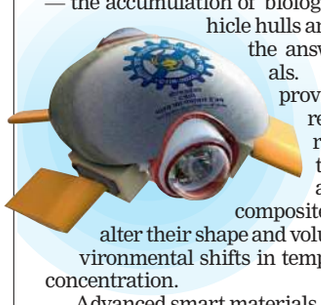
**Nida.Sayed**@timesofindia.com

Every time a robot dives for an underwater study, aquatic life shudders. Now, a team of scientists and engineers at the Goa-based National Institute of Oceanography (NIO) is working on an advanced fleet of bioinspired underwater robots (BURs) that mimic aquatic animals without disrupting their behaviour.

Traditional autonomous underwater vehicles (AUVs) rely on motorised, high-thrust bollard-pull propellers which generate much noise, turbulence, and localised habitat disruption.

BURs employ soft, flexible materials and mimetic mechanics designed to replicate marine life.

Operating robots in deep sea poses challenges including immense hydrostatic pressure, corrosive saltwater, severe light attenuation, and biofouling — the accumulation of biological organisms on vehicle hulls and sensors. NIO found the answer in smart materials. Silicone elastomers provide the durability required for flexible, repetitive fin articulation, while hydrogels and shape-memory composites can dynamically alter their shape and volume in response to environmental shifts in temperature, pH, or ionic concentration.



Advanced smart materials can convert mechanical strain into electrical energy to serve dual roles in propulsion and sensory feedback.

Scientists are researching electronics-free, fluidic control systems to operate in extreme deep-sea environments where conventional machines often fail. Since Global Positioning Systems (GPS) don't work underwater, NIO researchers are trying to develop a multimodal sensory array combining microcameras, acoustic sonar, and hydrophone systems.

Equipped with biological and chemical sensor suites, these autonomous platforms continuously sample seawater to measure salinity, pH, dissolved oxygen, and chemical pollutant concentrations. Their flexible bodies also make it possible to inspect submerged pipelines, ship hulls, and offshore platforms without damaging them.

Bioinspired engineering continues to face challenges, particularly regarding power density and energy efficiency. real marine organisms benefit from integrated muscular and metabolic systems, whereas robotic platforms depend on heavy, localized battery packs. NIO is focusing on low-drag efficient designs, incorporation of micro-energy-harvesting systems, self-healing polymers, and improvement in autonomy, ensuring future oceanic monitoring remains environmentally safe, non-invasive, and sustainable.

**LAST WEEK'S QUICK QUIZ** **Question on Oct 19: Which last reservoir of this virus was targeted by global health authorities for eradication 50 years ago? Answer:** Smallpox, the only human disease to have ever been eradicated (in 1980). The last known case (in 1978) was the result of a lab accident

# 'Mahadev syndicate ran from outside India'

▶ Continued from page 1

He will undergo a medical examination before being taken to Raipur after transit remand is obtained, the agency said.

The Royal Oman Police located and detained Chandrakar on the basis of an Interpol Red Corner Notice, according to CBI. The CBI and ED subsequently submitted extradition requests supported by evidence gathered against him. After Oman approved the extradition, a CBI team travelled to Muscat to bring him back.

The CBI took over the Mahadev Online Book cases at the Chhattisgarh govt's request and has described the operation as one of the country's largest illegal online betting syndicates.

Investigators allege that it was run from outside India through franchised "panels" and "branches" that enrolled users and collected bets on cricket, football, card games and other events.

The agency alleged that betting proceeds were routed through numerous mule bank accounts, layered through multiple transactions and transferred abroad through hawala channels. Part of the money was allegedly paid to public servants to allow the network to operate without interference.

Chandrakar is among the key accused named in chargesheets filed under the Prevention of Corruption Act, IPC provisions relating to criminal conspiracy, cheating and forgery, and the Chhattisgarh Gambling (Prohibition) Act.

# Arunachal anti-dam group calls Siang bandh over arrests

Kangkan.Kalita1
@timesofindia.com

**Guwahati:** The confrontation over the proposed 11,200MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP) in Arunachal escalated Sunday, with a youth organisation calling a shutdown across three districts along the Siang river Monday, demanding the release of those arrested over anti-dam violence and opposing the deployment of 30 CAPF companies in the region.

SUMP Affected Area Youth Association (SAAYA) called the bandh after state govt missed a deadline to release more than 40 protesters arrested over the Oct 23 violence in Pasighat and subsequent attacks on security personnel in Siang and Upper Siang. "Govt will decide on release of the arrested, but as of Sunday there is no such decision," a police source said.

# Bodies of 2 missing Kuki youths found in gunny bags in Manipur

## Shutdown Extended As Protests Grow

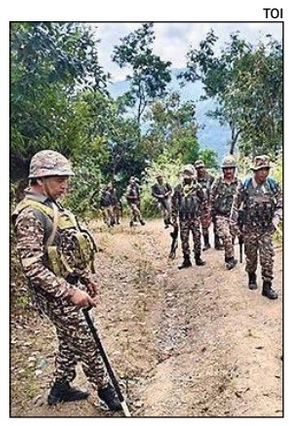
Kangkan.Kalita1
@timesofindia.com

**Guwahati:** Bodies of two Kuki youths allegedly abducted by suspected Naga militants in Manipur's Kangpokpi were found stuffed in gunny bags in a banana plantation Sunday, triggering protests and an extension of the shutdown in the Kuki-majority district.

The victims, identified as Tinginlun Chongloi, 21, and Paoginlal Hangshing, 20, both from Taphou Kuki village, had been missing since Oct 28, when they were allegedly abducted while returning from a police outpost.

The bodies of two Kuki youths were discovered a day after three Kukis were killed in a gunfight with suspected Naga armed groups in Noney district, deepening the confrontation between the two communities. The Kuki-Naga violence toll since Feb was reported at 66, comprising 37 Kukis and 29 Nagas. The separate Meitei-Kuki conflict has claimed more than 300 lives since May 2023, including four this year.

TOI



**HIGH TENSION:** Angry protesters in Kangpokpi district accused Naga militants of abducting and killing the youths

A joint search by Manipur police, CRPF, Assam Rifles and RAF along a hilly stretch east of NH-2 connecting Senapati and Kangpokpi districts led to the two bodies. Manipur Police said legal formalities were underway and combing operations would continue to identify and arrest those responsible.

Protests erupted in Kangpokpi town and community organisations refused to claim the bodies until the killers are arrested. They accused Naga militants of abducting and killing the youths. Several people were wounded as security personnel used batons and tear gas to disperse the protesters outside the Kangpokpi SP's office.

Kuki organisation Committee on Tribal Unity (CoTU), which had called a total shutdown over the alleged abduction, extended it by another 24 hours. The shutdown was scheduled to end at 5pm Sunday.

Committee on Tribal Unity demanded the removal of deputy CM Losii Dikho, alleging that he had failed to secure the youths' release and protect lives in the affected areas. Its other demands included handing the case over to NIA, and arresting and prosecuting all those involved in the murder.

The state second deputy CM Nemcha Kipgen condemned the killings, saying: "What began with hopes for their safe return has ended in a tragedy… This heinous crime must be thoroughly investigated, and those responsible must be brought to justice without delay."

11001/395/2627

**GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA**
**HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT**
**Lokaseva Bhavan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar - 751001**
**Phone: 0674-2390154 | Website: https://dhe.odisha.gov.in |**
**Mail: sectionithed@gmail.com**

**REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL**

Sealed proposals are invited from interested eligible Central/State Government PSUs for "GIS-based Land and Infrastucture Mapping (Land Management System) for all 742 Degree Colleges under the Higher Education Department, Odisha.

The last date of submission of tender is **on or before 18.11.2026, 5 PM**. Tender received after stipulated date shall not be entertained.

The detailed RFP document containing eligibility criteria, scope of work, submission requirements, evaluation process and other terms & conditions may be downloaded from the Department website: **https://dhe.odisha.gov.in** and HIMS Portal.

NOTE- The Department reserves the right to accept or reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

Tenders must be sent via Speed/Registered Post/Courier to:
Deputy Secretary to Government (IT), Higher Education Department,
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar -751001
Or By MAIL: **sectionithed@gmail.com**

OIPR-11001/11001/1/26-27/0082

11001/397/2627

**GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA**
**HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT**
**Lokaseva Bhavan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar - 751001**
**Phone: 0674-2390154 | Website: https://dhe.odisha.gov.in |**
**Mail: sectionithed@gmail.com**

**REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL**

Sealed proposals are invited from eligible Central/State Government Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) for creation of dedicated Wikipedia Pages for 742 Degree Colleges under the Higher Education Department, Odisha. The last date of submission of tender is **on or before 23.11.2026, 5 PM**. Tender received after stipulated date shall not be entertained.

The detailed RFP document containing eligibility criteria, scope of work, submission requirements, evaluation process and other terms & conditions may be downloaded from the Department website: **https://dhe.odisha.gov.in** and HIMS portal.

NOTE- The Department reserves the right to accept or reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

Tenders must be sent via Speed/Registered Post/Courier to:
Deputy Secretary to Government (IT), Higher Education Department,
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar -751001
Or By MAIL: **sectionithed@gmail.com**

OIPR-11001/11001/1/26-27/0083

**THE ANDHRA PRADESH MINERAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED**
**Door No. 294/1D, 100 feet Road (Tadigadapa to Enikepadu Road), Kanuru, Vijayawada – 521137, Andhra Pradesh, India**
**Tel: +91-866-2429999 Fax: +91-866-2429977 Email: contracts-ho@apmdc.in**

**E- TENDER**
**SALE OF 'RAW COAL' PRODUCED from Suliyari Coal Mine, Madhya Pradesh State.**
**Tender No. APMDC/P&C/Sale of Raw Coal-SCM/2026-27, Date: 02.11.2026**

**APMDC** invites E-tenders from reputed contractors for **SALE OF 'RAW COAL' PRODUCED from Suliyari Coal Mine, Madhya Pradesh State.** For more information on the eligibility criteria, tender fees, timelines and other details, please visit e-procurement website of **GoAP (www.tender.apeprocurement.gov.in)** or **APMDC** website **(www.apmdc.ap.gov.in)**. The tender document will be available for download from **02.11.2026** onwards and last date for bid submission is **23.11.2026.**

**Place: Vijayawada**
**Date: 02nd November 2026**

**Sd/- Managing Director**
**The A. P. Mineral Development Corporation Limited**

DIPR No.: 5535PP/CL/ADVT/1/1/2021-22 Dt:01/11/2026

**DIRECTORATE OF MINORITIES**
Maulana Azad Bhavan, No.16C, Miller Tank Bed Road, Vasantnagar, Bengaluru - 560 052.

**No: DOM/DEVP/CCH/40/2026-27** **Date:02-11-2026**

**Short Term Tender**

A Short term tender has been invited by the Directorate of Minorities for Providing **60 days Army Training** to Minority students for the year 2026-27. Interested & eligible bidders/ institutes can apply through e-Procurement portal. The schedule of tender will be as follows.

| Sl. No. | Details | Date/Time |
|---|---|---|
| 1. | Date of Tender Publication | 02-11-2026 |
| 2. | Date & time of Pre-bid meeting | 06-11-2026 11:30 AM |
| 3. | Last date and time for submission of tender: | 20-11-2026 by 5:30 p.m. |
| 4. | Telephone No. to be contacted | 080-22535902/901 8277799990 |

Other details can be obtained from the website of the Directorate of Minorities **https://dom.karnataka.gov.in** and e-Procurement website at https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in

**Sd/-**
**Joint Director**
**Directorate of Minorities, Bengaluru**

DIPR/CP/3457/MAA/2026-27

**DEPARTMENT OF ENERGY, GOVERNMENT OF UTTAR PRADESH,**
Room No. 324, Bapu Bhawan, Vidhan Shabha Marg, Lucknow (UP) 226001, India

**ADVERTISEMENT NO.- 03/2026**

Department of Energy, Government of Uttar Pradesh Invites on-line application for the following posts:-

| SL. NO. | NAME OF THE POST | NAME OF CORPORATION/DISCOM | NOS. OF VACANCY |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1- | Director (Distribution) | U.P.Power Corporation Ltd., Lucknow | 1 |
| 2- | Director (Finance) | U.P Power Transmission Corporation Ltd., Lucknow | 1 |
| 3- | Director (Operation) | U.P Power Transmission Corporation Ltd., Lucknow | 1 |
| 4- | Director (Planning & Commercial) | U.P Power Transmission Corporation Ltd., Lucknow | 1 |
| 5- | Director (Commercial) | Paschimanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., Meerut | 1 |
| 6- | Director (Technical) | Paschimanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., Meerut | 1 |
| 7- | Director (Finance) | Paschimanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., Meerut | 1 |
| 8- | Director (Technical) | Purvanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., Varanasi | 1 |
| 9- | Director (Personnel & Administration) | Dakshinanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., Agra | 1 |
| 10- | Director (Commercial) | Dakshinanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., Agra | 1 |
| 11- | Director (Commercial) | Kesco Ltd. Kanpur | 1 |

**Last date of application is 21st November, 2026 till 5 P.M.**
**Details and online application is available on the website: www.uppcl.org**
**The following information will generally be sought in application form on website. (The indicative format Is only for reference).**
**Basic details (Name, father's/Husband name, age, address, email, mobile no. etc.) educational qualifications details, work experience, details of your vision and achievement in past organizations.**
**RO.18 DATED 31 OCT 2026**

**THE TAMILNADU CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' FEDERATION LTD**
**JOINT MANAGING DIRECTOR'S OFFICE,**
**PLOT No.29 & 30, SIDCO INDUSTRIAL ESTATE, AMBATTUR, CHENNAI - 600 098.**
**Tel. Ph. Nos.: 044 - 23464528, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, Fax No.: 044-23464536 e-mail – dgmpurchase@gmail.com**
**TENDER NOTICE**

A Two Part Open tender is invited from the Manufacturers for the Purchase of following items :

| Sl. No. | Ref. No. | Description | Estimate Value | Important Dates: Pre-Bid meeting | Submission of e- bid tender document along with Sample | Opening of Technical Bids |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 6000/K3/ 2025 | Purchase of 20,402 MT ± 25% of Multilayer Co-extruded Poly End Film to Metro Dairies and all District Union Dairies for thirty six months requirement for the year 2026-2029. | Rs.495.77 Crores | 11.11.2026 by 11.00 A.M. | 09.12.2026 upto 3.00 P.M. | 10.12.2026 by 3.00 P.M. |

For pre-qualification criteria, specifications, EMD payable, place of tender opening, etc., please refer the website **www.tntenders.gov.in** and **https://aavin.tn.gov.in.** Tender documents can also be downloaded at free of cost and the tenderers should submit the tender offer only through the Website **www.tntenders.gov.in.**

**JOINT MANAGING DIRECTOR**
DIPR /3303/ TENDER /2026 TAMILNADU CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' FEDERATION LTD

11001/399/2627

**ଓଡିଶା ସରକାର**
**ଉଚ୍ଚଶିକ୍ଷା ବିଭାଗ**

**ଦ୍ୱାଦଶ ଶ୍ରେଣୀରେ ଉତ୍ତୀର୍ଣ୍ଣ ୧୫୦୦୦ ମେଧାବୀ ଛାତ୍ରଛାତ୍ରୀଙ୍କୁ ଲାପଟପ କିଣିବା ନିମନ୍ତେ ଆର୍ଥିକ ସହାୟତା ପ୍ରଦାନ**

ଉଚ୍ଚଶିକ୍ଷା ମାଧ୍ୟମିକ ଶିକ୍ଷା ପରିଷଦ (CHSE) ଦ୍ୱାରା ପରିଚାଳିତ Annual Higher Secondary Examination, ୨୦୨୬ ଏବଂ Shri Jagannath Sanskrit Viswavidyalaya, Puri ୨୦୨୬ ଉପଶାସ୍ତ୍ରୀ ରେ ଉତ୍ତୀର୍ଣ୍ଣ ହୋଇଥିବା ଛାତ୍ରଛାତ୍ରୀଙ୍କ ମଧ୍ୟରୁ ଯୋଗ୍ୟ ବିବେଚିତ ଛାତ୍ରଛାତ୍ରୀମାନଙ୍କୁ 'ଗୋଦାବରୀଶ ବିଦ୍ୟାର୍ଥୀ ପ୍ରୋତ୍ସାହନ ଯୋଜନା'ରେ ଲାପଟପ କିଣିବା ନିମନ୍ତେ (Direct Benefit Transfer – DBT) ମାଧ୍ୟମରେ ଟ.୩୦,୦୦୦/-ଙ୍କାର ଆର୍ଥିକ ସହାୟତା ପ୍ରଦାନ କରାଯିବ।

ଏଥିସହ, ୨୦୨୫ ମସିହାରେ ରେ ଉତ୍ତୀର୍ଣ୍ଣ ହୋଇଥିବା ଏବଂ ଆବେଦନ କରିପାରିନଥିବା ଯୋଗ୍ୟ ଛାତ୍ରଛାତ୍ରୀମାନଙ୍କୁ ମଧ୍ୟ ପୋର୍ଟାଲ ମାଧ୍ୟମରେ ଆବେଦନ କରିବାର ସୁଯୋଗ ପ୍ରଦାନ କରାଯିବ।

ଯୋଗ୍ୟ ବିବେଚିତ ଛାତ୍ରଛାତ୍ରୀମାନଙ୍କର ତାଲିକା ଏବଂ ମାର୍ଗଦର୍ଶିକା ଉଚ୍ଚଶିକ୍ଷା ବିଭାଗର ୱେବସାଇଟ www.dhe.odisha.gov.in ଓ www.scholarship. odisha.gov.in ରେ ଉପଲବ୍ଧ। ଛାତ୍ରଛାତ୍ରୀ ମାନେ ନିଜର ଆଧାର ନମ୍ବର ଓ ଆଧାର ସହିତ ସଂଯୋଗ ହୋଇଥିବା ମୋବାଇଲ ନମ୍ବର ମାଧ୍ୟମରେ www.scholarship. odisha.gov.in ରେ ରେଜିଷ୍ଟ୍ରେସନ କରି ମାର୍ଗଦର୍ଶିକା ଅନୁଯାୟୀ ନିଜର ବିବରଣୀ **ତା: ୦୨.୧୧.୨୦୨୬ ରିଖ (ଆବେଦନର ଆରମ୍ଭ ତାରିଖ) ଠାରୁ ୧୯.୧୧.୨୦୨୬ (ଆବେଦନର ଶେଷ ତାରିଖ)** ମଧ୍ୟରେ ପ୍ରଦାନ କରିବାକୁ ଅନୁରୋଧ।

ସ୍ୱା/-
ଯୁଗ୍ମ ଶାସନ ସଚିବ

OIPR-11001/11001/1/26-27/0084

# DGIT report flags major share valuation discrepancies

▶ Continued from page 1

Recording details of financial transactions, the bench noted Chetan Sabharwal along with his brother Nitin Sabharwal and two other shareholders entered into two share purchase agreements with GYS Real Estate Pvt Ltd (buyer company) for a sale of 7.5 lakh equity shares of Pawan Impex (P) Ltd and 2.5 lakh equity shares of SVIIT Software (P) Ltd held by each of the parties for a sale consideration of Rs 195 crore and Rs 60 crore, respectively. The appellant and other selling shareholders were each entitled to 1/4th share of the total consideration.

"The reasons rest on tangible material, namely the report of the DGIT Investigation Unit, Noida, which concluded that shares of company No. 1 (Pawan Impex (P) Ltd) and company No. 2 (SVIIT Software (P) Ltd) were overvalued when compared with the cost of their land and building, and they have a rational nexus and a live link with the belief formed by the assessing officer," it said.

Subsequent to completion of assessment, the investigation unit conducted enquiries into the value of the shares of Pawan Impex (P) Ltd and SVIIT Software (P) Ltd and prepared a report. The report concluded, prima facie, that the shares were overvalued when compared with the cost of their land and building, which was much lower than the transaction amounts of Rs 195 crore and Rs 60 crore, respectively.

**INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY**
**Chennai - 600 038**

The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to **www.ireps.gov.in** and quote against the tender. Manual Quotation will not be entertained for the tender.

| Open Tender No. | Short Description of the Item | Tender Value (₹) |
|---|---|---|
| 2026499212367 | Works Contract for Aluminium Composite Panelling and Associated works in LHB Coaches | 22197983 |

| Date of Tender | |
|---|---|
| Closing | Opening on |
| 20.11.2026 at 14.45 hrs | 20.11.2026 at 15.00 hrs. |

Hindi Version of the above advertisement is available in
**https://icf.indianrailways.gov.in**
**Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer / FUR**

**Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board, Pune**
Plot No. R-7, Market Yard, Gultekadi, Pune - 411037
Tel.No.: 020-24528100 / 24528200
Email - domestic@msamb.com Website - www.msamb.com

**e-TENDER NOTICE**

**e-Tender for Selection of Agency for Supply of Digital Moisture Meter (DMM) for determination of Moisture Content of food grains**

Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board (MSAMB) invites proposals from manufacturers and authorized suppliers for supply of Digital Moisture Meters (DMM) for determination of moisture content of food grains commodities. The last date and time for submission of bids is 16.11.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. The tender document may be downloaded from the Maharashtra e-Tender Portal (https://mahatenders.gov.in) and the MSAMB website (www.msamb.com).
Any corrigendum, extension of the bid submission deadline, or other information relating to this tender shall be published only on the above-mentioned websites.

**Managing Director**

**Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board, Pune**
Plot No. R-7, Market Yard, Gultekadi, Pune - 411037
Tel.No.: 020-24528100 / 24528200
Email - domestic@msamb.com Website - www.msamb.com

**e-TENDER NOTICE**

**e-Tender for Request for Proposal (RFP) for Selection of a Supplier for the Supply of G.P.T.S. to APMCs in Maharashtra**

The Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board (MSAMB), Pune, invites online bids from reputed manufacturers or their authorized dealers for the supply of Grain Protective Tarpaulin Sacks (GPTS) to Agricultural Produce Market Committees (APMCs) across Maharashtra. The last date and time for submission of bids is 16.11.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. The tender document may be downloaded from the Maharashtra e-Tender Portal (https://mahatenders.gov.in) and the MSAMB website (www.msamb.com).
Any corrigendum, extension of the bid submission deadline, or other information relating to this tender shall be published only on the above-mentioned websites.

**Managing Director**

**INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY**
**Chennai - 600 038**

**INDIAN RAILWAYS**
**Tender Notice No. ICF/EL/Cons/2026-27, Dt : 02.11.2026**
For and on behalf of The President of India, The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Maintenance/Shell, Integral Coach Factory, invites E-Tender for the following works.

| Tender No. | Name of Work | Approx value in Lakhs (Rs.) | EMD (Rs.) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2026245 212279R | EL-W-945 Augmentation of Power Supply Panels at ICF Substations | 730.88 | 14,61,800/- |

**Tender Closing Date and Time : 25.11.2026 at 15.30 hrs.**

Web site for submission of offer : **www.ireps.gov.in**
Hindi Version of the above tender notification is available in :
**https://icf.indianrailways.gov.in**

**INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY**
**Chennai - 600 038**

The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to **www.ireps.gov.in** and quote against these tender. Manual Quotation will not be entertained for this tender.

| Sl. No. | Open Tender No. | Short Description of work | Approx. Value in Rs. |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 202637 7212371 | (A) New Raw & Metro Water Pipelines: East Colony to Furnishing Factory & Main Pump House to Block 165. (B) Repairs to leakages in GLR & OHT and interconnection of pump houses in South Colony. (C) New GLR & OHT in South Colony. (D) 3.00 Lakh GLR in East Colony-2 Nos. (E) OHT & GLR in Shell Factory. (F) Reconstruction of 3 lakh litres capacity at GLR in East Colony-2 Nos | 5.93 Crore |

**Date of Tender Closing Date & Time : 21.11.2026 @ 10.30 hrs.**

Hindi translation of the advertisement available in the Website
**www://icf.indianrailways.gov.in**

**ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE**
**INDIAN INSTITUTE OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY AND MANAGEMENT GWALIOR**
**(Indian Institute of Information Technology & Management, Gwalior)**
**Morena Link Road, Gwalior – 474015 M.P.**

**Ref. ABV-IIITMG/NF Rect./2026/1418** **Date: 30/10/2026**

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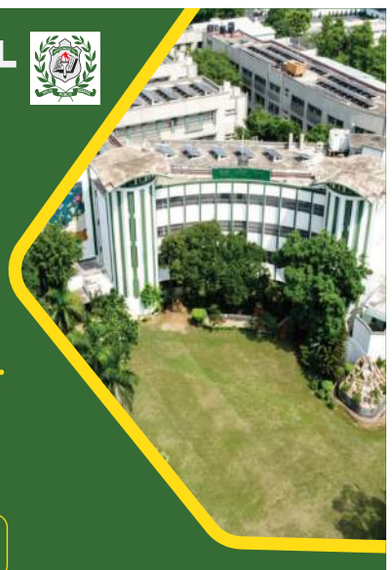

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**PRINCIPAL**

# Rahul: CEC, Modi & Shah suppressing people's voice

▶Continued from page 1

Opposition speakers repeated allegations about SIR and deletion of around 14 crore voters. Rahul accused the CEC, PM and Shah of suppressing the voice of people through "vote chori".

While Mamata and Akhilesh said the West Bengal mandate to BJP as "stolen", Rahul mentioned the Maharashtra, Haryana, Chhattisgarh, MP and 2024 LS polls. He said the 2024 polls were illegal, arguing the difference between NDA and opposition was merely 3% while 15% of the 2024 voters have been deleted under SIR. "Modi is selecting the voters," Congress chief Kharge said.

Led by Kharge, most INDIA bloc members stressed ejecting BJP from office was a must to save democracy, even leading the crowd in "BJP hatao, desh bachao" chants. Some reminded the crowd that Ramlila Maidan has been the harbinger of history and change in the past. SP chief Akhilesh called the historic venue the "Haldighati of democracy", referring to the battlefield in Rajasthan where Maharana Pratap faced off with the Mughals in 1576, remembered as a symbol of defiant resistance to a powerful empire. Addressing the crowd that had been growing since 9am and remained eager even as main INDIA bloc members came on the dais only by 3pm, Akhilesh, who occupied a key spot with UP polls looming, hit out at Modi, saying, "Jo UP se aaye the, woh UP se hi jaayenge (those who came from UP, will go from UP)". The UP poll results will see off BJP from office in Lucknow and Delhi, he said, also raising "chanda chori" in Ayodhya in his speech.

Akhilesh warned BJP was constantly trying to steal elections, even blaming SP's 2022 assembly defeat on voter list manipulation. The SP chief said UP BJP has stated that 1.27 crore votes of Hindus have been deleted in UP. He said the statement seems designed to "put the blame for their upcoming defeat on someone else" – touching upon the much-talked about "Delhi vs Lucknow" faultlines in BJP.

Indulging the sloganeering crowd, Rahul said his predictions always come true, and he was now forecasting that CEC Kumar would go to jail.

TOI

Congress MP Rahul Gandhi, along with other INDIA bloc leaders, proceeds in an open bus to stage the 'Chalo Dilli' march from Minto Bridge to Ramlila Maidan in New Delhi Sunday

# Holding rally on Nov 1 is like rubbing salt into '84 victims' wounds: Shah

▶Continued from page 1

As BJP functionaries, like former party chief and Union health minister J P Nadda, expressed jubilation over what they called a "super flop show" at Ramlila Maidan, the party also homed in on Congress's choice of the date for the rally — the anniversary of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots which took place in the wake of former PM Indira Gandhi's assassination — to accuse the opposition party of mocking the tragedy suffered by the community.

"They chose the very day when genocide of Sikhs happened to hold a rally. It is like rubbing salt into the wounds of 1984 victims," said Shah in Chandigarh.

Recalling Rajiv Gandhi's controversial "when a big tree falls, the earth shakes" remark, which was seen by many as the former PM seeking to rationalise the mass killings of Sikhs, a combative Shah emphasised that BJP had urged Congress not to hold the rally between Nov 1 and 3, days associated with the massacre.

Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis, joined by deputy CM Eknath Shinde, led the march in Thane, while CM Pushkar Singh Dhami and CM Rekha Gupta led similar anti-Congress protests in Uttarakhand and Delhi, respectively. Former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan along with Union minister Kishanpal Gujjar led a march in Faridabad. Assam CM Himata Biswa Sarma joined a protest at Shimla alongside former CM Jairam Thakur and former Union minister Anurag Thakur.

Uttar Pradesh saw six BJP rallies. Charges of "anarchy" and "undemocratic conduct" were the themes across the rallies, with party leaders like Union minister Bhupendra Yadav alleging that Congress's anti-SIR protest was a ploy to mask Rahul Gandhi's repeated political failures.

# Day after AAP's Punjab first list, 2 MLAs quit amid BJP entry buzz

**Navjeevan.Gopal**
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**Chandigarh:** A day after Punjab's governing AAP announced its first list of 40 candidates for the 2027 assembly elections, MLAs Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra and Chetan Singh Jouramajra quit the party Sunday amid speculation they would join BJP. Neither had made the first cut.

Pathanmajra is the Sanour MLA and Jouramajra, among AAP's early entrants in the state, is the Samana legislator. Sources said the duo was doubtful of getting a ticket this time — Pathanmajra faces a rape case and Jouramajra was dropped from CM Bhagwant Mann's cabinet in 2024. Mann was among those on Saturday's list of 40, renominated from Dhuri.

Jouramajra announced his exit in a social media post. Pathanmajra sent his resignation to AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal. Both cited Mann-led govt's failure to control the drug menace and anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota's murder as main reasons for quitting.

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## BEL Bengaluru Complex Celebrates 71st Karnataka Rajyotsava with Cultural Fervour

**BENGALURU: Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), Bengaluru Complex, celebrated the 71st Karnataka Rajyotsava** with great enthusiasm and cultural splendour at its premises on Sunday, November 1, 2026. The celebrations began with traditional prayers offered to Goddess Bhuvaneshwari, symbolising the state's rich heritage and spiritual traditions. This was followed by the unfurling of the Kannada flag by Shri Rajnish Sharma, Director (Bengaluru Complex), BEL.

The event saw active participation from the senior leadership, including Shri Giriraja N., Executive Director (Electronic Warfare & Avionics), and Shri T. N. Singh, General Manager (Human Resources), along with senior officials, employees, their families and workforce representatives.

Addressing the gathering, the Director (Bengaluru Complex) highlighted BEL's enduring bond with Karnataka and reaffirmed the organisation's commitment to preserving the region's linguistic heritage and vibrant culture. He emphasised that unity, cultural pride and a shared identity remain central to BEL's workforce culture. He also reiterated BEL's continued contribution to the state's industrial growth, technological advancement and socio-economic development.

The event showcased Karnataka's rich traditions and brought together employees and their families in a grand display of state pride and collective progress.

# 1984 survivors, Sikh grps question timing of rally, demand Cong's apology

**Manash.Gohain**
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**New Delhi:** Survivors of the 1984 anti-Sikh killings and Sikh organisations Sunday questioned Congress's decision to hold the INDIA bloc rally on Nov 1, the 42nd anniversary of the massacre. With Punjab assembly elections due in 2027, the rally's timing also gave BJP political ammunition against Congress.

The day saw a BJP-organised protest march in West Delhi, objections from victims' groups and renewed demands for justice.

In West Delhi, Sikh community members and survivors joined a march from Hari Nagar towards Tilak Nagar, demanding an apology from Congress and Rahul Gandhi. Union minister Hardeep Singh Puri, Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta, minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa and senior advocate HS Phoolka, who has represented riot victims for decades, participated.

"Nov 1 is not only a black day for the Sikhs but the entire country. They (Congress) should also observe it as a black day and hang their heads in shame," Phoolka had said ahead of the rally.

The 1984 Riot Victims Welfare Society also objected to the timing of the rally. Its representatives, who had met Punjab governor Gulab Chand Kataria on Friday, said Nov 1 was a day of mourning, not political mobilisation. They also raised pending demands for housing, employment and rehabilitation.

Society president Surjit Singh sought dignified rehabilitation, while women's wing president Bibi Gurdeep Kaur recalled losing eight family members in the violence. Rajya Sabha MP Vikramjit Singh Sahney, who met survivors in Delhi, recalled losing four family members and alleged that the killings were systematically planned.

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# MBBS seats on clearance sale as private colleges offer 40% discount in fees

**Around 3,426 MBBS seats remained vacant; K'taka reported unfilled seats for the first time in five years**

**Divyansh.Kumar**
@timesofindia.com

**With institutional overheads pushing annual outlays between Rs 25 lakh and Rs 35 lakh, the complete course may cost around Rs 1.25 crore**

After third and stray round of medical counselling, several MBBS seats remain vacant across several medical colleges. This has prompted private medical colleges to offer upto 40% discount in tuition fee. This points to a growing mismatch between the rapid increase in seats and students' ability to pay exorbitant fees, even as premier deemed universities struggle to fill them.

As many as 3,426 MBBS seats remained vacant after the third round of all-India counselling this year, more than five times of the 802 vacant seats in 2025. The Medical Counselling Committee (MCC) subsequently reported 837 unfilled spots after the stray vacancy round across Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, and Karnataka. These vacancies follow the National Medical Commission (NMC) sanctioning 13,636 new UG medical seats this year, expanding the national pool beyond 1.4 lakh.

With hostel, mess, and institutional overheads pushing annual outlays between Rs 25 lakh and Rs 35 lakh, the complete course costs around Rs 1.25 crore. "More than 75% of newly approved MBBS seats over the last three years have gone to private medical colleges. Students from lower middle-class and even middle-class families simply cannot afford these fees," says Muzaffar Khan, a Thane-based medical education counsellor.

### Stumbling Block

A senior official from the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW) notes that the problem begins and ends with high fee structure. "Government medical college seats are 100% filled; vacancies are confined entirely to the private sector. Colleges and state fee-fixation committees must re-examine these fee structures, because lowering NEET qualifying cut-offs will not resolve an affordability crisis when millions of candidates already qualify."

The resulting pressure has forced private colleges to negotiate. At one deemed university in Tamil Nadu, a candidate negotiated annual fees down from Rs 25 lakh to Rs 15 lakh, a 40% reduction bringing the four-and-a-half-year total below Rs 80 lakh, against an original figure exceeding Rs 1 crore. "Some colleges are approaching counsellors and admission agents to fill vacant seats. Families are reluctant to break their bank on an undergraduate seat, especially when PG admissions demand another round of high expenses," adds Khan.

Prince Gajendra Babu, a Tamil Nadu-based education activist, says, "The vacancies are an indicator that qualifying for medical admission does not necessarily mean students could afford a seat. Institutions charge full fees to early applicants and offer discounts to late entrants to fill the vacant seats. It reflects a purely commercial approach that compromises merit while still failing to fill classrooms."

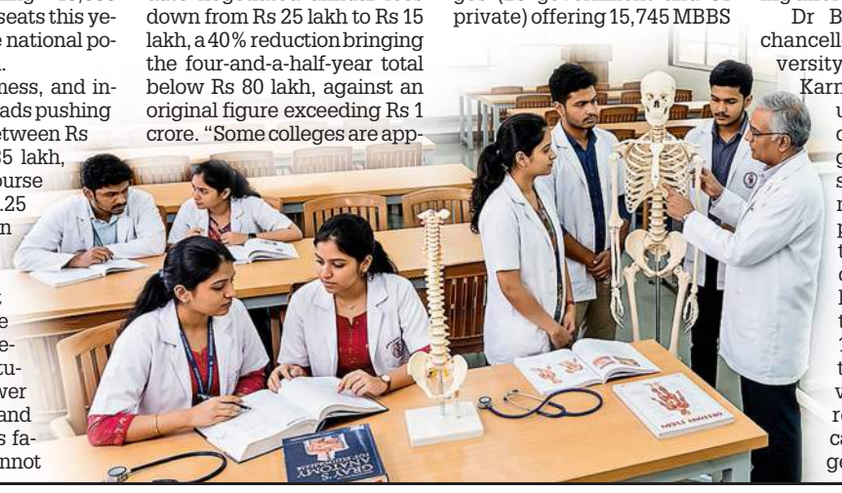
### Regional Crisis

Karnataka, home to 76 colleges (25 government and 51 private) offering 15,745 MBBS seats has 191 seats remain vacant for the first time in five years. The Karnataka Examinations Authority (KEA) conducted a record seven rounds of counselling. "This is the first time allotments were carried out across so many rounds. Further rounds could be held if MCC permits," says H Prasanna, executive director, KEA.

Expansion of NRI quota in government medical colleges could be attributed to the expansion. These seats cost around Rs 25 lakh a year, compared with management-quota fees of Rs 30 lakh to Rs 45 lakh annually in private colleges.

The Directorate of Medical Education has approached the NMC seeking a reduction in the NEET UG qualifying percentile, currently 50, to widen the pool of eligible candidates. The MoHFW official, however, says lowering the cut-off would not address the underlying affordability problem .

Dr Bhagavan BC, vice-chancellor, Rajiv Gandhi University of Health Sciences, Karnataka, the umbrella university for all medical-related programmes in the state, says, "High management-quota fees are putting seats beyond the reach of many candidates. Some 24 lakh students write the entrance test for 1.4 lakh seats. While the cream gets government seats, the rest of the students cannot afford a management-quota seat."



# NCTE's MITRA and PUSHTI aim to connect teachers with mentors and elevate professional standards

**Priyadarshini.Gupta**
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Although teacher mentoring has long existed informally, educators have lacked a structured nationwide framework for guidance from experienced professionals. To bridge this gap, the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE) is strengthening teacher development through two initiatives: Professional Upholding of Standards for Holistic Teaching and Integrity (PUSHTI) which sets professional standards and Mentoring Initiatives for Teaching, Research and Assessment (MITRA) which connects teachers with experienced educators to improve classroom practice. Mentoring is not currently mandatory for teachers. To support them, the NCTE has developed online resources called 'Bluebooks', available in all 23 languages.

Work on the two initiatives began around 2022 and was formally launched by the Ministry of Education in March 2024. They are aimed at improving school education by 2030, in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 objectives.

Pankaj Arora, chairperson, NCTE, says, "Teacher education should extend beyond pre-service training. In-service teacher education and continuous professional development are equally important, with teachers needing ongoing guidance and opportunities to strengthen their professional competencies. The initiative makes mentoring accessible to those who may not have regular opportunities to interact with experienced educators beyond their institutions."

### Assessing Strengths

PUSHTI establishes a framework for defining the professional competencies teachers need to develop throughout their careers. Linked to the National Professional Standards for Teachers (NPST), it helps them understand their roles, assess their strengths, and identify areas of improvement, adds Prof Arora.

MITRA connects teachers with experienced educators for guidance and professional support, enabling them to discuss classroom challenges, explore teaching methods, and learn from others' experiences. Formal mentoring system is relatively new to the Indian education. Prof Arora says, "Initial focus was on defining the concept and designing a framework centred on teachers' professional development rather than simply creating another digital platform."

The MITRA framework initially covered 13 mentoring domains. "The domains included writing competencies, research, management-related issues, pedagogy, and educational technology, inclusive education and special education. While some address common professional needs, others focus on additional educational support demanding special expertise," says Prof Arora.

### KJU hosts conference on smart tech and sustainable business

To provide international exposure in emerging technologies, digital business, sustainability, cybersecurity, and resilient enterprise practices, the Department of Management, School of Business and Management, Kristu Jayanti University, Bengaluru, organised a two-day International Conference titled 'Smart Technology and Digital Business Ecosystems for Sustainable and Resilient Intelligent Enterprises'. The conference was organised in association with the Faculty of Business and Law, University of Saint Joseph, Macau. The conference commenced with an inaugural session by Jenny Oliveros Lao Phillips, dean, Faculty of Business and Law and associate professor of Human and Social Science, University of Saint Joseph, Macau, as the chief guest. The presidential address was delivered by Fr Joshy Mathew, CHRO, Kristu Jayanti University. The inaugural session highlighted the importance of ESG practices and sustainability for small food and beverage enterprises in Macau.

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# Strangers To Our Mind?

**Santosh Desai**

We just cannot remember that name. A name we are very familiar with, but at that moment it escapes us. We can almost sense its shape, but the mind refuses to throw it up. We might even get to its first letter, but we are stuck there. And then, hours later, it effortlessly pops into the mind, as if it had been hiding in a corner just to tease us. It is just the mind doing its thing.

And it works the other way too. Things pop into our minds for no apparent reason whatsoever. You wake up with an old C-grade Hindi film song in your head, a song you have not heard in decades and did not remember knowing in the first place. Or a concrete image from childhood flashes into the mind, and we can feel the texture of the wall we used to run our fingers over. We really have very little idea how our minds work. Of course, we often use them purposively. We can direct our minds to solve a maths problem or work on a presentation. But we do not quite control what we can think of when. While writing, for instance, phrases appear in one's head without any conscious understanding of how one happened to think of them.

This should puzzle us more than it does. We go through life accepting that this is perfectly normal. We spend our time thinking, wondering, imagining, remembering. We drift to the past, construct scenarios for the future and hold detailed conversations with absent people in our head, where we almost always are devastatingly smart. We create fictional worlds and populate them with characters out of nothing that is visible to us. Our minds are the seat of the self; it is we who do the thinking, imagining, witty repartee-ing. The mind is us, at our most intimate. And yet so much of what it produces simply appears. We participate in thinking without being able to witness how a thought takes shape. The mind seems to have a mind of its own, to which we are not entirely privy.

This is mostly true of the body also. We have little sense of what the pancreas is busy doing or how our blood is getting filtered. Pain, hunger and fatigue tell us something about our internal condition but are largely silent on the underlying processes.

This does not trouble us much; we let the body do its work. Besides, it would be impossible to live if we felt everything happening inside our bodies. Why should the mind be any different? Because it is the means through which we think about everything, including ourselves. We know that the liver will not do our bidding, but it is something we expect from our mind. The name should come when we summon it; its refusal to do so feels like insubordination. It upsets us, but who exactly are we annoyed with when we are annoyed with ourselves for forgetting? We somehow become both the person issuing the instruction and the person failing to carry it out.

Interestingly, we tend to give credit to ourselves for a good idea but distance ourselves from the same mind when it fails to produce a name we were seeking. My mind is not what it used to be. My mind is playing games with me. Tellingly, we don't say 'my mind had this brilliant idea'.

This starts to matter in a less abstract way when it comes to AI. We ask something, and it produces an answer through a process we do not understand. Not that dissimilar from how the mind works, except in this case, we know that the processing came from an external actor. All this while, our mind had been giving us answers without showing how they were arrived at. We never needed to know how intelligence worked for us to enjoy its fruits. Which is why, perhaps, it is easier for us to accept AI's output. An answer emerging from somewhere inaccessible is hardly a new experience. But there is a difference. While we do not see our own thoughts come into being, we experience the effort our mind makes. Sometimes the answers just materialise, on other occasions we struggle to find the right word, we change what we think is inappropriate or just not good enough. We strain against the clunky, exult in the elegant. We are always inside the effort, inhabiting it.

With AI, the answers appear, fully formed. We sit outside the answer, having made no contribution to it. We can challenge it, reshape it, craft it, but all from the outside. It often sounds like us, in fact, a better version of us, giving us the sensation of encountering a stranger wearing an eerily familiar face. It's like looking into a mirror when we are not in front of it. It is unsettling because we see what resembles our output without seeing ourselves inside it. We sense that there is a difference. But is the effort we feel all there is to the difference between human and machine intelligence?

AI makes us think about something we didn't have to think about before. Before AI, we could take our own thinking for granted. AI makes that comfortable arrangement more difficult to sustain. In asking whether a machine can think, we find ourselves having to explain what we mean when we say that we do.

*santosh365@gmail.com*

# India's extreme poverty rate falls 90% in 12 years

## Employment Up By 13.4cr Since 2017: PM

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PM Narendra Modi

**New Delhi:** India has recorded one of the fastest poverty declines in the world, with the extreme poverty rate in the country "collapsing" by 90% between 2011 and 2023 to a low of 2.6%, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Saturday, while asserting that elimination of poverty is a commitment for his govt.

"A historic fall in poverty. A generational rise in opportunity... Gareebi hatao was never a slogan for us. It is our commitment. From more than 1 in 4 Indians to roughly 1 in 38 (in extreme poverty)," the PM posted on Instagram Saturday, citing the World Bank's latest numbers. He highlighted that nearly 50 crore people had moved out of poverty during these 12 years.

Besides, Modi added, employment had grown by 13.4 crore between 2017 and 2023, which was nearly twice the increase in India's working age population. "Inequality has fallen sharply. India's Gini index has dropped by over 20% from 29 in 2011 to 23 in 2023," the Prime Minister said in the Instagram post. The Gini index reflects how equitable is the distribution of income or wealth across a population, with a lower number indicating greater equality.

The World Bank's latest Poverty and Equity brief, released last week, said that the poverty rate in India, defined at $4.2 a day, will decline to 12.1% in 2028 from 57.7% in 2011, having fallen to 16.1% in 2023. Meanwhile, extreme poverty, defined as spending $3 a day, declined from 27.1% in 2011 to 2.6% in 2023.

"Strong consumption growth, rising employment, especially among women, and expanded social transfers drove poverty reduction, which is now increasingly concentrated among less-educated households with fewer assets, unstable jobs and higher dependency ratios," the World Bank had said.

## Govt starts testing DigiYatra for international flights in Bengaluru, 6 other airports

**New Delhi:** Govt has started DigiYatra trials for international passengers at 7 airports allowing eligible Indian nationals holding e-passports to use the facility at terminal entry points, security hold areas and boarding gates while travelling on select flights of Air India and IndiGo. Aviation ministry said trials are being held at Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Delhi, Cochin, Mumbai, Chennai and Amritsar. TNN


**GOVT. OF BIHAR**

**BIHAR COMBINED ENTRANCE COMPETITIVE EXAMINATION BOARD**
I.A.S. Association Building, Near Patna Airport, Patna-14.
Website : bceceboard.bihar.gov.in / Helpdesk : helpdesk.bceceboard@bihar.gov.in

**POST GRADUATE DENTAL ADMISSION COUNSELLING (PGDAC)-2026 for MDS in Govt./ Private Dental colleges of Bihar**

*Advt. No.*- BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/08 Dated : 01.11.2026

**Notice regarding Extension of Round-3 Online Counselling**

In continuation to Adv. No. BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/06 & 2026/07 dated 23.10.2026, it is informed to all eligible & interested NEET(MDS)-2026 qualified candidates and all concerned that in view of the Technical reason and Candidate's interest, the counselling programme for Online Registration & Submission of Application-cum-Choice filling / Consent for PGDAC-2026 is hereby extended as follows;

**Extended Important Dates for PGDAC-2026 Round-3 Counselling :**

i. **Last date** of online Registration ..... : 04.11.2026 (10:00 pm)
ii. Last date of submission of Application-cum-Choice Filling with payment through (Debit Card / Credit Card / Net Banking / UPI) / Editing of Application Form data / Editing of Choices ..... : 04.11.2026 (11.59 pm)
iii. **Consent** for Round-3 with Payment (if any) through (Debit Card / Credit Card / Net Banking/ UPI/ Editing of Application Form data/ Choice Filling/ Editing of Choices from such candidates who have already duly submitted the Application Form earlier ..... : 04.11.2026 (11.59 pm)
iv. **Publication of Rank Card** ..... : 10.11.2026
v. Last date of Choice Filling / Editing of Choices & Locking ..... : 10.11.2026 (11.59 pm)
vi. **Round-3 Provisional Seat Allotment Result publication** ..... : 12.11.2026
vii. Downloading of Provisional seat Allotment order ..... : 12.11.2026 to 14.11.2026
viii. Documents Verification and Admission ..... : 13.11.2026 to 14.11.2026

2. Rest of the terms / conditions for Round-3 Counselling mentioned in **Adv. No. BCECEB(PGDAC)-2026/06 Dated 23.10.2026 & 2026/04 Dated 02.10.2026** will remain the same.

**Controller of Examination**



**UJVN Limited**
Head Quarter: "Ujjwal" Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun -248006
Telephone Number: 0135-2523223, website: www.ujvnl.uk.gov.in
C.I.N. No. - U40101UR2001SGC025866

RO No. 1023 **Time Extension Notice-2** Dated : 31/10/2026

**INVITATION OF BIDS FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF SMALL HYDRO PROJECTS IN UTTARAKHAND**

Due to unavoidable circumstances various date of **Bid No. 05/GM(SHP)/UJVNL/2026-27, Bid No.06/GM(SHP)/UJVNL/2026-27 and Bid No. 07/GM(SHP)/UJVNL/2026-27** "Development of small hydro projects in Uttarakhand" invited by office of the General Manager (SHP), UJVN Limited, Dehradun and Expert (Technical), Urja Cell, Department of Energy, GoUK, Dehradun is hereby extended as follows:

| | |
|---|---|
| Last date of sale and downloading of RFQ cum RFP Document | 12.11.2026 |
| Last date for submission of completed bid document | 13.11.2026 (till 15:00 Hours) |
| Date of opening of technical proposal | 13.11.2026 (from 15:30 Hours onwards) |

All other terms and conditions of the above Bids shall remain unchanged. For other details kindly visit Nigam's website: **www.ujvnl.uk.gov.in**

**Expert (Technical), Urja Cell, Department of Energy, GoUK** | **General Manager (SHP), UJVNL, Dehradun**

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"



**PUBLIC NOTICE**

Notice is hereby given on behalf of our client that we are investigating the title of the following landowners **("Landowners")** with respect to the following plot numbers forming part of Survey No.129/1, situated at Banaswadi Road Extention, Jai Bharath Nagar, Bangalore-33, BBMP Ward No.59 (hereinafter, collectively, referred to as the **'Schedule Property'**). The Landowners have represented that they have absolute rights over the Schedule Property.

| Sl Nos. | Plot Nos / Structure | Extent (in square feet) | Landowner/s |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | 39 | 4770 | a) N. Munirathna, daughter of late M. Narayanappa; b) N. Balaram, son of late M. Narayanappa; c) A. Neela, wife of late N. Jagannath; and d) N. Srinivas, son of late M. Narayanappa |
| 2. | 40 | | |
| 3. | 51 | 5338 | |
| 4. | 52 | | |
| 5. | Mangalore Tiled House | 2600 | |
| 6. | 50 | 2318 | |
| 7. | 53 | 1912 | |
| 8. | 54 | | |
| 9. | 49 | 1964 | |
| 10. | 43 | 9744 | a) Ammaiyamma, wife of late A. Annayappa b) A. Chandra, son of late Annayappa c) A. Mohan, son of late Annayappa and d) A. Venkatesh, son of late Annayappa |
| 11. | 44 | | |
| 12. | 45 | | |
| 13. | 46 | 4012 | a) Ammaiyamma, wife of late A. Annayappa; b) A. Chandra, son of late Annayappa; c) A. Mohan, son of late Annayappa; and d) A. Venkatesh, son of late Annayappa |
| 14. | 47 | | |
| 15. | 48 | | |
| 16. | 23 | 2310 | a) Kamalamma, wife of late A. Muniswamy b) M. Renuka, wife of V. Devaraj; c) M. Lakshmipathy, son of late A. Muniswamy; and d) M. Manju Kumar, son of late A. Muniswamy. |
| 17. | 24 | 2156 | a) Kamalamma, wife of late A. Muniswamy b) M. Renuka, wife of V. Devaraj c) M. Lakshmipathy, son of late A. Muniswamy and d) M. Manju Kumar, son of late A. Muniswamy. |
| 18. | 25 | 2504 | a) N. Hemanth Kumar, son of late A. Nagaraj and b) N. Jayadev, son of late A. Nagaraj. |
| 19. | 41 | 6276 | a) N. Hemanth Kumar, son of late A. Nagaraj; and b) N. Jayadev, son of late A. Nagaraj |
| 20. | 42 | | |
| 21. | 43 | | |
| 22. | 56 | 5000 | a) N. Hemanth Kumar, son of late A. Nagaraj; and b) N. Jayadev, son of late A. Nagaraj |

Public is notified that any person having any right, title, claim or interest in whatsoever manner in the Schedule Property is hereby called upon to notify the undersigned in writing together with supporting documents within 15 (Fifteen) days from the date of this notice. If no such claims are received within the aforesaid period, it shall be deemed that the Landowners have clear and marketable title over the Schedule Property and our client shall proceed with the intended transaction with the Landowners with regard to the Schedule Property, as if no claims exist or if they have been waived or abandoned.

**Schedule Property**

All that piece and parcel of Plot Nos. 39, 40, 51, 50, 52, 53, 54, 49, 43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 23, 24, 25, 41, 42, 56 and Mangalore Tiled House forming part of Survey No. 129/1, situated at Banaswadi Road Extention, Jai Bharath Nagar, Bangalore -33, BBMP Ward No. 59 is bounded as follows:

| Plot Nos / Property | Boundaries | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | East | West | North | South |
| 39, 40 | Site No. 41. | Road. | Road. | Defence property. |
| 51, 52 | Site No. 50. | Road. | Property belonging to Munirathna and others (Mangalore Tiled House). | Road. |
| Mangalore Tiled House | Site No. 53. | Road. | Road. | Site No. 50, 51 and 52. |
| 50 | Site No. 49 | Site No. 51 | Site No. 53 and Mangalore Tiled House. | Road. |
| 53, 54 | Site No. 56. | Mangalore Tiled House. | Road. | Site Nos. 49 and 50. |
| 49 | Site No. 48. | Site No. 50. | Site No. 54. | Road. |
| 56 | Private property (Drain). | Site Nos. 54 and 49. | Road. | Site Nos. 46, 47 and 48. |
| 43, 44, 45 | Private property (Drain). | Site No. 43. | Road. | Defence property. |
| 46, 47, 48 | Private property (Drain). | Site No. 49. | Site No. 56 | Road. |
| 23 | Site No. 22. | Site No. 24. | Private property | Road. |
| 24 | Site No. 23. | Site No. 25. | Private property | Road. |
| 25 | Site No. 24. | Road. | Private property | Road. |
| 41, 42, 43 | Site No. 44. | Site No. 40. | Road. | Defence property. |

**Mr. Harsha Sudhindra**
**Partner**
**Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas**
Advocates and Solicitors,
Prestige Falcon Tower, 3rd Floor, Brunton Road,
off M.G. Road, Bangalore 560 025.
Ph No.: 080-67922000

**Date: 02-11-2026**
**Location: Bangalore**



**Karnataka Power Transmission Corporation Limited**
(CIN : U40109KA1999SGC025521)

**BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION**

(THROUGH KARNATAKA PUBLIC PROCUREMENT PORTAL ONLY)

No.CEE/T&P/SEE-1/2/2026-27/7594-630 Date: 28.10.2026

KPTCL invites Bids on electronic mode for the following works against following enquiry numbers on **Partial Turnkey basis.**

| Sl. No. | Enquiry Nos. and Name of the Works |
|---|---|
| 1. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4255:** Upgradation of existing 2x5MVA, 33/11kV to 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Mallapur village (Shirur)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 2.290 kms in Bagalkote Taluk and District. |
| 2. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4256: a)** Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **Agarabannihatti village** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of about 2.320 kms with High Performance Conductor (HPC) in Channagiri Taluk, Davanagere District. **b)** Replacement of existing 66kV **Benkikere - Devarahalli** SC line having coyote conductor by HPC Conductor for a distance of 15.680 kms from 220/66kV Benkikere sub-station to 66/11kV Devarahalli sub-station in Channagiri Taluk, Davanagere District. |
| 3. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4267:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Rajeev Grama** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 9.874 kms and construction of 110kV terminal bay at existing Shiggaon sub-station in Shiggaon Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 4. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4268:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Nittur** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 5.013 kms in Hirekerur Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 5. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4272:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Kunibenchi Village** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 3.083 kms in Ilkal Taluk, Bagalkote District. |
| 6. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4274**: Upgradation of 2x5MVA, 33/11kV sub-station to 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Bommanahalli** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 16.626 kms and construction of 2 Nos. of 110/11kV Terminal Bays at ongoing 110kV Akkialur (Balambeeda) sub-station in Hanagal Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 7. | **KPTCL/2026-27/TL/WORK_INDENT4287:** Construction of 110kV DC link on DC towers using Panther conductor from 110kV Yadgir North sub-station to 110kV **Honagara** sub-station and stringing of 110kV 2nd circuit line using Lynx conductor from 220kV Ramasamudra sub-station to 110kV Honagara sub-station in Yadgir Taluk and District along with construction of Terminal bays at both ends. |
| 8. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4286:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Tajapur(H)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 0.446 kms in Tikota Taluk, Vijayapura District. |
| 9. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4285:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **Madalagere(Bandri cross)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 9.315 kms in Harapanahalli Taluk, Vijayanagara District. |
| 10. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4278: Combined Package of the following works:** **Work-A:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **Narasimhagiri (Belligatta)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 0.679 kms in Kudligi Taluk, Vijayanagara District. **Work-B:** Construction of 66kV LILO line to 66kV **Venkatapura** sub-station from existing 66kV MSD (Munirabad-Sokke-Davanagere) for a distance of 0.952 kms and construction of two Nos. of terminal bays at existing 66kV Venkatapura sub-station in Hosapete Taluk, Vijayanagara District. |
| 11. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4277:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Arabhavi** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 0.5 kms in Mudalagi Taluk, Belagavi District. |
| 12. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4269:** Upgradation of existing 2x5MVA, 33/11kV sub-station to 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Mudenur** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 15.656 kms and construction of 2 Nos. of 110kV terminal bays at existing 110/33/11kV Tumminakatte sub-station in Ranebennur Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 13. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4270:** Establishing 2x20 MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Chalageri** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 18.169 kms and construction of 2 Nos. of 110kV terminal bay at existing Aremallapura sub-station in Ranebennur Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 14. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4279:** Upgradation of 2x5MVA, 33/11kV sub-station to 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Belagalapeth** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 8.664 kms and construction of 2 Nos. of Terminal Bays at ongoing 110kV Akkialur (Balambeeda) sub-station in Hanagal Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 15. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4276:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Hanumanamatti** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 2.414 kms in Ranebennur Taluk, Haveri District. |
| 16. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4284:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Wanadurga (Malagathi)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 1.559 kms in Shorapur Taluk, Yadgir District. |
| 17. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4288:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **G.Kodihalli** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 2.91 kms in Hagari Bommanahalli Taluk, Vijayanagara District. |
| 18. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4275: Combined Package of the following works:** **Work-A:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Nidasoshi** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of about 7.8 kms in Hukkeri Taluk, Belagavi District. **Work-B:**Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV at **Shekin Hosur (Bugate Alur) village** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 18.08 kms and construction of 02 Nos. of Terminal Bay at 110kV Nidasoshi sub-station in Hukkeri Taluk, Belagavi District. |
| 19. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4273:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 110/11kV sub-station at **Adakalabandi (Kodala)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 7.907 kms and construction of 02 Nos. of Terminal Bays at 110kV Gongadagi sub-station in Wadagera Taluk, Yadgir District. |
| 20. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4282:** Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **Kodihalli** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 9.305 kms and construction of 02 Nos. of 66kV terminal bays at ongoing 220/66/11kV Bharamasagara (Ajjappanahally) sub-station in Chitradurga Taluk & District. |
| 21. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4271**: Establishing 2x20MVA,110/11kV sub-station at **Kawloor(Shettikera)** along with construction of associated transmission line for a distance of 0.040 kms in Yadgir Taluk and District. |
| 22. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4342**: Establishing of 2x20MVA, **66/11kV** sub-station at **Belaghatta** and Construction of 66kV DC Line on MC/DC Towers from 220/66kV Chitradurga sub-station to Proposed 66/11kV Belaghatta sub-station by Utilizing Cross arm of existing MC Towers (up to Gunuru Limits) along with replacement of existing coyote conductor by HPC of ampacity 700amps conductor for a distance of 11.394 kms and construction of 66kV SC Link Line on MC/DC Towers from Proposed 66/11kV Belaghatta sub-station to Link existing 66kV Chitradurga - Turununu SC Line for a distance of 0.210 kms and Construction of 1No. of 66kV terminal bay at 220/66/11kV sub-station at Belaghatta in Chitradurga Taluk and District. |
| 23. | **KPTCL/2026-27/SS/WORK_INDENT4347**: Establishing 2x20MVA, 66/11kV sub-station at **Neralekere** in Magadi Taluk, Bengaluru South District with construction of associated 66kV Transmission line and Terminal Bays for a distance of 6.806 kms. |

The bids will be received through electronic tendering mode only. The details regarding participation in the e-tendering process can be obtained by logging on to KPTCL website: **https://kptcl.karnataka.gov.in** with hyperlink **"E Procurement KPTCL"** or **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in** on or after **04.11.2026 @ 15:00hrs** for the works mentioned at **Sl. No. (1) to (11) and Sl. No. (23), 07.11.2026 @ 15:00hrs for the works mentioned at Sl. No. (12) to (18),** on or after **11.11.2026 for the works mentioned at Sl.No. (19) to (21) and** on or after **16.11.2026 for the work mentioned at Sl. No. (22).** Last date & time for receipt of Bids and **any extension of Due date for Bid submission will be intimated in the KPP Portal.** Any details required in this regard can also be obtained from the office of the undersigned during office hours.

**All Corrigendum/Addendums shall be noticed by the bidders before the last date of submission of the Bids.**

**Sd/- Chief Engineer(Electy.),**
**Tendering & Procurement, KPTCL, 9th Floor, Indhana Bhavan, A.R. Circle, Bengaluru – 560 009.**


# EC to ease SIR portal curbs, allow tribunals to consider more docus

**Subhajoy.Roy**@timesofindia.com

Representation pic

The proposed changes follow objections from judges

**Kolkata:** Election Commission is likely to modify its portal to allow SIR tribunal judges to consider documents beyond the 13 listed and record observations while disposing of appeals, potentially ending a month-long deadlock in West Bengal.

The proposed changes follow objections from judges, who said they must be free to examine any acceptable document. No judge has uploaded an order since Sept 21, when EC introduced the portal.

The assurances have persuaded retired Calcutta HC judge Indrajit Chatterjee to withdraw his decision to step down from Nov 2. Chatterjee, who hears appeals from Murshidabad, had cited long commutes. "Justice Chatterjee is not resigning, he will continue to hear appeals. EC has promised to make amends that will allow the tribunals to function better," a tribunal source said.

EC is also considering allowing judges to authenticate orders through digital signatures instead of Aadhaar credentials. The commission may shift the tribunals from Joka in south-west Kolkata to a more accessible location.

The dispute centres on the EC's restriction of judges to 13 specified documents. While the SC's March 2026 order listed these documents, it clarified that the list was "indicative", not "exhaustive".

Judges argued that the portal's restrictions violated their mandate as quasi-judicial authorities appointed under SC order. They said they were free to consider any relevant and acceptable document for proper adjudication. A source said digital signatures would replace Aadhaar credentials.


**ASRTU**
ASRTU BHAWAN, Plot No.4-A, PSP Block Pkt.14, Sec-8, Dwarka New Delhi - 110 077
Ph.: 011-43294294 Extn. 406/414

**NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BID**
**NIT NO. 2/2026 - 275th SC (S&C)**

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| A | Tender Commencement Date | 02/11/2026 | 11 00 Hrs |
| B | Tender Forms request Last Date | 30/11/2026 | 11 00 Hrs |
| C | Tender Closing Date (CAT-1 e-submission) | 01/12/2026 | 11 00 Hrs |
| D | Tender Closing Date (CAT-2 - Manual submission) | 01/12/2026 | 17 00 Hrs |

**Cost of Tender form including GST Rs 3,540/- to be paid only at www.tenderwizard.com/ASRTU**
for more details of Tender Notice Visit **www.asrtu.org**



CAFRAL
Centre for Advanced Financial Research and Learning
Promoted by Reserve Bank of India

**Tender Notice**

Centre for Advanced Financial Research and Learning (CAFRAL). Promoted by Reserve Bank of India, is inviting tenders for the IFMS services at its campus in Mumbai.

For details and to download tender document visit the CAFRAL website: **https://www.cafral.org.in/tenders**

Any related corrigendum / amendments will be published on the CAFRAL website.

**Last date for tender submission November 30, 2026**

CONTRAPUNTO

One of the funny things about the stock market is that every time one person buys, another sells, and both think they are astute

– WILLIAM FEATHER

# Chips Are Down

*The pause might be temporary, but markets did well to reassess their AI play in Oct*

Secretly, many of us want AI to go away like a bad dream. We have no stomach for those noisy, thirsty and hungry data centres, 'chipflation', AI slop, and job losses. But AI is here to stay. That much is certain. What might happen – and looks probable after a sobering Oct – is that some of the market enthusiasm for AI might cool. We know a "bust" would be music to many ears, and if markets were rational it would have happened two years ago. For now, though, it looks like markets have turned sceptical.

So Apple, which has the least AI exposure among Big Tech, is back to being the world's most valuable company, ahead of chipmaker Nvidia. Yes, this Apple-Nvidia switch happened in July too, and sceptics might be reading too much into it this time, but there are other signs. Like Nasdaq's $2tn wipeout during the month. Or Alphabet's 12% share price drop on Thursday, S&P Global's negative outlook for Meta Platforms, and reports of OpenAI reducing its funding target by $10bn in the latest round. And while we weren't paying attention, Oct had started with data centre firm Firmus shelving its IPO in Australia after institutional investors didn't show interest. Suddenly, AI euphoria seems missing.

It might not be a case of cold feet yet, but anxiety is palpable among investors. Unlike 2024, when US Fed cut interest rates thrice, and Nvidia overtook Apple for the first time, 2026 is ending with the Fed in a hawkish mood. AI firms are increasingly raising money via new shares and bonds. Old investors hate new shares because they weaken prospects of future per-share earnings, while debt has to be repaid at all costs, and it's growing costlier. With AI investments approaching $1tn this year, the debt albatross is massive anyway. What if, investors are asking, a Chinese open-source model comes along and undercuts the US-centric AI business. It could drive down valuations sharply.

And that would have serious consequences for the global economy, because anywhere from 20% to 30% of US GDP growth today is AI-led. The Big Seven account for 35% of S&P 500. A sudden slowdown in US won't spare anyone, because US is the biggest market. For IMF, an AI asset price crash is among the top threats to the global economy right now. So if markets are looking wary, belatedly, that's not bad. We'll know their pulse better after Anthropic's upcoming IPO.

# Manipur, Again

*Armed groups of every ethnicity are letting down people. Govts aren't helping either*

Arestive Northeast is any govt's worst nightmare. What is unfolding in Manipur – massive protests, targeted killings – is too dangerous for Centre, state govts, and opposition parties, to not urgently make peace moves top priority. Immediate dialoguing interventions, and participation of top leadership, are vital to press pause on the bloodshed. Manipur has seen a flare-up in violence since Feb, when, reportedly, some tribes disagreed on strategy within their KukiZo umbrella grouping, and Naga groups joined the Meitei-KukiZo (Valley vs Hills) fight that has engulfed the state since May 2023, in the worst conflict in decades. Armed attacks, murders, retaliatory kidnappings, have spiked.

Issues are multi-layered and overlapping – Meiteis & Nagas reject Kuki demand for their region to be made a UT; Meiteis want the bar removed for them to buy land in the hills; there's distrust of Centre's paramilitary Assam Rifles; armed groups have plenty of funds, guns and vested interests to keep the state burning – the list is long, the terrain treacherous. What's clear is that ethnicity has morphed from a socio-cultural identity to each community asserting its rights to land and resources – giving new life to old grievances, and security concerns a dreadful fright.

It is just as plain that the violence belongs to armed groups in each community who claim to represent the full ethnicity. But, Manipur's civil society and ordinary people, in Imphal valley, in camps for the internally displaced, in the hills, have yearned only for some semblance of normalcy. To get on with their lives. Without fear. They have been let down on that promise of governance. Their sliver of hope that a framework, political and administrative, a peace deal, for communities to approach reconciliation and co-exist, lies shot. Manipur is, today, a state, where every community believes govts have been unfair to them. It's on New Delhi and Imphal to set that record straight.

# The Know-All Uncle

*How AI recast his WhatsApp life*

**Milind Ghatwai**

Once, he considered himself the life and soul of WhatsApp groups: regularly posting forwards, comments, and provocations, to keep the other members engaged. Less active and dormant members thought differently, but chose to humour him. He also built a reputation as the OG fact-checker, flagging anything and everything posted by others, which seemed remotely bogus.

His attempts to discipline the group did make him enemies, but he got a high every time he called out a fake, or a repeat forward, and the transgressor admitted to the mistake. Others, too, wanted to get even, but he had a lot more free time. Then things changed. AI-generated content arrived, changing the groups' power dynamics. The self-assigned gatekeeper lost his pre-eminent position. Because he had no domain expertise in platforms that value speed over accuracy. While members started sourcing content from new sources, he was stuck in a WA universe of the pre-AI era. He lost the first-mover advantage that once defined his existence. His type of content now had few, if any, takers. This digital extrovert retreated into a shell, unable to reconcile himself with his notional demotion. He stopped posting but thought of this as digital fasting, a sort of sacrifice and altruism, which would earn him *punya*.

No one branded him a *naraz fufa,* but they missed his eccentricities. Not everybody weighs artificially generated content on a moral scale. After dropping their jaw for a while, most consume it without much fuss. No matter how creative it was, he didn't.

The forwards look perfect, their language immaculate. He bided his time because he couldn't make out whether what others were now sharing was real or not. Then, one day, a smile flickered on his otherwise impassive face. The fact-checker morphed into a conscientious objector. Marking out AI posts for lacking true emotions, he adopted a freshly sanctimonious tone. He reckoned it a principled stand, and prepared himself for being called a neo-Luddite. Every AI fake now gave him his mojo back. The first correction he extracted was worth its weight in a doctoral thesis made without using any AI tool. Gradually, though, as most content failed his morality and authenticity test, silence blanketed his WA groups. Last heard, he was readying to create exclusive groups of diehards who share his nostalgia for non-AI content. He may yet become the admin of a group of one.

# Beyond Ramlila Maidan

*Congress-led oppn's high optics but episodic agitation against EC won't win polls. Organisational heft & listening to voters are crucial*

**Asim Ali**

On June 25, 1975, Jayaprakash Narayan led a massive 'Janata Front' opposition rally at Ramlila Maidan against Indira Gandhi. There, he articulated an extra-institutional protest strategy, to oust the "unlawful" Indira Gandhi govt.

Opposition bloc INDIA, with its mock impeachment of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, and its own massive Ramlila Maidan rally against 'vote chori', appears to be echoing the JP movement, adopting its repertoire of extra-institutional mobilisation against Modi govt.

The extra-institutional strategy consists of withholding recognition of legitimacy of democratic institutions, such as Parliament, higher judiciary, and mainstream media, as they are presently constituted. It comprises going back to public spaces to mobilise the people in defence of democracy.

Hence, the setting up of the parallel 'opposition' parliamentary session on the lawns of Congress chief Kharge, presided over by former Lok Sabha speaker Meira Kumar, to impeach CEC.

But this strategy carries its own risks. In effect, opposition is playing a two-level strategic game. At one level, it competes in elections under rules of the game as they exist. At the same time, it questions the very legitimacy of the system, and pushes for reform of the rules of the game, that is, conditions under which elections take place.

Since opposition parties have limited organisational resources, risk is over-investment of time and effort in the second (protest-mobilisational) level, could undermine performance at the first (electoral) level. There are three specific mechanisms through which an over-reliance on protest strategy, to contest legitimacy of govt, can divert resources away from building an effective political platform to fight elections.

Firstly, extra-institutional mobilisation can increase opposition's dependence on negative coalition-building. This can dilute the distinctive identity and programme of individual parties. When the principal objective becomes challenging incumbent's legitimacy, ideologically diverse parties can unite, without resolving differences over political programmes. This can also concentrate decision-making and agenda-setting among a small coterie of opposition party brass.

We see this happening in Bengal. TMC has imploded, not just because of coercive actions of state's new BJP govt, but also because, many of TMC veterans and cadres were not motivated by a commitment to a political programme, outside the pursuit of power and wealth.

The 'vote chori' campaign offers Mamata Banerjee an expedient way to keep the party's revival centred on her personal charisma, without having to undertake the harder task of rebuilding its organisational roots, and renewing its links with social constituencies, through a programmatic agenda.

Similarly, Congress, in enlisting Didi's help in projecting a united INDIA's 'vote chori' campaign nationally, may have to give up the opportunity to expand its organisational presence in Bengal. Reported attempts by Congress high command to explore an alliance with

TMC, despite resistance from much of its West Bengal leadership, illustrate how opposition's coordination at the national level can take precedence over rebuilding party's independent political base. As Congress's state brass understands, this is precisely the time to push through Congress's revival in Bengal through grassroots mobilisation efforts among constituencies, such as Muslims and Dalits, at the expense of the disintegrating TMC.

Second, an extra-institutional mobilisation strategy can increase opposition's dependence on negative polarisation against govt, at the expense of developing its own political agenda. Rather than building support across constituencies, by taking up a range of political issues, and offering an attractive political programme, opposition parties risk concentrating their limited organisational resources on generating popular anger against the incumbent, over a couple of headline issues.

Take the Congress campaign in Bihar last year. In the run-up to Bihar election, it devoted most of its organisational resources to 'Voter Adhikar Yatra', protesting SIR. From an organisational standpoint, the yatra was a success: Rahul Gandhi led a 1,300-km march across 20 districts over two weeks, culminating in a massive rally at Patna's Gandhi Maidan.

The yatra drew huge crowds, buoying Congress's expectations of growth in the state. That was belied by the results of the election, where Congress won 6 out of 61 seats it contested. The predominant focus on 'vote chori' might have stirred crowds, but ordinary voters of Bihar cast their votes on everyday concerns of jobs, caste, welfare and public services. In hindsight, organisational resources of Congress and wider INDIA coalition, may have been better spent in building themselves as an attractive alternative to the two-decade-old JDU-BJP regime.

Third, episodic extra-institutional mobilisation that reacts to govt scandals, can generate a lot of political energy and media visibility, but it does not contribute to sustained organisational building. Unlike grassroots mobilisation around concrete grievances of specific constituencies, campaigns like 'vote chori' do little to build durable social relationships, or activist networks, which can sustain the party, beyond episodic mobilisation.

Congress managed to effect this organisational renewal very effectively in Telangana. In the year before assembly election, the state unit, moribund until then, undertook an intense mobilisation drive, forging partnerships with Dalit and tribal social movements and building networks with veteran activists from the statehood movement. This process was further energised by Bharat Jodo Yatra. Subsequently, political and business elites flocked back to Congress, culminating in a remarkable turnaround as Congress won office, in the state, for the first time.

Opposition has every right to make a coordinated push for reforms in the electoral process to ensure free and fair elections. But in playing a two-level game, competing in elections while simultaneously pushing for institutional reform, it must ensure its strategy does not become distorted in favour of one, at the expense of the other. It must continue to mobilise public opinion against govt's policies, and not just challenge its legitimacy, while building itself up as a credible alternative govt-in-waiting.

*The writer is a political researcher*

# 'If Democrats Win House & Senate, We'll Probably See A Lot Of Probes Against Trump Admin Officials'

*On the verge of US midterms, defence security researcher and a former Regional Director on Trump's 2024 presidential campaign,* ***Sean Nottoli****, spoke with* ***Rudroneel Ghosh*** *about possible election outcomes, Iran, and how Trump is actually trying to preserve the liberal world order.*

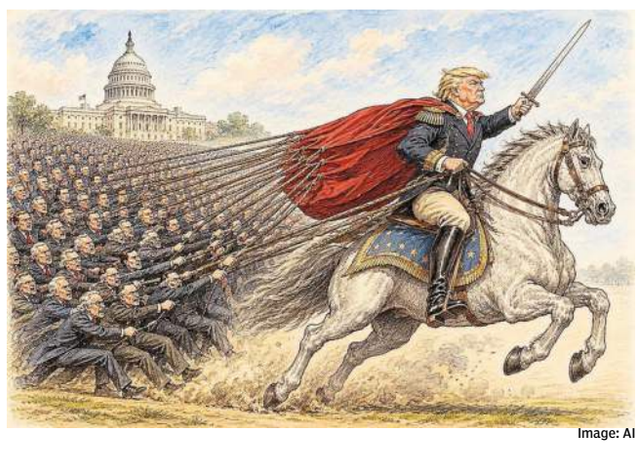


Image: AI

Q&A

**● Are we looking at a potential flipping of US Congress?**

Almost every president has lost the midterms. So, going by historical trends, we would most likely expect Democrats to get a majority in the House. And with competitive Senate races in Texas, South Carolina, Michigan, it's possible that Democrats could end up getting a 55-seat majority in the Senate. If that were to happen, I have heard there are staffers among Democrats, and candidates, who are looking to launch investigations, to begin impeachment proceedings against Pete Hegseth, and probably do investigations against President Trump. We will probably see a lot of probes against Trump administration officials.

**● How would it impact Trump admin policies?**

Democrats would definitely be pushing Trump to be more aggressive with Russia. They are not happy about the waiver for countries under the Lindsey Graham Act. They are not happy about Trump importing diesel from Russia. That will be the biggest push foreign policy-wise.

**● What about Iran, will Trump restart full-scale war?**

If Democrats win Congress, it will definitely have an impact on the Iran situation. A lot of Americans are not happy about the Iran war, including Republicans, and they are absolutely going to try to stop Trump from restarting that war.

**● Can they actually stop him?**

I think Trump will continue to do what he thinks is right for the American people, and he thinks taking care of Iran, once and for all, is part of that. I think there is a good possibility that Trump will continue strikes on Iran regardless of midterm results. And if that happens, you are going to see a lot of political backlash in US, and a lot of arguments over the Gulf of Tonkin resolution, and presidential powers and authority.

**● Won't Republicans push back if fuel prices rise further?**

Some have pushed back already, and there will be a backlash. But I don't know or haven't seen who among the Republicans will lead that charge.

**● If midterms go badly, will people within the administration take a position against Trump?**

I don't see people within the party, at this stage, even after midterms, making themselves anti-Trump, or standing up to Trump. There's a consensus within the administration that this is the Trump administration, and Trump is President. Everyone serves at the pleasure of the president. If there are any disagreements with policies, I think they'll continue to be behind closed doors. But closer to 2028, you will have people, like the eventual Republican candidate, say this is where I am like Trump, and this is where I'm different from him.

**● What could an Iran escalation look like?**

I think the only people who know are Trump and Hegseth. What I can expect is possible uses of MOABs. Whether he plans attacks on Iranian energy infra, naval targets, or sanctions everyone who's doing business with Iran, I can definitely see we're escalating things further from that.

**● But application of sanctions has been inconsistent, as we have seen with Russia, China and India.**

People need to realise we are living in an increasingly chaotic world. We've had this incredible period of relative stability since the fall of Soviet Union. And now we're getting back to sort of pre-WW1 world order, where you have Great Power competition, multiple states fighting to create a multipolar world.

And it's hard to be consistent on everything, because we don't want any of these nations causing a ruckus. We don't want a change to the status quo. There are certain moves and things you have to do in order to maintain the status quo, and that might be seen as inconsistent. It's the same thing with the Russia-Ukraine war, where you have France, which has been continuously importing LNG from Russia since the start of war, while pushing for sanctions on Russia.

So, we're all being forced to adapt. We're all working towards the ideal of preserving the global order, and sometimes that seems like it's inconsistent. I know people like to say that Trump is getting rid of the status quo. No, we're trying to preserve the status quo. These moves are being made to try to keep the peace, and try to preserve this liberal world order.

**Calvin & Hobbes**

**Sacred***space*

*People are always blaming their circumstances for what they are. I don't believe in circumstances. The people who get on in this world are the people who get up and look for the circumstances they want, and if they can't find them, make them.*

**George Bernard Shaw**

# Don't Let Politicians Hijack Your Student Years

**Osho**

I am not a politician, and i believe that there is politics involved in what both sides say: those in power and those outside it. Those who tell students to participate in politics have their own political motives. And those who tell them to stay away from politics are also making a political statement. Both positions are political.

But this is how i see it: a student is preparing for life. He should not plunge into life just yet; he should prepare himself for it. He should understand politics thoroughly. There is no need for him to participate in politics at this stage. He needs to understand it so that when the time comes for him to enter politics, he cannot be exploited by politicians.

I would like to tell students that their greatest responsibility is to raise the intellectual and creative potential of their country to ever greater heights. The country provides them with food, clothing, and other necessities for as many as twenty-five years so that their talents can develop.

But if they spend their academic years shouting slogans for political leaders, carrying their flags, and cheering them on, they are doing great harm both to their country and to themselves. I am absolutely opposed to students participating in politics. I oppose it because, once a student becomes involved in politics, he ceases to be a student in the true sense of the word.

THE SPEAKING TREE

Image: AI

Yes, students should study politics and understand it thoroughly. Then, when they turn twenty-five, leave the university, and enter the world of practical life, no second-rate politician should be able to deceive or exploit them.

Politicians who are not in power will continue urging students to join politics. But why are they so eager to attract students? The reason is simple: students are a source of power. Whoever gets students on his side gains enormous strength, whether his cause is right or wrong. That is why young people have always been exploited. If Indian students were to study politics seriously, they would be astonished by what goes on in the name of politics in this country…

Who will develop this political awareness in India? It is the coming generation. If young people learn to understand politics properly, genuine political awareness will emerge. It is unfortunate that a political party can win an election simply because of its election symbol. Symbols can be remarkably influential. Someone can go into a village and tell the people, "If there are no bullocks, how will you plough your fields?" The poor farmer thinks, "That is true! If there are no bullocks, how will i cultivate my land?" And so he votes for the pair of bullocks.

When political awareness is so limited, it is essential for India's young people to become well-informed and politically mature. The sooner you plunge into politics, the less mature you are likely to be. Wait! Study, learn, observe, understand, and look at life from every angle. Study world history, examine the way the world functions today, and think about what needs to be done ...The time to act will come; prepare yourselves for it.

*Translated from Bharat ke Jalte Prashna; Courtesy Osho International Foundation/www.osho.com*

# ‘US billionaires saw supporting knowledge as a statement of arrival — this also shaped science’

*Lukas Rieppel is Associate Professor of History & Faculty Director of the Native American Studies and Indigenous Studies Initiative at Brown University. Speaking with Srijana Mitra Das at Times Evoke, he discussed how the growth of scientific knowledge intersected with the rise of billionaires in America’s ‘Gilded Age’ — and why the super-rich began turning to philanthropy for institutions of learning:*

**What is the core of your research?**

■ I’m a historian of science and I also work in an interdisciplinary field called Science Technology Studies (STS). The basic premise of both fields is to think about how the history and current practice of science are entangled with broader social, cultural, political and economic issues. People often think science is distinct or separate from the rest of society — many scholars like myself are interested in figuring out the opposite of that. Science is not separate from the rest of society — rather, there are connections between the content of scientific knowledge, how scientists work, the ideas they produce and how those are related to or entangled with broader social, cultural, political and economic history.

**You write on how vertebrate paleontology got linked with the rise of American capitalism — can you elaborate?**

■ A lot of my work is on the history of paleontology and how this connected to capitalism and imperialism in North America. The United States, created 250 years ago, became an economic power particularly in the second half of the 19th century, after the bloody Civil War fought over the enslavement of African people. Much of what fueled its post-Civil War economic rise was the expansion of an industrial economy, made possible by new developments in scientific fields like phy-sics and chemistry but also, the extraction of mineral resources.

As it turned out, the United States was especially rich in mineral resources that were very important for building an industrial economy. Many American capitalists who created tremendous wealth in the 19th century were involved in mineral extraction — and that became deeply tied with paleontology, the scientific study of prehistoric fossils. These were often discovered by people in mining, especially prospectors looking for gold, silver, coal, copper, etc. In their searches, they’d stumble across prehistoric fossils. Hence, the rise of the extractive economy in the 19th century boosted the scientific study of fossils.

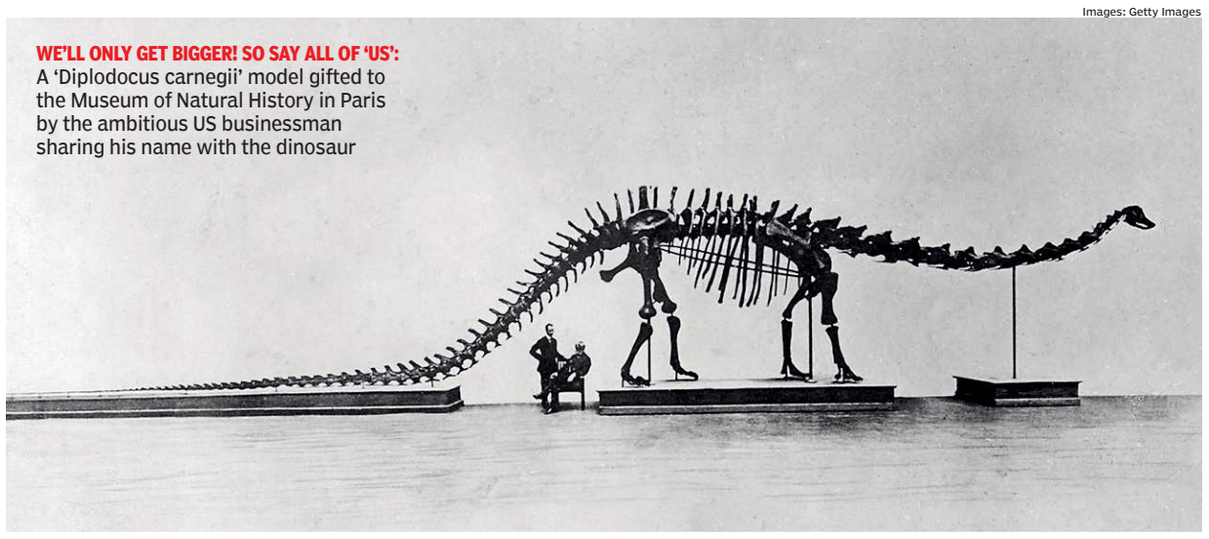
UNDERGROUND: US miners provided the material basis for wealth and science

Fossils also played an important role in mining — they can tell you the age of various rocks and thus, they became important clues for where to find rich minerals. Further, the people who profited enormously from the rise of this industrial extractive economy developed a cultural fascination with fossils that were dug up as a result of mining. They began lavishly funding museums in urban centres like New York City, Chicago and Pittsburgh, where such fossils were put on display.

**Can you tell us about these American industrialists?**

■ The best example is Andrew Carnegie, a fascinating figure who exemplifies much of what made this late 19th century period in American capitalism so distinctive. Carnegie was born to a family of handloom weavers in Scotland. His parents became economically destitute due to a new technological innovation — steam power. Once steam power was used in the textile industry, many handloom weavers, like Carnegie’s parents, were put out of work. A large political protest movement, Ludditism, grew in Britain, with people objecting to new technologies being brought into industry and ruining working-class people.

Images: Getty Images



WE’LL ONLY GET BIGGER! SO SAY ALL OF ‘US’: A ‘Diplodocus carnegii’ model gifted to the Museum of Natural History in Paris by the ambitious US businessman sharing his name with the dinosaur

Carnegie came out of that background. His parents moved to the United States for a brighter future — and there, Andrew succeeded beyond anyone’s wildest dreams, becoming the richest person in the US and among the wealthiest people alive at the turn of the 20th century. He made his fortune off the extractive economy, especially steel manufacturing. Using that wealth, Andrew Carnegie became a famous philanthropist and built several cultural institutions, including a natural history museum in Pittsburgh, where his parents had settled.

Curators of the ‘Carnegie Museum of Natural History’ began looking for a star specimen, a show-stopping centrepiece — they found a dinosaur in Wyoming, discovered by William Harlow Reed who’d worked for the Union Pacific Railroad and was thus connected to the industrial economy. They brought this fossil to Pittsburgh and attached Carnegie’s name to it, calling it ‘Diplodocus carnegii’, Latinising the industrialist’s name in the scientific literature. This was placed in the grand hall of the Pittsburgh Natural History Museum — Carnegie was so pleased with this majestic dinosaur in his museum, he tasked his curators with manufacturing plaster-cast replicas of it on a quasi-industrial scale. Carnegie then went across the world, depositing replicas of this dinosaur bearing his name in the most famous museums, including the British Museum in London and others in Paris, St. Petersburg, Berlin, Madrid, Argentina, etc. Carnegie used the dinosaur as a way of broadcasting what he understood to be the exceptional promise of the United States. This was not lost on anyone — a lot of newspaper coverage commented on how the dinosaur’s massive size seemed to represent something significant about the industrial and political ambitions of the United States.

THE GREAT CARNEGIE: Andrew Carnegie defined the Gilded Age billionaire

**How did billionaire philanthropy in science then intersect with economic tensions?**

■ This period of reconstruction after the American Civil War is often called the Gilded Age. It was an era of tremendous economic expansion. However, it wasn’t called the ‘Golden Age’ — it’s the ‘Gilded Age’ because it was felt the benefits of industrialisation were not running very deeply across society. Some people were gaining enormously from industrial capitalism but many weren’t — in fact, working-class people did not see their prospects improve much. Wages were relatively stagnant and there was economic uncertainty, even moments when real wages declined.

There was also mass migration taking place from Europe and China to the US then. Many migrants, especially from Europe, brought radical ideas about socialism and communism. The picture — stagnant wages, tremendous wealth inequality, horrific, dangerous and unhealthy conditions workers faced versus the amazing growth of wealth among the Gilded Age elite — was stark. The importing of radical political ideas, invoking people like Karl Marx, created an intellectual landscape of dissent. Thus, this also became a time of labour organising and fairly open class warfare.

Against this backdrop, American capitalism was experiencing great ideological crisis — and Gilded Age industrialists like Andrew Carnegie turned to philanthropy. Associating with institutions of learning and culture like universities, museums, libraries and halls for classical music was a way forward for someone like Carnegie, who came from a fairly humble working-class background. Many of these capitalists did not come from established wealth — they were ‘new money’ and had to find ways of performing their social distinction, signaling their new status often by backing institutions of culture and learning.

THE SPINE: Steel was a booming US extractive industry

Another reason was that by funding cultural institutions, they could argue that American capitalism —which was so controversial — was producing public goods in addition to private profits. The suggestion was, American industry was not only benefiting the wealthy few but improving all of society. Carnegie was deeply interested in publishing in such arguments. Carnegie himself wrote copiously, including, most famously, an essay called ‘The Gospel of Wealth’ where he said capitalism did mean tremendous wealth becoming concentrated at the top of the economic hierarchy. However, he wrote, that was a good thing because society’s productive resources being concentrated among its most talented and far-seeing individuals —such as himself — meant this wealth could be used well, as he was doing in the Natural History Museum. So, Carnegie argued through philanthropy, the productive capacity of capitalism could be unleashed, concentrated and redistributed to benefit working-class people as well. I leave it to you to decide whether you find that argument convincing or not.

**Lands containing mineral wealth belonged mostly to Native Americans — why were they absent from science and profiteering?**

■ The United States entirely owes its existence to the dispossession of Native Indigenous people from North America. All the lands from which mineral resources that fueled the United States’ growth, from where gold, silver, coal, even petroleum, were extracted, belonged to the native inhabitants of North America. The rise of America’s industrial economy is entirely based on the dispossession of American Indian lands.

However, the prehistoric fossils unearthed during the extraction of such mineral resources were used to write new narratives about ‘evolutionary progress’ — where ‘extinction’ played a key role. Now, as almost all dinosaurs had suffered a cataclysmic mass extinction event, they were seen as a model organism for studying extinction. Theories produced by late 19th century American scientists — using those dinosaurs — argued extinction played a necessary role in evolutionary advancement. They claimed nature had an innate tendency to progress — but extinction was a necessary part of that evolution and old lineages had to disappear for new ones to grow.

That same narrative was then projected back onto the native inhabitants of the US to fuel its economic expansion. Fossils extracted from Native American lands were used to justify the dispossessing of those same people by erroneously describing them as ‘naturally doomed to extinction’. Fortunately, Native American people have not gone extinct in the US. They contribute tremendously to American culture and science. Native Americans also knew about the fossils on their lands — but their scientific knowledge and ideas were displaced by such notions about evolution and extinction.

*Views expressed are personal*

OVERGROUND: Carnegie’s great-grandson, William, in a UK natural history museum

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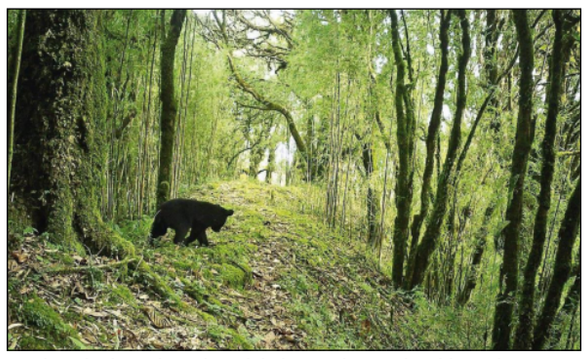
BRING THE WORLD HOME



# Hibernation shifts reshape bears’ diet in Himalayas?

## Asiatic Black Bear Hunts Red Panda On Cam

**Shivani.Azad**@timesofindia.com



Nowhere in the red panda’s global range has such evidence been reported earlier, said Pooja Kumari, the study’s lead author

**Dehradun:** Researchers from Wildlife Institute of India (WII) have documented what they describe as the first verified photographic evidence of an Asiatic black bear (Ursus thibetanus) preying on an endangered red panda (Ailurus fulgens). The incident was recorded at an altitude of 9,000ft in West Bengal’s Singalila National Park, which covers 78.6 sq km.

A peer-reviewed research study confirming the unique predation incident was recently published in Journal of Threatened Taxa. Pooja Kumari, the study’s lead author from WII, said black bears are opportunistic feeders whose diets could vary during periods of food scarcity. The incident, recorded in Feb, raised questions about shortening hibernation periods and changing seasonal patterns, she said.

Asiatic black bears, classified as vulnerable on IUCN Red List, are omnivores that normally feed on berries, cherries, acorns, insects, squirrels and frogs, and typically hibernate from late Nov to March. Red pandas are also classified as endangered on IUCN Red List and they are strictly an arboreal herbivorous species.

Both share an overlapping ecological space. Red pandas are usually found between 6,400 ft and 14,500 ft ranges from the eastern to the western side at an altitude between 2,600 ft and 11,400 ft above sea level.

Highlighting the ecological complexity of this interaction, Kumari told **TOI** that “this is a natural history moment”. She added that nowhere in the red panda’s global range across Nepal, Bhutan, China, Myanmar and India has such evidence been reported earlier.

The authors noted in the study: “A predation event at a resting site is interesting, as red pandas use arboreal habitats as refuges, which may indicate that these refuges are not entirely free from predation risk.”

It stated that a sequence of images captured a red panda ascending a resting tree Betula utilis on Feb 11, 2024, and next day, the same camera recorded an Asiatic black bear approaching the site, climbing the tree and descending with a red panda in its mouth.

## Desi Bullet Train closer to reality as squeeze test nears completion

**New Delhi:** Paving the way for final production of the country’s first indigenous Bullet Train, B28, the “Squeeze Test” or vehicle body shell test of the first coach is underway and will be completed next week. Railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw witnessed the test at BEML’s Bengaluru facility on Sunday, **reports Dipak Dash**.

A squeeze test is a safety assessment to determine whether a train’s car body can withstand heavy external forces and pressure without excessive deformation or structural failure in case of a collision or crash.

“Squeeze test of the integrated car body is at final stage. After this, propulsion system will be placed and all electronic systems will be put in place. Subsequently, a climatic test will be carried out wherein the car will be subjected to tests at high temperature of 50 degree Celsius and negative temperature, and dusty and heavy rain environment conditions,” Vaishnaw said.

# Restoring fighter strength ‘foremost task’: New IAF chief

**Surendra.Singh**
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New IAF chief ACM Ashutosh Dixit takes charge

**New Delhi:** In his first address after taking charge as the new air force chief on Sunday, Air Chief Marshal Ashutosh Dixit said that restoring the sanctioned fighter squadron strength, accelerating indigenous programmes like Light Combat Aircraft ‘Tejas’ and fifth-generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), and strengthening tri-services synergy will be his top priorities.

“Tejas MklA and lI, AMCA, Indian sensors and Indian weapons are our highest priorities. We will fight with Indian solutions, and we will hold them in numbers that meet our operational demands. Our responsibility is to fight and win, but most importantly, it is to deter conflict through credible air power,” the 29th IAF chief said. He said “restoring” the IAF’s combat strength towards the “sanctioned level” will be his “foremost task” – as the number of India’s combat squadrons have fallen to 29 from the sanctioned 42, IAF is desperately seeking to raise the strength of fighters in its fleet.

Dixit outlined his core focus areas under the acronym VAYU, defining his ‘vision’ as vigilance and operational readiness, ‘aatmanirbharta’ (self-reliance), ‘yukti’ (tactical innovation) and ‘unity’ of effort across the tri-services.

On the current security situation, the new IAF chief said, “Our security environment remains demanding. In addition, the character of war is being reshaped by new technologies and systems like drones, long-range precision weapons, space, cyber, AI and the electromagnetic spectrum. The air force, while transforming into the force that India will need in the next decade, must always be ready to fight and win.”

Dixit also lauded his predecessor Air Chief Marshal AP Singh, saying the IAF displayed under his leadership what “precise and decisive” air power can achieve during Operation Sindoor. “I thank him for handing over a force in a high state of readiness,” he said. The IAF chief also underlined his priorities for the welfare of air warriors, Agniveers (Vayu), civilians, veterans, Veer Naris and their families. “Their training, professional excellence, morale, safety, welfare and dignity will have my personal attention.”

# 6 Indians stranded in Nepal after defying weather warnings

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Six Indian trekkers, including four men and two women, remained stranded in Nepal’s snowbound Upper Dolpa region on Sunday after allegedly ignoring weather warnings and leaving their guide behind to continue towards Shey-Phoksundo Lake. A technical fault in a Nepal Army helicopter delayed rescue efforts, while heavy snowfall linked to Cyclone Arnab made mountain trails inaccessible.

The six — Moumita Halder, Piyali Koley, Jajla Trivedi Kumar, Aditya Singha, Diplina Biswas and Rajesh De — became stranded on Saturday afternoon in Danigad, roughly 300km northwest of Kathmandu. Their destination, Shey-Phoksundo Lake, lies at an altitude of about 3,600 metres and is considered Nepal’s deepest lake, with an estimated depth of 145 metres.

Nepal’s Department of Hydrology and Meteorology had warned of rain, heavy snow and avalanche risks between Oct 29 and 31, prompting restrictions on high-altitude travel. Dolpa chief district officer Junu Hamal Dhakal said, “The group continued towards the lake despite warnings from security personnel and their Nepalese guide about worsening weather. They left the guide behind and pressed ahead as snowfall intensified, disregarding restrictions the district administration had imposed on travel towards Upper Dolpa. Locals also warned them that heavy snow could make the mountain passes impassable.” The guide alerted authorities on Saturday evening after losing contact with the trekkers. By Sunday morning, the administration had mobilised security personnel and sought helicopter assistance.

“We have located the area where they are stranded, and an Army helicopter is arriving to rescue them. We hope to rescue them soon,” Dhakal said. However, the helicopter stationed at Surkhet air base could not take off because of a technical fault, forcing authorities to arrange another aircraft.

## Justice lies in timely court intervention: CJI Surya Kant

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**New Delhi:** Flagging the importance of timely intervention by courts in crucial matters, CJI **Surya Kant** said the difference between justice and injustice was not in the final judgement but in whether the court intervened when “intervention was most needed”.

He underlined the need for the judiciary, particularly constitutional courts, to introspect to further improve their working and to make listing of cases “more transparent and predictable”.

Speaking at the platinum jubilee celebration of Kerala HC, CJI Kant said constitutional justice in India did not begin and end in New Delhi and its strength lay in the robust network of 25 HCs spread across the country, each entrusted with the duty of protecting rights and upholding the rule of law.

“It is in this context that I wish to emphasise the extraordinary constitutional significance of Article 226. Its breadth is one of the greatest strengths of our judicial architecture. While Article 32 guarantees access to SC for enforcement of fundamental rights, Article 226 empowers HCs to issue appropriate writs and directions not only for fundamental rights but also for other legal rights. This wide constitutional canvas allows HCs to fashion meaningful remedies across diverse legal, statutory, administrative and contractual disputes,” the CJI said.

# CAG flags unclear status of ₹3L cr cess on crude oil

**Pradeep.Thakur**
@timesofindia.com

**New Delhi:** The cess collected on crude oil by the govt amounting to Rs 2,93,948 crore till 2023-24 was not transferred due to non-creation of a designated fund, federal auditor Comptroller and Auditor General has said in a report released last week.

Only after its intervention, which sought for proper accounting and earmarking of cess proceeds, central govt during 2024-25 created Oil Industry Development Fund (OIDF) and transferred cess of Rs 17,730 crore to the designated fund, the CAG has noted.

There is, however, no mention of the status of the remaining fund balance. Normally, all such cess, not transferred to earmarked funds, are with the Consolidated Fund of India.

This is one of several case studies cited by the federal auditor in its report — Adding Value to Public Governance — which was presented to President Droupadi Murmu last week.

“This is a significant change in accounting/fund management arrangement relating to transfer and earmarking of cess proceeds on crude oil in govt accounts,” the auditor noted.

On Thursday, while speaking at an international seminar on emerging audit challenges and evolving role of federal auditors, in Hanoi, Vietnam, CAG K Sanjay Murthy highlighted “the importance of access to digital records and govt databases, standardisation of data, secure data-sharing mechanisms and institutional capacity for undertaking technology-enabled audits”.

Murthy outlined three essential prerequisites for digital transformation of audit: “a strong legal mandate for access to govt data; trustworthy digital evidence, supported by appropriate safeguards for information security and confidentiality; and institutional mechanisms for collecting, integrating and analysing data across public authorities”.

The CAG’s recent report includes studies on poor governance practices across govt departments and how the auditor’s intervention led to correction in policy practices and fixing departmental accountability.

TIMES GLOBAL
THE TIMES OF INDIA, BENGALURU | MONDAY, NOVEMBER 2, 2026

MICHAEL DOUGLAS SAYS HE'D LOVE TO ACT WITH JACK NICHOLSON: 'HE'S WELL BUT NOT WORKING ANYMORE'

KNOWLEDGE IS POWER ONLY IF MAN KNOWS WHAT FACTS NOT TO BOTHER WITH
— ROBERT STAUGHTON LYND

SELMA BLAIR APOLOGISES AFTER HER ARREST FOR 'INJURING' CREW ON A FLIGHT, SAYS 'I WAS FRIGHTENED AND ALARMED'

# Why 4 is the magic number in US midterms

Tomorrow, America will elect a new House of Representatives and over a third of the Senate. Republicans now control both. Four more seats each in House and Senate are all that stand between Democrats and control of the two chambers. Winning either would mean greater power to block legislation. For Republicans, losing the Senate would threaten Donald Trump's ability to secure appointments in his last two years as prez

## First, What Exactly Are Americans Voting For?

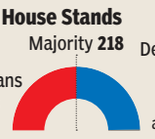
**Think of US Congress as America's Parliament:** It comprises the House of Representatives and the Senate. The House is broadly comparable to Lok Sabha, with members elected from constituencies called congressional districts. The Senate represents states: each gets two senators, regardless of population. Unlike Rajya Sabha members, US senators are directly elected.

House members serve two years. Senators serve six years, with roughly a third facing voters every two years. 'Midterms' simply means these elections fall halfway between presidential elections.

## The Big Numbers

**435** All voting seats in House are being contested

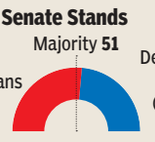
**How US House Stands**




**35** Senate seats on the ballot: 33 regular elections and two special elections

**4** Net Senate seats Democrats must gain to reach 51 and take control; the party also needs 4 seats more than their current tally of 214 to take control of the House

**How US Senate Stands**




**50** Seats Republicans need to retain Senate control, because Vice President JD Vance can break a tie

**36** States electing governors; three territories also have gubernatorial elections

*Special Senate elections are in Florida and Ohio, for seats previously held by Marco Rubio and Vance*

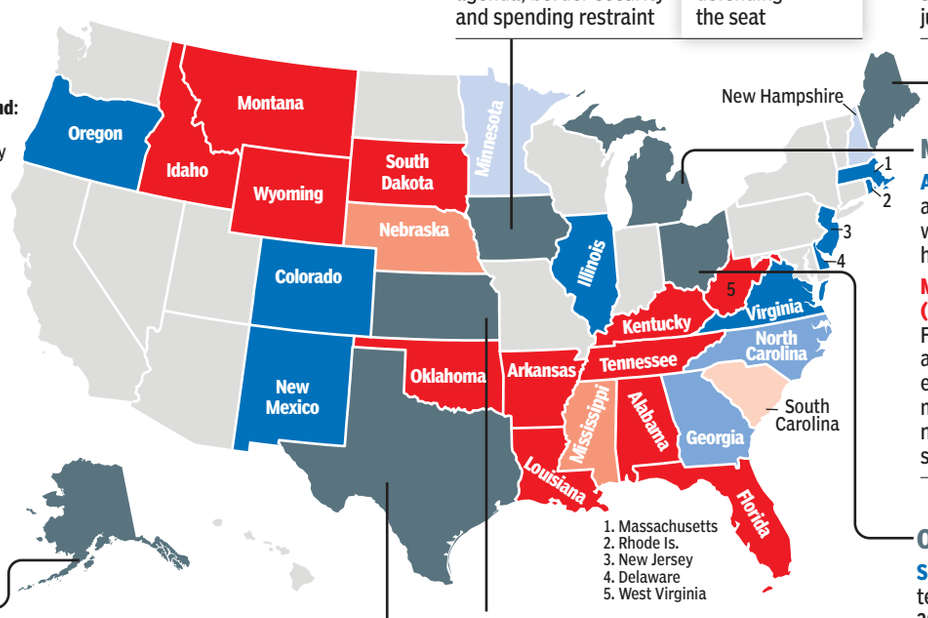
## SAFE SEATS & BATTLEGROUNDS

DEMOCRAT
REPUBLICAN

**Safe:** No competitive race expected
**Strongly favoured:** Upset is a possibility
**Edge:** But still competitive
**Battleground:** could go either way

**How to read the battle:** North Carolina is a Republican-held seat rated in Democrats' favour. Six of the seven battlegrounds are also Republican-held; Michigan is Democratic-held. Of the total 35 Senate seats going to polls, Republicans hold 22 and 13 are with Democrats

**Note:** Map shows only the Senate races, with 35 of the 50 states holding Senate elections this year. All 50 states will elect House members. But those contests are decided district by district, so labelling an entire state "safe Democratic" or "safe Republican" would not convey an accurate picture




### ALASKA | Republican-held

**Mary Peltola (Democrat)** | Former fisher and Congresswoman; combines support for oil and gas development with gun rights and public services

**Dan Sullivan (Republican)** Incumbent, former attorney general and retired Marine colonel; stresses experience, energy and defence

**The twist** Ranked-choice voting could prove decisive. Another Dan Sullivan is also on the ballot

### TEXAS | Republican-held

**James Talarico (Democrat)** | Former teacher and state legislator; stresses affordability and bipartisan work on prescription drugs and childcare

**Ken Paxton (Republican)** Attorney general and combative Trump ally; defeated incumbent John Cornyn in the party runoff

**The history** Texas last elected a Democratic senator in 1988

### KANSAS | Republican-held

**Adam Hamilton (Democrat)** | Methodist pastor campaigning on affordability and healthcare; backed by two former Republican governors

**Roger Marshall (Republican)** | Incumbent, obstetrician and army reserve veteran; Trump-backed, with a focus on farmers and taxes

**The history** Kansas last elected a Democratic senator in 1932

### IOWA | Republican-held

**Josh Turek (Democrat)** | State legislator and four-time Paralympian; has won in a district that also backed Trump

**Ashley Hinson (Republican)** Congresswoman and former TV journalist; campaigns on Trump's agenda, border security and spending restraint

**The opening** Republican Joni Ernst's retirement leaves no incumbent defending the seat

### MAINE | Republican-held

**Troy Jackson (Democrat)** | Fifth-generation logger and former state Senate president; stresses workers' interests and rural roots

**Susan Collins (Republican)** Five-term senator facing Democratic attacks over her support for Trump's judicial appointments

**The challenge** The only Republican-held Senate seat being contested in a state Kamala Harris won in 2024

### MICHIGAN | Democratic-held

**Abdul El-Sayed (Democrat)** | Epidemiologist and former public health official; progressive who's campaigning on universal healthcare, housing and affordability

**Mike Rogers (Republican)** | Former FBI agent, army veteran and Congressman; emphasises manufacturing, national security and support for Trump

**The stakes** Democrats must defend retiring senator Gary Peters's seat in a state Trump won in 2024

### OHIO | Republican-held

**Sherrod Brown (Democrat)** | Former three-term senator seeking a comeback after his 2024 defeat; known for his focus on workers and manufacturing

**Jon Husted (Republican)** Appointed to replace J D Vance; now seeking voters' endorsement

**The wrinkle** The winner serves only the remaining two years of Vance's term

## Indian Americans To Watch

**Amish Shah | Democrat**

**Arizona's 1st House district** | Emergency physician and former state legislator, he faces Rep. Jay Feely, a former professional football player

**Pia Dandiya | Democrat**

**Florida's 22nd House district** | Former teacher, principal takes on Rep. Casey Askar in a close race

**Vivek Ramaswamy Republican**

**Ohio governor election** | Faces Dem. Amy Acton, former state health director, in key fight outside Congress race

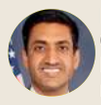
**Saritha Komatireddy Republican**

**New York attorney general election** | She is challenging Dem. incumbent Letitia James

**Nithya Raman | Democrat**

**Los Angeles mayor election** | City councillor and urban planner takes on incumbent Karen Bass

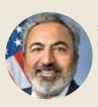
## Four Indian-American Are Seeking Re-election



**Ro Khanna (Democrat), California's 17th House dist:** Faces Rep. Ritesh Tandon, making this a desi duel

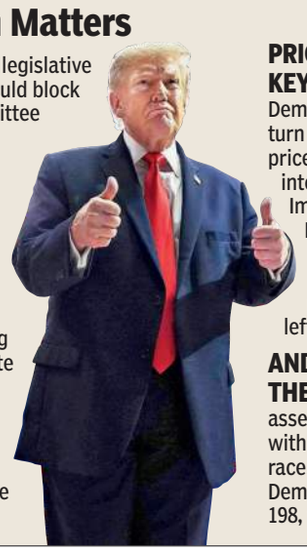
**Suhas Subramanyam (Democrat), Virginia's 10th:** Faces Republican Dave Beckwith and independent candidates

**Pramila Jayapal (Democrat), Washington's 7th:** Faces Republican Nirav Sheth, another Indian-American



**Ami Bera (Democrat), California's 3rd:** Faces Republican Robb Tucker

## Why This Election Matters



- The House controls a crucial legislative gate. A Democratic majority could block Republican bills and use committee hearings and subpoenas to scrutinise the administration. Budget negotiations could become more confrontational
- The Senate controls appointments. It can approve or reject nominees for the Supreme Court, senior administration posts, etc. Losing it would substantially complicate Trump's appointments
- Winning Congress does not give Democrats control of the presidency. Trump would retain his veto and considerable executive authority

**PRICES, IMMIGRATION KEY ISSUES**
Democrats are trying to turn dissatisfaction over prices and Trump's record into congressional gains. Immigration is also key with Republicans defending their record and warning about Democratic policy proposals and the party's leftward candidates

**AND WHAT ABOUT THE HOUSE?** Recent assessments show Democrats with an edge in the House race. One forecast gave Democrats 220, Republicans 198, with 17 toss-ups

## President's Party Tends To Be On Weak Wicket

1. History usually punishes the president's party. Across the 23 midterms from 1934 to 2022, it gained House seats only three times: 1934, 1998 and 2002
2. The two chambers can swing differently. In Trump's first midterms in 2018, Republicans lost 41 House seats but gained two Senate seats
3. Alaska could keep everyone waiting. Authorities say ranked-choice tabulations will not be available until Nov 18, after eligible ballots are reviewed and counted
4. Why a Tuesday in Nov? The timing has roots in an agrarian America: Nov fell after harvest and before severe winter; Tuesday avoided making distant voters begin their journey on the Sunday Sabbath

## How Indian Americans Count

**Influence in pockets:** Community concentrated in specific areas, like California's Silicon Valley, central New Jersey, etc, where their turnout could make a difference in close fights

**Leaning Democratic:** One survey found 66% of Indian-American respondents preferred a Democrat for the House, against 18% for a Republican. For Senate, the figures were 66% and 22%

**Pragmatic politics:** A Carnegie-YouGov survey found inflation and prices were the leading concerns, followed by jobs, economy and healthcare. Immigration, too, is key while just 2% named US-India relations as their most important issue

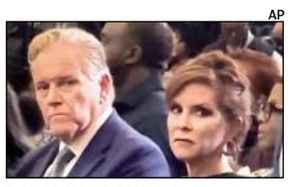
**Watch on Nov 4 in India** — and allow for a wait. Election night falls on Wednesday morning here. Close contests may take longer to resolve. The new congressional terms begin on Jan 3, 2027

# 'Becoming Mr Veto': Trump WH charts path to govern sans Congress if Democrats win

**Washington:** President Donald Trump said he may have to become "Mr. Veto" if Democrats win a majority in Tuesday's midterms, according to a clip of a New York Post interview aired Sunday on Fox News. "They'll be sending stuff up, you veto it," he said. "Eventually, after a month or two of getting all vetoed — you know, it's just waste — they come over and make a deal." It marks a rare acknowledgment by Trump that his party may lose the midterm elections.

Trump's White House, meanwhile, has spent months preparing to advance parts of his agenda through executive power if Democrats take control of Congress, with officials mapping unilateral action on immigration, tariffs and spending, according to a White House official and two people familiar with the plans.

Deputy chief of staff Stephen Miller and budget director Russell Vought have been working with White House counsel's office to identify measures requiring no congressional nod. White House counsel Will Scharf and his team are examining what Trump can legally do alone, where he could test his authority and how to defend decisions in court.


AP

**BREAKING RANKS:** In Michigan, Dem Haley Stevens (R) endorsed Republican Mike Rogers (L) in the Senate race after appearing with him at a Detroit church. The surprising move came on what was supposed to be a day of unity following public tensions with her former primary rival, Democrat nominee Abdul El-Sayed. Stevens was uninvited to a joint event the same day with El-Sayed. Stevens has been critical of El-Sayed's comments surrounding Israel

Vought is examining which priorities could proceed with money appropriated by Congress. He also wants federal grant rules changed to give political appointees greater say over which govt programmes receive taxpayer money, potentially increasing White House influence sans congressional approval.

Trump has used executive authority since returning to office in Jan 2025, imposing tariffs, intensifying immigration enforcement, and pursuing foreign-policy goals without congressional approval. White House lawyers have briefed political appointees on handling congressional inquiries and cautioned over written communications. AGENCIES

## Dems victory would shift Congress' trade debate but fall short of US tariff rollbacks

**Washington:** President Donald Trump's tariff agenda is unlikely to change even if Democrats take control of at least one chamber, trade experts and congressional aides said, because they would remain far short of the two-thirds majority needed to override a veto.

UNITED STATES MIDTERMS

Democrats could use control of a chamber to hold oversight hearings, investigate tariff exemptions and their impact on businesses, and stage symbolic votes to roll back duties. They could also revive Senator Chuck Schumer's "End Trump's Tariff Tax Act," which would repeal statutes underpinning tariffs on Canadian goods and temporary 10% global duties and refund collections under those laws.

However, William Reinsch of Center for Strategic and International Studies said no party was likely to secure a veto-proof majority. The administration is also preparing to rely heavily on executive action, including on trade, without congressional approval.

Trump is expected to pursue tariffs during his final two years, including measures arising from an investigation into excess industrial capacity among 16 major trading partners. White House spokesman Matthew Middleton said Trump would continue his tariff-driven agenda to protect American workers, farmers and businesses. REUTERS

# Binance covers 95% of stolen $6.3bn, resumes withdrawals

Binance, the world's biggest cryptocurrency exchange, resumed bitcoin, ether and some stablecoin withdrawals Sunday and said others would follow in phases, after it covered 95% of the $6.3 billion in tokens stolen from its platform.

Binance, which was founded in China, said the first phase of withdrawals would cover 15 crypto assets including bitcoin, ether, XRP and dogecoin. Binance said it had covered $6 billion of stolen cryptocurrencies by using company money to buy replacement tokens. The remaining 5% of stolen tokens consist of assets that are less liquid and may take longer to source in the required amounts, according to the exchange.

Reuters

Binance said it had covered $6bn of stolen cryptocurrencies by using company money

**FBI ties heist to N Korea**

The FBI said Saturday that the North Korean state-sponsored unit known as Trader-Traitor was responsible for the attack. Pyongyang has for years denied using state-linked cyber units for espionage, financial theft and revenue.

Law enforcement observed members of the unit converting stolen assets into the cryptocurrency ether, the FBI said in a statement, adding that it expected "further laundering" of the assets through the use of related technology. Richard Teng, the other co-CEO, has said that the breach was a "complex attack" involving a compromised laptop and malicious software designed to delete evidence of its activity, making it harder to trace and investigate. REUTERS

# Germany hit by protests, 100 cops hurt, shops looted

More than 100 police officers were injured and 54 people aged 13 to 29 were detained after rioters attacked police and looted shops in Frankfurt late Saturday following largely peaceful youth-led protests across Germany.

Police said 17 shops were damaged, five of them looted. The situation calmed early Sunday after officers cordoned off the city centre. Violence also erupted in Cologne, where cops used water cannons, and Berlin, where protesters threw bottles and pyrotechnics at officers.

More than 100,000 people had joined demonstrations demanding govt investment in education, housing and climate protection, and measures to make daily life more affordable. Organisers "Gen Z regelt" distanced themselves from the violence.

In France, authorities reported less violence than on previous protest weekends, though 779 people were arrested by Saturday night and police prepared for renewed demonstrations as schools reopen Monday. AP

# *La La Land goes Lal? After NYC, a desi socialist takes aim at LA*

**Chidanand Rajghatta** | TNN

**Washington:** For all the attention that the 2026 midterm elections in US are attracting over control of the House, Senate, and governorships, a municipal contest in California with strong political and electoral ties to India is challenging the Golden State — and America's — reputation as a bastion of capitalism.

The mayoral election in Los Angeles, whose $15 billion budget matches that of Costa Rica or Chhattisgarh, pits incumbent Karen Bass (73), against Nithya Raman (45), an India-born socialist councilwoman whose challenge has turned into one of the more intriguing political contests of the election season. Polls show the race currently tied, with Bass, a Democrat backed by the establishment, including California governor Gavin Newsom, Kamala Harris, and Nancy Pelosi, clawing back from a 10-point deficit in Sept.

If, however, Raman wins on Nov 3, LA will join New York City, now led by Zohran Mamdani, in having a mayor of Indian ancestry identified with democratic socialism. It would underscore the irony of two of America's most economically powerful, globally influential and famously expensive cities being governed by politicians from a movement that Trump and his political allies routinely portray as an existential threat to American capitalism.

Raman's story has Indian middle-class template. Born in Keralam, she moved to US at the age of six and became an urban planner after graduating from Harvard and MIT.

AP

Los Angeles mayoral candidate Nithya Raman in Santa Monica

She moved back to India in 2009, establishing Transparent Chennai, an urban research and advocacy initiative, and worked on sanitation and water access in the city. Returning to LA in 2013, she became involved in neighbourhood activism, particularly around homelessness and affordability. She is married to Vali Chandrasekaran, a screenwriter.

In 2020, Raman defeated an incumbent to become the first Indian elected to the LA City Council and went on to build a reputation for activism on affordable housing, tenant protections, and climate policy, eventually identifying herself as a Democratic Socialist. Her mayoral campaign centres around a simple proposition: LA is a spectacularly wealthy city that is somehow lousy at providing basic services to its residents. She promises more affordable housing, better public infrastructure and a more accountable homelessness programme, pointing to a nearly 50% reduction in street homelessness in her council district, even as the city's overall numbers have increased — a jab at Bass, whose term is dogged by rising living costs, infrastructure gridlock and persistent homelessness in the City of Angels.

There is, incidentally, an interesting Indian historical footnote to LA's — and for that matter California's and America's — flirtation with socialism. Long before Mamdani and Raman began making their mark in US politics, several prominent Indian nationalists and intellectuals had encountered the country's radical political traditions firsthand.

Lala Lajpat Rai spent five years in US between 1914 and 1919, establishing the India Home Rule League and publishing the journal Young India in New York. The radical humanist MN Roy arrived in US in 1916 as a global itinerant, encountered American radicals and began studying socialism, subsequently moving to Mexico City, where he founded Communist Party of Mexico in 1919.

BR Ambedkar studied at Columbia University in NYC, encountering some of America's leading liberal and progressive intellectuals, including philosopher John Dewey. And Jayaprakash Narayan spent seven years in America (1922-1929), studying at Berkeley, Iowa, and Wisconsin, where he encountered Marxism.

All this was at a time when socialism was enjoying considerable electoral popularity. In 1912, Socialist Party presidential candidate Eugene Debs won nearly a million votes, then about 6% of the national total. Socialists also held hundreds of municipal offices, including mayoralties. In fact, in the early 1950s Donald Trump's father, Fred Trump, clashed with the folk singer Woody Guthrie, an avowed socialist, over racial segregation and housing discrimination in Brooklyn, causing him to write a song — a scalding takedown of a predatory landlord — titled "Old Man Trump", who stirred up racial hatred "in the bloodsport of the human heart."

The subsequent "Red Scare" and the association of socialism with communism marginalised the movement, but almost a century later "the times they are a-changing." Of course, Mamdani and Raman represent a different generation and a more modern version of democratic socialism. Neither is proposing to abolish private property or install a Soviet-style command economy; their politics revolve around housing affordability, public services, redistribution, workers' rights and making the wealthy contribute more towards the common good.

# Pak LNG cargo hit near Hormuz had Iran's clearance

Pakistan secured Iranian clearance for LNG carrier Al Mayeda to pass through Strait of Hormuz, but the vessel was attacked near the waterway on Friday, people with direct knowledge said.

The Marshall Islands-flagged ship, loaded with Qatari LNG, subsequently turned back into the Persian Gulf, ship-tracking data showed. Indian shipping minister Sarbananda Sonowal said it was targeted in a projectile attack. All 25 crew members, including six Indians, were safe.

Operator Nakilat said the carrier remained operational. It was unclear why the cargo was attacked. BLOOMBERG

TIMES BUSINESS
THE TIMES OF INDIA, BENGALURU | MONDAY, NOVEMBER 2, 2026

# BANKROLLING THE GOVT

**Central govt bonds worth ₹128.2 lakh crore are in the market. Here is who holds them**

**The leader**
Banks still hold the most, at 33%, though down from 35.3% a year ago

**The anchor**
Insurers hold a steady second place, at 25.7%, barely changed from 26% a year ago

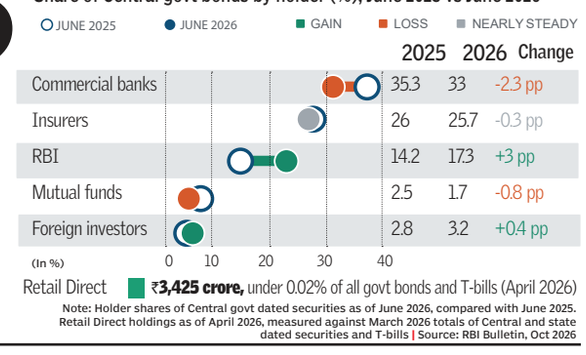
**The mover**
RBI's share has climbed to 17.3% from 14.2%, the sharpest gain among all holders

**The retreat**
Mutual funds have thinned to 1.7% from 2.5%

**The visitor**
Foreign investors remain small at 3.2%, but are edging up from 2.8%

**The newcomer**
Retail Direct holdings are up nearly 50% in a year to Rs 3,425 crore, but are still under 0.02% of all govt bonds and T-bills (April)

**WHO GAINED, WHO GAVE WAY**
Share of Central govt bonds by holder (%), June 2025 vs June 2026




Note: Holder shares of Central govt dated securities as of June 2026, compared with June 2025. Retail Direct holdings as of April 2026, measured against March 2026 totals of Central and state dated securities and T-bills | Source: RBI Bulletin, Oct 2026

# Festive tailwinds drive car sales to record highs in Oct

## Maruti, Hyundai Clock Highest-Ever Monthly Domestic Sales

Aabhas.Sharma
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**New Delhi:** Carmakers rode festive demand to new sales records in Oct. Growth extended beyond SUVs, with Maruti Suzuki reporting stronger car sales and supply constraints in CNG vehicles, although the durability of demand after the festive season will be the next test.

Maruti and Hyundai recorded their highest-ever monthly domestic sales, while Tata Motors narrowly edged past Mahindra in passenger vehicle volumes.

Market leader Maruti's domestic passenger vehicle sales rose 20.5% to 2,12,384 units. Its passenger car portfolio grew 18.4%, alongside a faster 26.1% increase in utility vehicles, suggesting that Oct's gains were spread across vehicle categories.

Small cars contributed about 40,000 units, said Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer, marketing & sales, Maruti Suzuki India. CNG sales stood at around 87,000 units, or about 40% of domestic volumes, with supplies still constrained. The scale of CNG demand underlines the importance of running costs in buyers' choices, even as manufacturers expand their electric portfolios.

Banerjee said Maruti was expected to gain market share over the next few months. For its e Vitara, domestic volumes were expected to remain around 2,000 a month through Dec as "commitments to other markets are there", he said.

Exports provided another growth engine for Maruti and Hyundai, rising 59.3% and 21.1%, respectively. Hyundai's domestic sales increased 16.7% to a record 62,799 units.

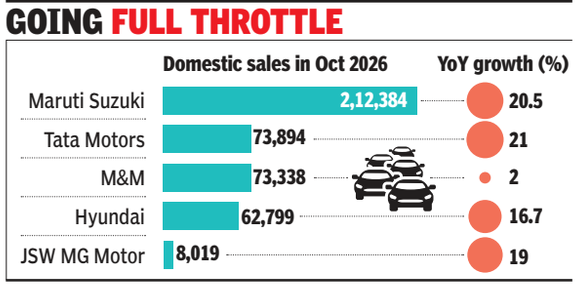
"Strong festive demand, coupled with healthy momentum in both domestic and export markets, helped us set this new sales record," Hyundai Motor India MD and CEO Tarun Garg said.

Competition below the market leader remained close. Tata's domestic passenger vehicle sales grew 21% to 73,894 units, just 556 ahead of Mahindra's record SUV sales of 73,338 units. Mahindra's growth was a more modest 2%, showing that record volumes did not translate into equally strong expansion across manufacturers.

Tata's electric vehicle sales, including exports, rose 75% to 16,244 units, increasing their contribution to its overall passenger vehicle business to more than a fifth.

Meanwhile, Toyota Kirloskar Motor reported domestic sales of 29,521 units in Oct and exports of 839 units, taking total volumes to 30,360 units. JSW MG Motor India's wholesale sales grew 19% to 8,013 units. Renault, on the other hand, surpassed its entire 2025 sales in 10 months, with Jan-Oct volumes rising 31% to 39,955 units. The next few months will show whether festive buying translates into sustained demand.

**GOING FULL THROTTLE**




### EV sales cross record 3.5L units in Oct

**Chennai:** Amid festive fervour, India's electric vehicle (EV) market clocked a record month in Oct, with registrations crossing 3.5 lakh units for the first time. Electric two-wheelers did most of the heavy lifting, notching up record sales and growing close to 50% year-on-year. Electric passenger vehicles (PVs) presented a more mixed picture: registrations jumped 75% year-on-year but fell 4% from Sept.

The final Oct tally could be higher, as there is typically a lag before all registrations are reflected on the Vahan dashboard. Even so, the figures available as of Nov 1 point to a landmark month for India's EV market. Total EV registrations across all segments stood at about 3,54,000 units in Oct, compared with 2,45,000 units in Oct 2025 and 3,38,000 units in Sept this year. EV registrations have now surpassed the 3-lakh mark for the fifth month in a row. Electric 2w registrations also hit a record high of 2,24,000 units in Oct, compared with 1,51,000 units in Oct 2025 and 2,09,000 units in Sept this year. TNN

# EPFO pumps ₹17k cr into equities in Q1, exposure at 11.2% in June-end

Shiva.Rajora@timesofindia.com

**New Delhi:** Taking advantage of the weak stock markets, the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) deployed nearly Rs 17,000 crore in fresh equity investments during April-June.

Equities accounted for 14.6% of the fresh investment across all asset classes and underline EPFO's reliance on stocks to generate inflation-beating returns for its nearly 30 crore members. It comes at a time when yields on central govt securities (G-secs) and state development loans (SDL), which account for more than three-fourths of EPFO's investments, have ranged between 6.5 and 7% in recent years.

EPFO's cumulative equity corpus rose to around Rs 3.7 lakh crore at the end of June, increasing the aggregate equity exposure to 11.2% of the Rs 33.2 lakh crore investment corpus, according to data discussed by the agency's investment committee last month. The agency is allowed to deploy 15% of its corpus in equities.

When the stock market recovers, the ETF units through which investments are routed are expected to yield strong long-term gains and enable the social security organisation to announce a higher annual interest rate.

In Q1, the social security organisation recorded no redemptions of these equity units, maintaining a pure accumulation strategy. Fresh deployment was led by the Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) at about Rs 12,000 crore, followed by the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS) at Rs 4,800 crore.

Overall, of the nearly Rs 1.2 lakh crore fresh investments made during Q1, short-term debt instruments and cash equivalents absorbed the lion's share (48%) of fresh capital, totaling around Rs 56,000 crore, through liquid mutual funds, TREPS, bank cash balances, and short-term FDs.

Long-term sovereign assets, meanwhile, which are the preferred form of investment by the retirement fund body, saw nearly 30% of the fresh assets deployed (Rs 36,000 crore) during the quarter. This segment was mainly led by EPFO buying Central govt securities, including ultra-long 50-year paper maturing in 2076, and state development loans (SDLs) with yields broadly ranging between 7.4% and 8%.

### FPIs pull out ₹34.8k cr from equities in Oct

**New Delhi:** Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) withdrew Rs 34,843 crore from Indian equities in Oct, marking the second consecutive month of heavy outflows, amid concerns over elevated crude oil prices, global interest rates and the corporate earnings outlook.

However, foreign investors turned net buyers towards the end of the month, infusing around Rs 6,300 crore during Oct 26-30 compared to net outflows of nearly Rs 2,700 crore in the week ended Oct 23. According to CDSL data, FPIs withdrew Rs 35,861 crore in Sept. Before that, they had invested Rs 20,200 crore in July and Rs 29,631 crore in Aug. AGENCIES

### UPI crosses record 25bn transactions

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

**Mumbai**: UPI transactions crossed the 25-billion mark for the first time in Oct, while average daily transaction value breached Rs 1 lakh crore for the first time, signalling continued growth in digital payments despite the debate over the introduction of merchant discount rate (MDR) charges.

UPI processed 25.5 billion transactions worth Rs 31.5 lakh crore in Oct, compared with 24.1 billion transactions valued at Rs 29.4 lakh crore in Sept. Transaction volumes rose 5.8% month on month, while the value of payments increased 7.4%.

The increase was also reflected in daily averages. Average daily transactions rose 2.5% to 822 million in Oct from 802 million in Sept, while average daily transaction value increased 3.9% to Rs 1,01,707 crore from Rs 97,913 crore. On a year-on-year basis, transaction volumes grew 23% in Oct, matching Sept's growth rate. However, value growth moderated to 16% from 18% in Sept.

The Oct numbers come amid a debate over the introduction of MDR charges, with some quarters raising concerns about the potential impact on merchant acceptance and cost of digital payments. The latest figures, however, show no immediate slowdown in aggregate UPI activity.

TOI IN THE CLASSROOM

## Gold FoF Curbs: What To Do In Order To Stay Invested In Yellow Metal

Several mutual fund houses have temporarily stopped accepting fresh investments into gold fund-of-funds, leaving investors wondering whether they can continue investing through existing SIPs, and alternatives available to them

**Invesco Mutual Fund**
An investor education and awareness initiative

For Know Your Customer (KYC) guidelines along with the documentary requirements and procedure for change of address, phone number, bank details, etc., please visit the Education and Guidance section on www.invescomutualfund.com. Investor should deal with only SEBI registered Mutual Funds, details of which can be verified under "Intermediaries/Market Infrastructure Institutions" on https://www.sebi.gov.in/index.html. For any grievance / complaint, please call us on 1800-209-0007 or write to us at mfservices@invescoindia.com. Alternatively, complaints can be registered on the SEBI SCORES Portal at https://scores.sebi.gov.in

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

### What Are Gold Fund Of Funds?

Gold FoFs are mutual fund schemes that invest in Gold ETFs rather than buying physical gold directly. When an investor puts money into a gold FoF, the fund manager uses that money to purchase units of a gold ETF. The gold ETF, in turn, invests in physical gold. As a result, a gold FoF's value generally moves in line with gold prices. They offer a simple way to invest in gold through the mutual fund route without needing a demat account. Investors can buy and redeem units like any other mutual fund scheme while gaining exposure to changes in gold prices.

### Why Have Some Mutual Fund Houses Restricted Fresh Investments In Gold FoFs?

Several fund houses have temporarily stopped accepting fresh investments in gold FoFs from mid-Oct. The restrictions include fresh lump-sum investments, new SIP registrations and switch-ins, though they differ across schemes. While fund houses have not disclosed specific reasons behind the move, industry participants believe it may be linked to concerns over rising gold imports and strong inflows into gold investment products. As these ETF units are backed by physical gold, sustained inflows into such products can translate into higher demand for imported gold.

### What Other Options Are Available Now?

Gold ETFs are one of the closest alternatives for investors seeking exposure to gold through market-linked investments. While there are restrictions on fresh investments in several Gold FoFs, there are none on their ETFs.

### Difference Between Gold ETFs And FoFs

Gold FoFs are generally more convenient for retail investors because they can be bought and redeemed like any other MF schemes without requiring a demat account. Gold ETFs can only be bought and sold through a demat and trading account. Gold ETFs typically have lower costs because investors bear only the ETF's expense ratio. In a gold FoF, investors indirectly bear the expenses of both the FoF and the underlying ETF. Gold ETFs can be bought and sold on exchanges, while gold FoFs are purchased and redeemed at the day's closing NAV.

— SACHIN KUMAR

### Innovatiview to invest ₹1,000cr in exam centres

**New Delhi:** As the Centre moves to overhaul public examinations, exam-security company Innovatiview India has announced an investment of Rs 1,000 crore over the next 18 months to develop standardised testing centres, targeting capacity for one lakh candidates in a single session by March 2028. The company's Aadarsh Pariksha Kendra network envisages around 150 centres across 100 cities, particularly in tier-II and tier-III locations where inadequate facilities often force candidates to travel long distances. The investment will be financed through 60% debt and 40% equity. Ashish Mittal, founder and whole-time director, Innovatiview, said the proposed network would enable about one lakh candidates to take examinations on computers simultaneously by March 2028. TNN

### G-Sec yields may ease to 6.75-7%: SBI

**Mumbai:** Govt bond yields could ease to 6.75-7% by March 2027 even if RBI increases benchmark interest rate by 0.5%, as lower borrowing and historical yield trends are expected to support the market, according to SBI Research. "India's 10-year G-sec yield could settle in the range of 6.75-7% by end March '27," the report said. AGENCIES

### BoB scales up cyber defences after attack

**Mumbai:** State-run Bank of Baroda has scaled up its cybersecurity framework across technology, personnel, and operational processes following a July 2026 incident, with overall IT defence spending set to exceed 10% of its operating profit, a senior official said. Some of the spends will be incurred in FY27, while some may go into the next fiscal. AGENCIES

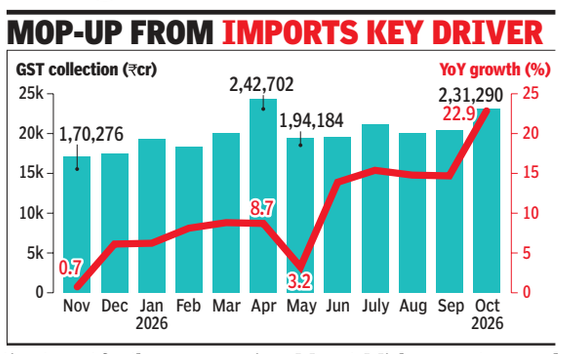
# Meghalaya, HP top GST collection growth chart

▶Continued from page 1

Sales had slowed in Sept 2025 in anticipation of lower rates kicking in from Sept 22. As a result of the pent-up demand, Oct 2025 saw strong growth. So far this year, sales have held up with sectors such as automobiles recording robust growth. The numbers for Oct 2026, based on transactions in Sept, pegged domestic GST collection growth at 15.8% to just under Rs 1.6 lakh crore, while integrated GST on imports jumped 42% to Rs 72,246 crore. Analysts see the increase in GST on imports as a result of higher commodity prices, although there was also a word of caution given that there has been a rising trend in recent months.

Refunds rose 6.5% to Rs 27,934 crore, and net collections were 25.6% higher at over Rs 2 lakh crore. The current trends point to the Centre surpassing its GST collection target for the year, a positive for its finances amid higher subsidy outgo due to the war in West Asia. "While the Oct numbers are encouraging, the more important test will be whether this momentum continues after the festive season. The focus now should be on sustaining domestic revenue growth and ensuring that the benefits of GST 2.0 translate into stronger compliance, smoother input tax credit flows and faster refunds for businesses," said Manot Mishra, partner and tax controversy management leader at Grant Thornton Bharat. Among the states, Meghalaya (32%) and Himachal Pradesh (30%) led the growth charts, with all states logging an increase, barring Jharkhand, Odisha, Arunachal Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. Among the large states, Uttar Pradesh reported a 20% rise in SGST mop-up in Oct, while Maharashtra (11%), Karnataka (16%), Tamil Nadu (8%) and Gujarat (18%).

**MOP-UP FROM IMPORTS KEY DRIVER**




# *Mfg divide: 10% factories account for 72% output*

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**New Delhi:** India's manufacturing sector suffers from fragmentation, with a small minority of large establishments driving output, while thousands of medium and small units are burdened with debt and low productivity.

Large factories, employing over 200 workers, account for 10.4% of total operational units, but generate nearly 72% of the country's manufacturing gross value added (GVA) amounting to Rs 15.9 lakh crore and provide 63% of industrial jobs.

In contrast, smaller factories, employing up to 50 workers, make up over 71% of all operational units but contribute 10% to overall manufacturing GVA. Units with up to 10 workers represent 36.3% of operational factories, but yield 2% of output, a recent study in a NSO journal, using data from the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) 2022-23, showed.

The GVA by the manufacturing sector in the country was estimated at around Rs 22 lakh crore in 2022-23. To accelerate industrial growth, policy experts frequently recommend facilitating the scaling up of smaller units through targeted technology upgradation, cluster-based supply chain linkages with larger firms, and easier credit access.

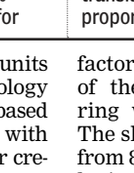
This productivity gap also coincides with a large debt burden on smaller establishments as factories with up to 10 workers carry a formal loan-to-GVA ratio of 85%, compared with around 39% for factories that have more than 200 workers. This indicates that while small units leverage significant formal credit relative to their size, low capacity utilisation and limited scale prevent them from translating that capital into proportionate output.

In terms of employing women workers, the ASI study underscores much sharper vulnerabilities on factory floors as merely 11% of the overall manufacturing workforce is female. The share rises marginally from 8.5% in factories employing up to 10 workers to 11.5% in large units with more than 200 workers.

A key driver behind the productivity divide is the sharp disparity in shop-floor enablers, such as research and development and worker training. Across all operating factories, a mere 2.7% maintain an active R&D unit, while only 6.7% provide formal skill training to workers. Adoption, however, the study finds, scales heavily with size. Nearly 12% large units operate R&D facilities and 20% offer formal training, compared to just 0.6% and 2.5% respectively among micro units (up to 10 workers).

**WHAT AILS SMALLER UNITS**

- Smaller factories, employing up to 50 workers, amount to over 71% of all operational units
- These establishments face large debt burden
- Factories with up to 10 workers have a loan-to-GVA ratio of 85% as against around 39% for factories that have more than 200 workers
- This shows smaller units enjoy significant formal credit relative to size
- But low capacity utilisation and limited scale prevent them from translating that capital into proportionate output



### 'Social media shapes India's drinking choices'

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**Bengaluru:** Social media is helping consumers decide where to go out and what to drink. As many as 82% of respondents visited a venue after seeing it on social media, while 66% tried a drink they discovered online, according to NielsenIQ's findings on India's beverage market.

The estimates draw on several NIQ consumer studies, with cited sample sizes ranging from 1,002 to 1,009 and 2,504 respondents. The sources include studies conducted in India and across Asia-Pacific. The beverage categories cover both alcoholic and non-alcoholic drinks.

"Consumers are curating their own drinking life across categories, multiple formats and a feed that never stops scrolling," Sujoy Das, NIQ's commercial director for India, said in the report.

NIQ said the average consumer covered by the research drinks across five beverage categories. Soft drinks featured among the usual choices of 68% of respondents. Beer and whisky were each cited by 43%, while 33% included cocktails.

The figures reflect overlapping choices: someone who drinks beer may also choose cocktails or soft drinks on other occasions. They do not represent shares of sales.

For beverage companies, this broadens the competition beyond rival brands selling the same type of drink.

# Costlier phones give refurbished devices a boost

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**New Delhi:** Refurbished smartphones are finding more buyers in India. Rising prices of new devices are pushing consumers towards cheaper alternatives, including older iPhones, helping the secondary market grow even as new handset sales face a slowdown. ControlZ (refurbished electronics retailer) reported 100% growth this festive season, led by the iPhone 13, 14 and 15 series, founder and CEO Yug Bhatia, said. He identified the Rs 30,000–50,000 band as its strongest segment.

"When an entry-level Android phone costs about the same as a like-new iPhone, most buyers prefer the iPhone," Bhatia said.

He estimated India's pre-owned smartphone market at about 5 crore units, with iPhones accounting for 15–20%. Supply was sufficient, he said, but the largely unorganised market needed to be organised to bring renewed devices to more buyers in smaller towns.

Cashify, another refurbished electronics retailer, said sales of refurbished smartphones priced above Rs 50,000 more than doubled, while trade-ins in that segment more than quadrupled. Overall, exchange volumes rose 25%, with the average trade-in value reaching Rs 15,105. The company also reported stronger growth in smaller cities. Trade-ins in Tier 3 and beyond grew 49%, compared with 39% across the six metros. Motorola and Google recorded the fastest growth in upgrade and trade-in activity, at 79% and 74%, respectively, while Samsung led in overall volumes.

The shift is also visible in the models consumers are exchanging. Cashify said trade-in activity was increasingly moving towards newer devices, including the iPhone 15, 16 and 17 series, indicating that consumers were upgrading more frequently and looking to recover greater value from their existing smartphones. The trend comes as India's new smartphone market faces pressure from rising handset prices, making refurbished devices an increasingly attractive alternative for buyers looking for premium features at lower prices.

### SWISS CEO: Capacity can't cope with air travel demand

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**Bengaluru:** SWISS CEO Jens Fehlinger said "capacity can't cope with the demand being seen in India." The airline has started flights to Bengaluru, the third Indian city for the Lufthansa group airline after Delhi and Mumbai.

The reason: Air India group and IndiGo have significantly cut long hauls to the West, primarily due to closure of Pakistan airspace for Indian carriers even as the demand for foreign travel to and from India remains inelastic and high. Once US-Iran war started on Feb 28, 2026, and all airlines had to cut flights to West Asia, many foreign carriers deployed their spare capacity to India.

The Lufthansa group, for instance, used to have 318 monthly flights to India by Lufthansa, SWISS and ITA Airways (erstwhile Alitalia) till Feb 2026. By Aug, that number swelled 9% to 344 and is expected to increase to 383 by Aug 2027. Will the additional capacity deployed to India be scaled back when West Asia reopens? "We are looking at India for long term investments and long term growth. It is the second biggest market for us after the US and our presence here will go only one way — up."

AP

LAKSHYA SEN BT JONATAN CHRISTIE 21-17, 21-10

TOI

PV SINDHU BT LINE KJAERSFELDT 21-12, 21-14

# SIN-SEN'S GERMAN HIGH

## PV Sindhu & Lakshya Sen Win Hylo Open Super 500 Titles, Make It A Double Delight For India

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Saarbrucken provided the perfect setting for two of India's biggest badminton stars, PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen, to rediscover their winning touch and end their title droughts in style. The two Indians made it a memorable Sunday for the country, clinching the women's and men's singles crowns with commanding straight-game victories in the finals of the Hylo Open Super 500 badminton tournament here.

Former world champion and double Olympic medallist Sindhu continued her impressive resurgence, producing a clinical performance to defeat eighth seed and world No. 25 Line Hojmark Kjaersfeldt of Denmark 21-12, 21-14 in the women's singles final. The 39-minute victory earned the second-seeded Indian her second title of the season, following her triumph at the Japan Open in July and a runner-up finish at the French Open last week.

A little later, Lakshya Sen completed India's memorable double, outplaying Indonesia's Jonatan Christie 21-17, 21-10 in the men's singles final. Though tested a little in the second-half of the first game, Lakshya did not break any sweat in the second game as he eased towards title triumph.

Sindhu dictated proceedings with a fine blend of precision, deception and attacking strokes, giving the Dane little opportunity to settle into the contest. The Indian, who enjoyed a 6-1 head-to-head advantage over Kjaersfeldt before the final, took the initiative early and maintained her grip on the match throughout.

"It was important for me to give my 100 per cent, irrespective of who the opponent was. We've played each other many times, and I needed to focus on every point. Every point mattered to me. I took the lead from the beginning and didn't give her a chance," Sindhu said after her victory.

The world No. 8 collected 9,200 ranking points, giving her a significant boost in the race to qualify for the season-ending World Tour Finals.

The title was particularly satisfying for Sindhu, who acknowledged the role of her support team in helping her overcome a difficult phase. "This gives me a lot of boost and confidence. I'm happy that things are going according to plan, and I'm very grateful to my whole team. I know there were days when I felt absolutely low, but my team was always there to pump me up. It's time to go back and celebrate," she said.

Asked whether she felt she was back to her best, Sindhu was emphatic. "Definitely yes. As you keep growing, it's important to improve and be smarter in your choices. At the same time, it was important to stay calm. There is still room to improve, things are getting better, and I'm happy with that."

Sindhu opened with a sharp cross-court winner. Although Kjaersfeldt briefly moved ahead 5-3, the Indian responded with five successive points to seize control. Her deceptive strokes, crisp net play and well-directed smashes kept the Dane under pressure as Sindhu carried a three-point advantage into the interval. The Indian extended her lead to 17-12 with a well-placed backcourt push and a superb backhand winner. Sindhu wrapped up the opening game 21-12.

The second game followed a similar pattern. Sindhu moved ahead 6-3 before the Dane briefly reduced the deficit to 6-7. However, the Indian quickly regained control. She opened up a 17-11 lead before sealing the championship with her first match point.

Pix: Piyal Bhattacharjee

# A wall of champions, a new name waits to join the legends

Once an all-male preserve, Sir Chhotu Ram Akhara in Rohtak is an unlikely nursery for women wrestlers. Sakshi Malik's Rio 2016 medal was the tipping point, now Manisha Bhanwala's historic world title gives it a new meaning altogether

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**Rohtak:** Some walls tell stories. Inside the wrestling academy at Sir Chhotu Ram Akhara here, one such wall speaks of Olympic glory, world-class grit and the extraordinary journeys of wrestlers who once dared to dream big. Large photographs of Sushil Kumar, Yogeshwar Dutt and Sakshi Malik adorn it, turning the space into something of an informal hall of fame. And now, there is a new champion whose photograph is waiting to find its place among these illustrious names — Manisha Bhanwala.

"Yes, yes, Manisha's photograph will soon be up here too," chief coach Mandeep Singh said with a knowing smile. "These photographs are reserved for our Indian wrestling's extraordinary champions. When world champion Manisha returns to the academy, she will put up her own photograph. All the trainees will be here for that moment. Perhaps, the next time you visit, you will find her photo there," he said.

It was an evening on Saturday when the day's gruelling training had already drawn to a close. The young wrestlers were preparing to head home. Yet, wanting to talk about Manisha gave them a reason to linger. They stayed back, eager to talk about their Manisha *didi* — the senior teammate whose journey has made their own ambitions seem a little less distant.

For this is no ordinary celebration at the *Akhara*. In winning the 59kg title at the senior world wrestling championships in Astana, Manisha has added another glorious chapter to an institution that has, over the years, quietly built a formidable reputation as a nursery for producing India's finest women wrestlers.

TIMES Special

For Mandeep, who has coached here since 2010, Manisha's triumph is the culmination of years of discipline. "When she joined me some years ago, Manisha was regular, dedicated and always looking to improve. She would identify her shortcomings and work on them. Her ground game, once a weakness, improved considerably," he said.

The Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, where Manisha missed a medal, did not derail her. "After she returned, she did not miss a single day of practice. Her enthusiasm remained the same," Mandeep said.

Manisha now gives back to her institution as well. Posted here as a Haryana gov coach under the sports quota, she guides younger wrestlers while pursuing her own career.

Komal, a 65kg wrestler and Manisha's sparring partner for two years, knows the demands. They train together two or three times a week. "She is powerful, but also points out our mistakes and tells us how to correct them. We learn a lot," Komal said.

Deepanshi Phogat, a 50kg wrestler who has trained here for five years, values Manisha's generosity. "When we struggle with a move or strength, she explains it like an elder sister. She teaches from the heart," she said.

**HIGH TURNOVER:** Young wrestlers train under the watchful eyes of chief coach Mandeep Singh at Chhotu Ram Akhada in Rohtak

For trainee Mahi Singh, Manisha has made a world title feel within reach. "I watch her techniques and ask how to do them. I want to become a wrestler like *didi* and win an Olympic medal," she said.

The academy's story is also one of persistence. Named after reformer Sir Chhotu Ram, it was once a male-only preserve. In the early 2000s, coach Ishwar Singh Dahiya began training girls despite social resistance. Sakshi's 2016 Rio Olympic bronze brought national recognition and helped transform the modest tin-roofed facility into a modern, air-conditioned training hall.

Mandeep informed the centre has produced around 25 international medal-winning women wrestlers, including 15 world medallists across age groups. Its celebrated names include Sakshi, Reetika Hooda, Mansi Ahlawat, Ritu Malik, Pooja Gehlot and Savita Dalal. Around 80 girls now train here. "We give the children as much time as we can. If wrestling is helping build their future, we must give them our maximum," Mandeep said.

## SNAP SHOTS

### Pant out of third game

Wicketkeeper-batter Rishabh Pant was ruled out on Sunday of the third and final red-ball fixture between India 'A' and New Zealand 'A', starting Nov 7, as a precaution, casting a shadow over his availability for the first Test in Wellington. Pant was earlier ruled out of the first two India 'A' games in New Zealand after suffering a side strain in the Irani Cup. "Rishabh Pant has been ruled out of the third unofficial Test vs New Zealand A, as a precautionary measure," said a BCCI source.

**Pranavi logs top-20 finish:** India's star golfer Pranavi Urs shot a solid four-under 68 to round off a decent week at the Wistron Ladies Open, finishing tied 17th in Taoyuan, Chinese Taipei, on Sunday. This was her ninth top-20 finish of the season. She ended with rounds of 70-68-73-68 to be nine-under 279.

**Shnaider wears crown:** Russia's Diana Shnaider won her first title of the year with a hard-fought victory over Leylah Fernandez in Tokyo on Sunday and couldn't wait to tell her mum. The world number 13 beat Canada's Fernandez 6-4, 5-7, 6-2 to win the Pan Pacific Open and then went straight to her phone to call home.

**Alcaraz triumphs:** Carlos Alcaraz beat Alex de Minaur 6-1, 6-4 to win the Vienna Open on Sunday, claiming his fourth title of the season and the 28th of his career, and extending his ATP 500 winning streak to 26 matches. The 23-year-old Spaniard arrived in Vienna after titles in Doha and Tokyo and completed a perfect 16-0 record at ATP 500 events in 2026, capping another dominant week without dropping a set in his five matches.

**Hami takes record pole:** Lewis Hamilton became the oldest man to claim a pole position since 1982, when he secured his first pole for Ferrari ahead of Mercedes' George Russell in Saturday's qualifying for the Mexico City Grand Prix. Hamilton and Russell needed to be fastest. They are the only drivers who can prevent Kimi Antonelli from clinching the title on Sunday. Each of the front-row pair needs to win and hope the Italian finishes worse than ninth. For Hamilton, it was his first pole since the Hungarian Grand Prix in 2023, and it brought his total to 105 poles. At 41, he became the oldest pole-sitter since Mario Andretti claimed the final pole of his career aged 42 at the 1982 Italian GP, also for Ferrari.

**Goa edge past Inter Kashi:** FC Goa relied on the poaching skills of their proven goal-scorer Chiki to put it across Inter Kashi FC 2-1 for their first win in the Indian Super League in Pune on Sunday. It was Franchu who gave Goa the lead in the 34th minute but the visitors were jolted when Inter Kashi captain Sumit Passi struck on the counter to draw level in the 51st minute. It was then left to Chiki to strike in the 66th minute to ensure Goa's win.

**Spurs top Timberwolves:** Victor Wembanyama poured in a season-high 43 points to help the host San Antonio Spurs defeat the short-handed Minnesota Timberwolves 121-111 on Saturday.

**K'taka in semis:** Karnataka girls claimed a 79-55 win over Chhattisgarh to enter the semifinals of the Youth National Basketball championship in Pune on Sunday.

**Results (Quarters): Girls:** Karnataka 79 (Mahek Sharma 22, HS Shreshta 17, Aanchal P Seervi 18, Vibha S M 12, Aadhya Vijay 10) bt Chhattisgarh 55 (Rumi Konwar 26).

# K'taka eye second straight win

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

It's been a testing start to the season for former champions Karnataka. After conceding the first-innings lead in their opening two Ranji Trophy matches, they finally found their rhythm against a struggling Tripura in Mysuru last week. Shreyas Gopal and his men bounced back with an innings-and-116-run victory to revive their campaign.

With nine points from three matches, Karnataka are fourth in the standings. With just one league fixture remaining before the red-ball season takes a break for the white-ball tournaments, they will be keen to sign off with another win when they take on Assam at the Barsapara Stadium in Guwahati from Monday. A victory in the away fixture could significantly strengthen their chances of qualifying for the knockouts.

RANJI TROPHY

Playing in the East, however, will bring its own challenges, with the visitors needing to adapt quickly to the conditions and the early start.

TOI

**FRESH CHALLENGE:** Karnataka will have to come up with an all-round show against Assam

Karnataka have struggled to get their combinations right in their two home games and will be looking for a course correction. The R Vinay Kumar-coached side have had their share of teething troubles, with a settled opening partnership among the biggest concerns. They still lack a substantial opening stand, and Mayank Agarwal, who has yet to find his stride this season, will be eager to make amends. He is likely to again open alongside Rohan Patil.

However, there have been encouraging signs in the middle order, with the all-rounders and youngsters stepping up. Manvanth Kumar has emerged as the find of the season, making valuable contributions with both bat and ball, while Aneeshwar Gautam is fresh from a century. KV Aneesh and KL Shrijith have also chipped in, while seasoned campaigner Karun Nair has provided valuable experience.

The bowling department, though, remains a work in progress, with inconsistency hurting Karnataka. Vidwath Kaverappa, who was left out against Tripura to accommodate an extra spinner, is likely to return and lead the pace attack alongside Vyshak Vijaykumar and Manvanth. Captain Shreyas will continue to shoulder the responsibility in the spin department.

Assam, meanwhile, will be eager to bounce back after a heavy defeat to Saurashtra in Rajkot in the previous match.

# Boyle, Foxcroft lead NZ 'A' fightback

**Christchurch:** New Zealand 'A' recovered from a disastrous start to reach 218 for three at stumps on day two of the second unofficial Test against India 'A' here on Sunday, riding on an unbeaten century by Matthew Boyle and a half-century from Dean Foxcroft.

Boyle was batting on 107 off 148 balls, having struck 14 boundaries and a six, while Foxcroft remained unbeaten on 80 off 180 deliveries, with nine fours, as the duo stitched together an unbroken 205-run partnership for the fourth wicket to put the hosts back in the contest.

New Zealand 'A' were in deep trouble at 13 for three after losing three wickets in the first eight overs, with Mohammed Siraj and Mukesh Kumar doing the early damage. Siraj dismissed captain Rhys Mariu (4), who was caught behind by Dhruv Jurel, while Mukesh removed Curtis Heaphy (4) and Tim Robinson (3) in quick succession to leave the hosts reeling. However, Boyle and Foxcroft displayed considerable patience and application to steady the innings.

**Brief scores: India 'A': 346 all out (o/n: 291/7) in 102.4 overs** (Dhruv Jurel 105, Akash Deep 68; Fraser Sheat 4-63, Brett Randell 2-66, Jarrod McKay 2-113) vs **New Zealand 'A': 218/3 in 62 overs** (Matthew Boyle 107 batting, Dean Foxcroft 80 batting; Mukesh Kumar 2-44). PTI

# Captain Harman does the 'trick for India

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**Jalandhar:** India registered a 4-2 victory over Malaysia in an engaging contest in the penultimate league engagement at the Asian Champions Trophy here on Sunday. Captain Harmanpreet Singh led from the front with a hat-trick.

India made a confident start against Malaysia and broke into the lead in the third minute with Harmanpreet's powerful drafgflick finding the net. India had chances to swell the lead, but failed to convert.

ACT HOCKEY

India displayed impressive composure and control, moving the ball around with precision and using their passing game to dictate the tempo. Up front, India had to do without in-form striker Abhishek, who picked up an injury during warm-ups and missed the match.

The second quarter witnessed a significant shift in momentum, with Malaysia stepping up their intensity in search of an equaliser. The contest turned into a penalty-corner battle, with Malaysia piling on the pressure and earning three. However, Indian goalkeeper Krishan Pathak stood tall in the post, producing another crucial save to deny Faizal Saari and keep India's lead intact—Malaysia's repeated inability to convert their penalty corners added to the mounting frustration.

Hockey India

**STRIKE FORCE:** Harmanpreet Singh

However, the Malaysian pressure eventually paid off. Akhimullah Anuar found a way through India's defensive line to level the score, with Faiz Jali providing the decisive pass in the build-up to the equaliser in the 26th minute.

India came out firing in the third quarter, putting the Malaysian defence under sustained pressure. A penalty corner earned by Sukhjeet Singh created the chance, and Harmanpreet unleashed a trademark drag-flick to restore India's lead.

Malaysia's Faiz Jali was shown a yellow card for a tackle on Mandeep, and India made the most of the man advantage as Sukhjeet Singh unleashed a reverse flick off a Hardik pass to stretch the lead. With two minutes to go, India found the fourth goal with Harmanpreet completing his hat-trick by converting a penalty stroke. A minute later, Shello Silverius added a consolation goal for Malaysia.

In the last league engagement on Monday, India, who have confirmed their place in the semifinals, will take on South Korea.

**Other results:** Korea: 5 (Park Geunwoo 7,34; Son Dain 17, 32, 51) bt Bangladesh 0; Japan: 2 (Raiki Fujishima 48; Yuma Nagai 48) drew with China: 2 (Zhang Jialiang 8; Chen Benhai 60).

# Platform for Indians to shine

**M.Sudharshan**@timesofindia.com

Chennai: The challenge is formidable, but so is the opportunity. The Indian singles contingent at the Chennai Open will be keen to make its presence felt against a competitive international field and use the WTA 250 platform to push their limits.

For the second successive year, three Indians have been awarded main draw wildcards. Teenager Maaya Rajeshwaran Revathi will enter the competition on the back of her maiden professional singles title, which she won at a W35 event in Portugal, while India No. 1 Vaishnavi Adkar has had impressive performances this year.

CHENNAI OPEN

Maaya shifted her training base from Rafa Nadal Academy to the Elite Tennis Centre in France three months ago, and the 17-year-old feels that the move has helped her.

As for world No. 334 Vaishnavi, she sees playing in this event as a big opportunity rather than a source of pressure. This will be the final edition of the Chennai Open, with the slot having been allocated to Manila next year.

"We need to show the world that there is potential in this country as well," Vaishnavi said. The other Indian in the fray is Sahaja Yamalapalli. She was one of the two Indians to enter the second round at the Chennai Open last year.

## Paes to run for VP

**Pune:** In a move filled with surprise and intrigue, Leander Paes has decided to run for the lone vice-president's post in the All India Tennis Association (AITA) elections, scheduled for Nov 27, **reports Kumaraswamy K.** Paes' candidature was revealed by Chintan Parikh, AITA's interim president, in a press release on Sunday. "Parikh will contest as president and Paes as vice president. Both of them will be supported by a capable team of honorary secretary, treasurer, two joint secretaries and other Executive Committee members ... these names will be decided in the next few days," the press release said. TNN

# Dominant Sathish bags title

**Ashim.Sunam**@timesofindia.com

**Bengaluru:** India's Sathish Karunakaran and Yataweemin Ketklieng of Thailand clinched the men's and women's singles crowns, respectively, at the KBA Diamond Jubilee India International Challenge here on Sunday. Sathish claimed a 21-9, 23-21 victory over Tankara Talasila in the 38-minute final, while Yataweemin eased past India's Diana Waldia 21-11, 21-10 in 30 minutes.

Sathish was in his element from the start, taking an 11-4 lead with a lovely net shot that drew applause from the crowd at the KSBA courts. The Tamil Nadu shuttler, competing in his first singles event after recovering from a patellar tendon injury last year, gave his opponent little chance and played an all-round game to win the first game in 14 minutes.

BADMINTON

However, Tankara was in no mood to give up and looked sharper in the second game. He went toe-to-toe until 8-8, with both players making unforced errors, before Sathish moved ahead 13-9 with strong smashes and deceptive net play. Those shots brought him to 20-18, but Tankara saved three match points before his long return sent Sathish into jubilation.

In the women's event, fourth seed Yataweemin dominated her final against Diana, clinching the title in the day's first match.

**CHAMPIONS:** Sathish Karunakaran (left) and Yataweemin Ketklieng

In the men's doubles, Sai Pratheek K and Ruban Rethinasabapathi defeated Malaysia's Lau Yi Sheng and Lee Yi Bo 21-15, 21-19 to emerge triumphant. In the corresponding women's contest, the Japanese pair of Mei Sudo and Mai Tanabe battled past local hope Ashwini Bhat K and Shikha Gautam with a 21-13, 13-21, 21-19 scoreline.

**Results: Singles: Men:** Sathish Karunakaran bt Tankara Talasila 21-9, 23-21; **Women:** Yataweemin Ketklieng (Tha) bt Dianka Waldia 21-11, 21-10; **Doubles: Men:** Sai Pratheek K/Ruban Rethinasabapathi bt Lau Yi Sheng/Lee Yi Bo (Mas) 21-15, 21-19; **Women:** Mei Sudo/Mai Tanabe (Jpn) bt Ashwini Bhat K/Shikha Gautam, 21-13, 13-21, 21-19; **Mixed:** Rodion Alimov/Alina Davletova bt C Lalramsanga/Angel Punera 21-12, 21-14.

# Mbappe strikes as Real extend winning run

**Santander (Spain):** Real Madrid beat hosts Racing Santander 3-0 in LaLiga on Sunday with goals from Kylian Mbappe, Jude Bellingham and Yan Diomande to rack up a sixth straight victory in all competitions.

Mbappe opened the scoring with an 11th-minute penalty, before Bellingham skipped past Racing goalkeeper Julen Agirrezabala to add a second in the 22nd minute. Diomande thundered a bouncing ball into the top corner to stretch their advantage to three goals nine minutes before the break.

FOOTBALL

In a comfortable second half for Real, Mbappe went closest to another goal when he hit the post after an hour.

Third-placed Real Madrid are three points behind league leaders Barcelona, who thrashed Alaves 6-1 on Saturday, and a point behind Atletico Madrid in second. Racing stay in 16th, one point above the relegation zone.

AFP

**ALL SMILES:** Kylian Mbappe (left)

**BAYERN HELD BY DORTMUND**

Fabio Silva's 89th-minute goal earned Borussia Dortmund a 2-2 draw at Bayern Munich after Harry Kane missed a penalty in a see-saw Bundesliga clash on Saturday.

**Select results: Spanish league:** Getafe 3 (Unal 68, Satriano 73, Mangala 90+4) bt Sevilla 1 (Salas 19); Racing Santander 0 lost to Real Madrid 3 (Mbappe 11-pen, Bellingham 22, Diomande 37). **Saturday**: Barcelona 6 (Raphinha 8, 41, Lopez 23, Yamal 45+1, 64, Gordon 81) bt Alaves 1 (Diaz 84). **Italian league:** Como 1 (Da Cunha 43-pen) bt Venezia 0; Lazio 2 (Isaksen 36, Pinamonti 83) bt Cagliari 1 (Nzola 21); Frosinone 2 (Ghedjemis 48, Calo 90+3) bt Torino 0; **Saturday:** AC Milan 3 (Pulisic 4, Rabiot 10, Moreira 43) Inter Milan 1 (Bastoni 22). **German league: Saturday:** Bayern Munich 2 (Laimer 38, Upamecano 66) drew with Borussia Dortmund 2 (Guirassy 60, Silva 89). AGENCIES

## Chiranth, Savion shine

Bengaluru's **Chiranth Vishwanath** held off his arch-rival and Petronas TVS Racing team-mate, Sarthak Chavan from Pune, for the second time in two days to complete a double in the premier Super Sport 301-400cc Open class as the third round of the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 2W 2026 concluded at the Madras International Circuit on Sunday.

MOTORSPORT

Sarthak and Chiranth were locked in a keen fight. The decisive moment came in the closing stages when the 19-year-old roared past Sarthak. Chiranth went on to register his second win of the weekend, while Sarthak again had to settle for a P2 finish.

Earlier, Bengaluru's 19-year-old Savion Sabu delivered another strong performance, leading a maiden podium sweep for the MadRabbit Racing team and completing a double this weekend in the Pro-Stock 200cc Open class.

**Results (Provisional – all 6 laps unless mentioned, only B'luru): Super Sport 301-400cc Open (Race-2):** 1. Chiranth Vishwanath (B'luru, 11min, 09.613sec). **Pro-Stock 200cc Open (Race-2):** 1. Savion Sabu (B'luru, 11:51.669); 3. AS James (B'luru, 11:54.026). **Petronas TVS One-Make Championship: Expert (Apache RR 310) Race-2:** 3. AS James (B'luru, 11:39.270). **Rookie (Apache RTR 200) Race-2:** 2. Dev Agastya (B'luru, 13:14.006). TNN

## East Bengal women off to winning start

**Kolkata:** East Bengal women's team began their Mission Asia on a perfect note, defeating Vietnamese champions Ho Chi Minh City WFC 2-1 in their Group B opener of the AFC Women's Champions League here on Sunday, **reports Nilesh Bhattacharya.**

Ugandan striker Fazila Ikwaput was the chief architect of the hosts' win at Kishore Bharati Krirangan, scoring both goals in the first half and setting the Moshal Girls on track for a historic last-8 spot in the continent's premier women's club football. TNN

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SKODA

TIMES SPORT
THE TIMES OF INDIA, BENGALURU | MONDAY, NOVEMBER 2, 2026

SKODA

Tough day on the pitch.
Brighter days on the road.

# WARNING BELLS DESPITE SERIES WIN

## Seifert, Phillips And Milne Expose India's Flaws In 5th T20I; NZ Sign Off With Seven-Wicket Victory

**Gaurav.Gupta**@timesofindia.com

India may have pocketed the five-match T20I series 3-2, but Sunday's crushing seven-wicket defeat to New Zealand in Hamilton exposed several cracks that will concern the team management ahead of the ODI leg starting on Nov 4.

For the second successive match, India's bowling lacked penetration and their fielding failed to back it up as New Zealand chased down 192 with ease at Seddon Park. Tim Seifert blasted a breathtaking 93 off 50 balls, while Glenn Phillips capped a dream series with an unbeaten 65 off 38 deliveries as the hosts romped home with 12 balls to spare.

Earlier, Adam Milne's fiery spell of 4-19 had ensured India were restricted to 191-8 despite half-centuries from Ishan Kishan and captain Shreyas Iyer.

The biggest talking point before the match was India's continued reluctance to hand teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi an opportunity despite the game being a dead rubber. Instead, Sanju Samson retained his place and endured another disappointing outing, falling for four. Apart from his 67 in the opening match, Samson failed to make an impact in the series and compounded a poor evening by dropping Phillips on 31.

India's innings appeared set for a grandstand finish after Kishan and Iyer launched a counterattack following early setbacks. Abhishek Sharma fell for one while Sam son's struggles continued, leaving India under pressure at 18-2.

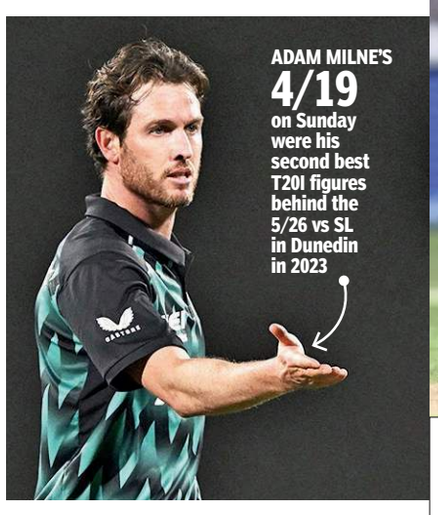
Kishan, returning after missing two matches because of a low-grade adductor strain, looked in sublime touch from the outset. The left-hander hammered 61 off just 32 balls, striking five fours and five sixes. At the other end, Iyer finally rediscovered his rhythm, racing to a 22-ball fifty, his fastest in T20Is.

The pair added 93 runs in only 43 balls for the third wicket and powered India to 111-2 after 10 overs.

However, New Zealand's bowlers staged an impressive comeback. Blair Tickner dismissed Kishan while Nathan Smith removed Iyer with a well-directed short ball. Milne's pace and bounce troubled the lower order and India managed only 80 runs in the second half of the innings. Naman Dhir's 33 and Nitish Kumar Reddy's 22 provided late impetus, but the visitors ultimately finished short of what would have been a par score.

The chase belonged almost entirely to New Zealand. Seifert survived an early reprieve when Naman Dhir dropped him on 13 and made India pay dearly. He added 73 runs with Daryl Mitchell before combining with Phillips in an 86-run stand for the third wicket that effectively ended the contest.

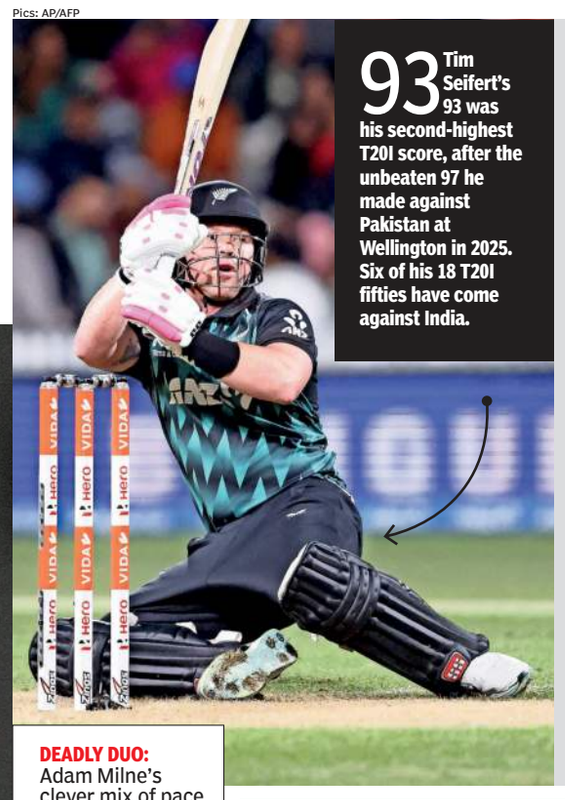
Phillips once again showcased why he is among the most destructive T20 batters in the world in the middle order. Fresh from his century in the previous match, he struck eight fours and three sixes and finished the series with a record-breaking 341 runs in five matches.



ADAM MILNE'S **4/19** on Sunday were his second best T20I figures behind the 5/26 vs SL in Dunedin in 2023

There was one bright spot for India. Kishan's knock took his tally to 1,220 T20I runs in 2026, surpassing Suryakumar Yadav's record for the most runs by an Indian in a calendar year and helping him cross the 2,000-run milestone in T20Is. But on a night when New Zealand exposed India's shortcomings with the ball and in the field, the 3-2 series victory felt a little hollow.

Pics: AP/AFP



**DEADLY DUO:** Adam Milne's clever mix of pace and Tim Seifert's (right)innovative strokeplay guided New Zealand to a comfortable 7-wicket win over India in the fifth T20I in Hamilton's Seddon Park on Sunday

**93** Tim Seifert's 93 was his second-highest T20I score, after the unbeaten 97 he made against Pakistan at Wellington in 2025. Six of his 18 T20I fifties have come against India.

**341** Glenn Phillips amassed 341 runs at an average of 113.66, including a century and three fifties in five innings, the highest aggregate by a batter in a bilateral T20I series. He surpassed England's Phil Salt, who scored 331 runs at 82.75 against West Indies in 2023-24. After Pakistan's Muhammad Rizwan and Japan's Saborish Ravichandran, he is only the third batter to hit four 50-plus scores in a series.

**2016** Ishan became the seventh Indian batter to complete 2,000 T20I runs. He joins Rohit Sharma (4,231), Virat Kohli (4,188), Suryakumar Yadav (3,272), Hardik Pandya (2,288), Abhishek Sharma (2,268) and KL Rahul (2,265).

—**Stats:** Rajesh Kumar

True fans never lose their drive.

### SCOREBOARD

**India:** S Samson c Bracewell b Milne 4, A Sharma c Mitchell b Milne 1, I Kishan c Smith b Tickner 61, S Iyer c Seifert b Smith 50, T Varma c and b Smith 6, N Dhir c Bracewell b Tickner 33, N Reddy c Phillips b Milne 22, B Kumar c Mitchell b Milne 6, P Yadav not out 0, A Singh not out 1. **Extras:** (b1, lb-1 nb1, w4) 7. **Total:** 191-8 in 20 overs.
**Fall of wickets:** 1-2, 2-19, 3-112, 4-123, 5-133, 6-179, 7-185, 8-190
**Bowling:** Jacob Duffy 3-0-27-0, Adam Milne 4-0-19-4, Nathan Smith 3-0-28-2, Blair Tickner 4-0-38-2, Mitchell Santner 4-0-39-0, Michael Bracewell 2-0-38-0.
**New Zealand:** T Seifert b Reddy 93, F Allen c Kishan b Arshdeep 2, D Mitchell c Abhishek b Varun 29, G Phillips not out 65, B Jacobs not out 1.
**Extras:** (lb2, w3) 5. **Total:** 195-3 in 18 overs.
**Fall of wickets:** 1-9, 2-82, 3-168
**Bowling:** B Kumar 4-0-41-0, Arshdeep 4-0-40-1, P Yadav 3-0-35-0, V Chakravarthy 4-0-45-1, N Reddy 2-0-19-1, A Sharma 1-0-13-0.
**Result:** NZ won by 7 wickets
**Player-of-the-Match:** Adam Milne
**Player-of-the-Series:** G Phillips

## Gambhir on Vaibhav: Will take right calls, not popular ones

**Hamilton:** India head coach Gautam Gambhir has made it clear that team selection will be driven by what is best for the side rather than public sentiment, even as teenage batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi continued to miss out.

Speaking ahead of the fifth T20I against New Zealand, Gambhir defended the management's approach of backing established performers, stressing that creating security within the dressing room was as important as rewarding emerging talent. "My job is not to make everyone happy. My job is to take the right decisions, not the popular decisions," Gambhir said.

"It's very easy to take the popular decision. For me, the important thing is to take the right decision and make sure there is a lot of security inside the dressing room. Guys who have done phenomenally well over a longer period deserve a longer rope," he said.

After the game, he hailed skipper Shreyas Iyer for leading the side to a series win, describing the achievement as "incredible" given the limited preparation time and lack of experienced bowlers. AGENCIES

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SANDALWOOD'S HALLOWEEN COOL CATS SERVE UP SOME SPOOKY STYLE P4



Check out what our critic says about Mr Lucky P4

Diljit Dosanjh: He is an artist, bro! P3

Priyanka backs Oscar-qualified Indian short with Andrew Scott P2


HOT TAKES

# Celebrating the launch of a new era of payments

Mumbai witnessed an exclusive evening hosted by Visa to celebrate the launch of Apple Pay for Axis Bank cardholders, marking a new chapter in convenient, seamless digital payments. The celebration brought together actor Ali Fazal, travel creator Tanya Khanijow, and entrepreneur and content creator Saloni Kukreja. In a fireside conversation moderated by Gaurav Ramdev, Head of Marketing, India & South Asia, Visa, the three shared perspectives from their respective worlds – from Ali's international career and Tanya's travels to Saloni's experience as a creator and entrepreneur. Their conversation highlighted how seamless digital experiences are becoming increasingly relevant across travel, work, business and everyday life.

(L-R) Gaurav Ramdev, Ali Fazal, Tanya Khanijo and Saloni Kukreja

At the heart of the evening was the ease of getting started with Apple Pay. Axis Bank cardholders can add an eligible Visa card to Apple Wallet in just a few simple steps, without needing to carry a physical card or enter card details each time they pay. Once added, the card can be used wherever contactless payments are accepted – in stores, within apps and online. Payments are authorised securely with Face ID, Touch ID or a device passcode, offering a faster and more seamless alternative to traditional methods such as OTP-based authentication. With card details protected and not shared with merchants during transactions, the service combines convenience, speed and security in one intuitive experience.

Ramakrishnan Gopalan

Guests also experienced a live demonstration, seeing how easy it is to make a secure, contactless payment. An e-commerce demonstration led by Ramakrishnan Gopalan, Head of Product and Solutions, India and South Asia, Visa, also showcased how seamlessly consumers can complete an online purchase, without having to manually enter their card details. Blending innovation with engaging conversations and immersive experiences, the evening celebrated a shared vision by Visa, Axis Bank and Apple Pay: making payments more intuitive, secure and convenient for consumers, wherever life takes them.

Leaders from the payment and banking sectors along with Ali Fazal at the launch of the digital payment service

A CELEBRATION OF LOVE: DHANANJAYA & DHANYATHA TO SHARE THEIR WEDDING FILM

P3


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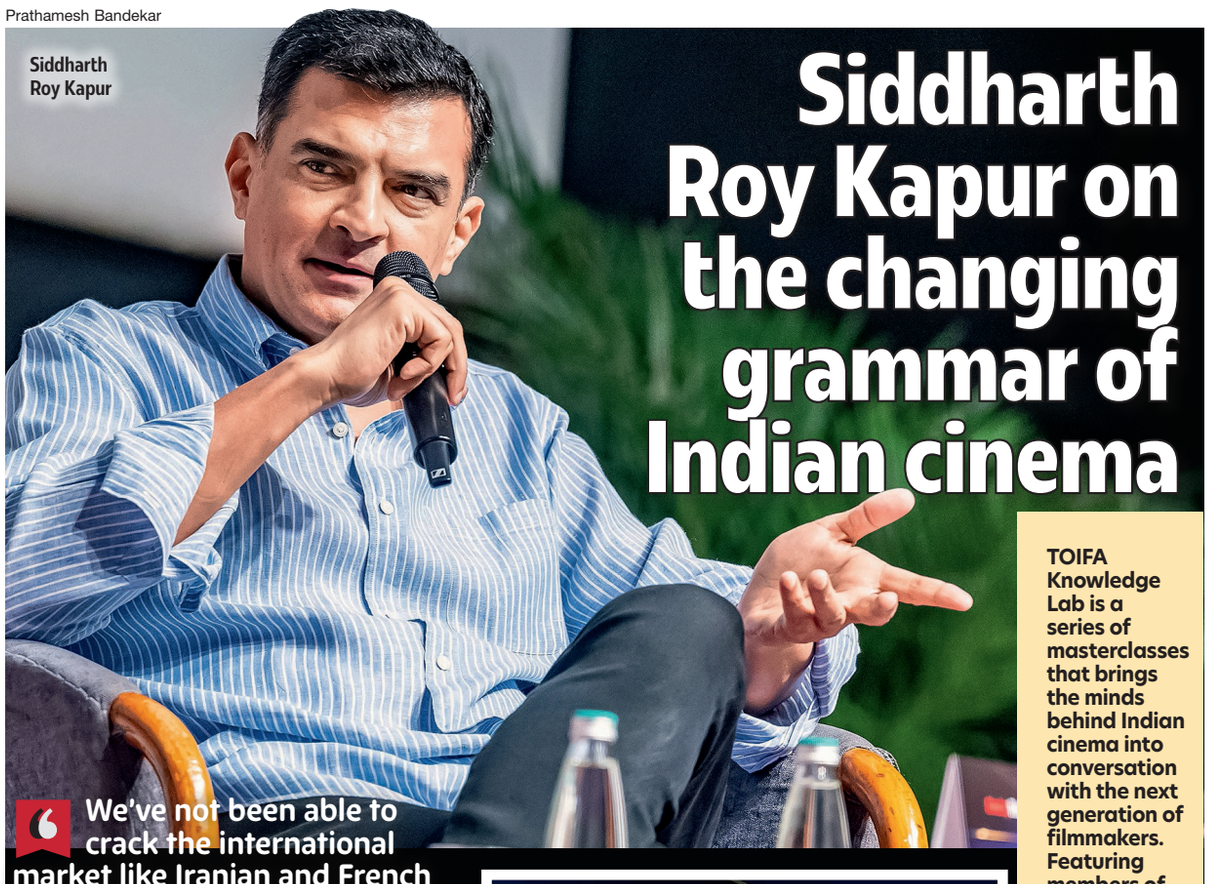
# Hands down, Klum wins Halloween

Heidi Klum, the undisputed Queen of Halloween, stunned at her 25th annual bash in New York as a giant blood-soaked dismembered hand. The elaborate look took six hours to wear. And notice how the manicure's on point!

P4

Prathamesh Bandekar




# Siddharth Roy Kapur on the changing grammar of Indian cinema

"We've not been able to crack the international market like Iranian and French cinema because we have such a large captive audience of our own. Indian cinema has never felt the need to cater to Western or non-South Asian audiences, so the grammar of our cinema has remained what it's always been - longer screentime, an interval point, songs and dances. But these are things that make us unique as well

Bombay Times
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KNOWLEDGE LAB

TOIFA Knowledge Lab is a series of masterclasses that brings the minds behind Indian cinema into conversation with the next generation of filmmakers. Featuring members of the TOIFA (Times of India Film Awards) Advisory Board, the series explores the art, craft and business of making movies. The second masterclass features producer Siddharth Roy Kapur

P2

Vijay Varma in a still from *Matka King*, which is co-produced by Siddharth Roy Kapur

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Everything you can imagine is real - Pablo Picasso

SIDDHARTH ROY KAPUR

# 'It's important to find subjects where emotions transcend boundaries'

A still from *Dangal*

Shalini Sharma

When Siddharth Roy Kapur joined the Indian film industry in 2005, he brought with him a corporate perspective to a business largely driven by legacy film families and independent producers. Over the years, he has combined that business acumen with a willingness to take creative risks, backing films that have earned both critical acclaim and commercial success. As Founder of Roy Kapur Films and a member of the TOIFA Advisory Board, Kapur shared his insights on the business and craft of filmmaking with students at Whistling Woods International, as part of the TOIFA Knowledge Lab masterclasses. Excerpts:

### 'THE CORPORATE WORLD FELT TOO BINARY FOR ME'

Going from the corporate to the creative world didn't feel alien to me. When the film industry realised that I lived and breathed cinema just as much as they did, I got embraced by this industry quickly. I enjoy being around creative people, being involved in decisions that are not black and white. In fact, the corporate world felt too binary & straitjacketed for me.

### 'CHARACTER-DRIVEN STORIES LEND THEMSELVES TO OTT'

If the idea is more plot-driven, then it tends to work for cinema. If it's more character-driven, it works better as a series as you need to live with those characters over long periods of time. For instance, *Rocket Boys* was a saga of two individuals, Homi Bhabha and Vikram Sarabhai, who were close friends and rivals. Their careers span across multiple decades and across a whole arc of our modern history, so it just felt like a series.

Prathamesh Bandekar

Siddharth Roy Kapur

### On the Kapurs' weekly union

When asked about what dinner table conversations are like when the entire family of actors Vidya (Balan), Aditya and Kunaal come together, Siddharth said, "We discuss what we're eating and laugh a lot. We share our stories, share information or vent depending on who's had the most dramatic week. Four of us are working in an industry that's so volatile and sensitive, so the best way we can support each other is by being there for each other."

> AI exists and we need to embrace the ways that it will improve our storytelling. But I think what's important is that they need to have copyrights for the use of someone's likeness or voice. Without that if it runs rampant, you're trampling on people's moral, professional and personal rights. Even Hollywood has not figured it out right now. But I think it will happen in time

### 'FILMS LIKE THE LUNCHBOX AND DANGAL HAD EMOTIONS THAT WERE UNIVERSAL'

For Indian cinema to find a global audience, it's very important to be able to find subjects where the emotions transcend all boundaries, but are very authentic to the sense of place, time and people. *The Lunchbox* is about a tiffin service in Mumbai, which is such a unique thing that doesn't happen anywhere around the world, and within that you're addressing loneliness which is something that everyone anywhere can feel. *Dangal* was about a Haryana wrestling family, but it explored father-daughter dynamics, which is again a universal theme.

### 'WE LOVE BEING FANS OF STARS, IT'S IN OUR CULTURE'

I think there's no doing away with the star system completely because we love being fans of stars, it's in our culture. I was talking to Javed Akhtar *saab* recently, and he was telling me that ever since he entered the industry, there's been a lament that the star system is destroying Bollywood. Today, the good thing is that audiences are indicating that if you give us something without a star that compels us to visit theatres, like *Main Vaapas Aaunga* or *Mirzapur*, we will come in hordes for that too.

Watch the full masterclass on the Bombay Times YouTube channel

Knowledge Partner: Whistling Woods
Instagram: @whistling_woods

## UP TO DATE

## WHAT'S #TRENDING AND WHY

### What went into Anirudh & Kaviya's viral wedding invite

If the wedding invitations are anything to go by, Anirudh and Kaviya Maran seem to already be making a statement. The invitation arrives in an ornate ivory box, complete with intricate powder-blue floral carvings, gold accents and a vintage-inspired medallion. The accompanying invitations follow the same aesthetic: damask-inspired prints, embossed details and wax seals. Ranjani Iyengar, who designed the invitations, said that the idea was to create something that guests would want to hold on to. "Kaviya was closely involved throughout the process; she and Anirudh worked together to refine the design," she mentioned. Getting the box just right was a project in itself. "Each one was individually constructed by hand and hand-painted, with multiple printing techniques used to achieve its elaborate, three-dimensional finish. Even the hinges and the weight of the lids were carefully considered. We experimented with tapping white paint onto the surface and it became part of the final design," Ranjani says.

Aashna Reddy

### Priyanka backs Oscar-contending Indian short with Andrew Scott

Priyanka Chopra Jonas has joined filmmaker Pranav Bhasin's short film *We Were Here* as an executive producer, alongside Andrew Scott and playwright-activist V, formerly known as Eve Ensler, reported *Variety*. The film has already screened at more than 80 international festivals and won over 20 awards, including the audience award for Best Narrative Short at SXSW. Its wins at the Palm Springs International ShortFest also made it eligible for Academy Award consideration. "It offers a refreshing, witty take on a subject that feels very timely. I jumped at the opportunity to come on board as an executive producer to amplify this creative team and ensure their brilliant, original vision gets the spotlight it deserves," she said.

## SUDOKU CHALLENGE

Level: Medium

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | | | | | 3 | 2 | | |
| | | | 2 | | | | | |
| 7 | | 3 | | 1 | | 4 | 8 | |
| 3 | | | 9 | | | | 7 | |
| 2 | | | | | | | | 8 |
| | 9 | | | | 2 | | | 6 |
| | 7 | 4 | | 8 | | 6 | | 3 |
| | | | | | 1 | | | |
| | | 5 | 3 | | | | | 7 |

### HOW TO PLAY

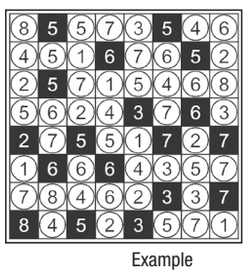
Fill in the grid so that every horizontal row, every vertical column and every 3x3 box contains the digits 1-9, without repeating the numbers in the same row, column or box.You can't change the digits already given in the grid. Every puzzle has one solution.

## TIMES HITORI

### HOW TO PLAY

1. A number may appear just once in each row or column. Eliminate repeat numbers by darkening cells. (see example)
2. Darkened cells must never be adjacent in a row or column.
3. Unmarked cells must create a single continuous area, undivided by darkened cells.
4. Every time you darken a cell, you can automatically circle its vertical and horizontal neighbours, which means they cannot be eliminated.
5. Any cell "sandwiched" between neighbours of the same value can be circled. (e.g. 6 (4) 6 )
6. A "triple" is a special case of sandwich. Circle the centre cells, and darken the ends. (e.g. 6 6 6 )

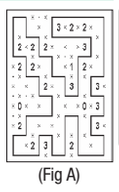
| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 4 | 4 | 2 | 7 | 3 | 1 | 5 | 2 |
| 4 | 6 | 2 | 9 | 3 | 7 | 5 | 8 |
| 1 | 3 | 4 | 1 | 7 | 1 | 8 | 1 |
| 7 | 7 | 9 | 1 | 6 | 4 | 2 | 3 |
| 8 | 8 | 1 | 4 | 8 | 2 | 8 | 7 |
| 6 | 7 | 6 | 8 | 2 | 5 | 1 | 2 |
| 4 | 1 | 6 | 3 | 3 | 8 | 5 | 9 |
| 3 | 5 | 2 | 2 | 4 | 9 | 7 | 6 |

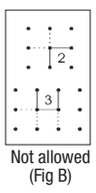

Example

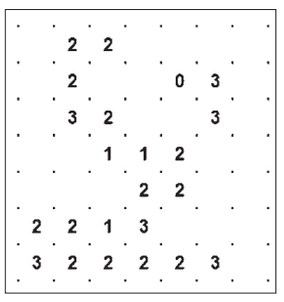
## LOOP THE LOOP

### RULES

- Connect adjacent dots with vertical or horizontal lines, creating a single loop (Fig A).
- Crossovers or branches are not allowed (As shown by dotted lines in Fig B).
- Numbers in the puzzle indicate the number of lines that should surround it, while empty cells may be surrounded by any number of lines.
- You can't draw lines around zeroes.
- Each puzzle has just one unique solution.


(Fig A)


Not allowed (Fig B)

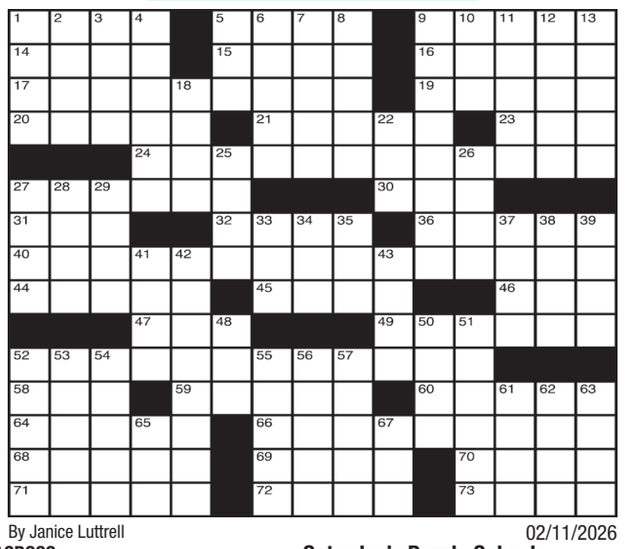


### HOW TO BEGIN:

**Example (Fig A)** - Begin with the zero next to 3. Since no lines can be drawn around zero, mark crosses around it, as shown. Now there is a cross in one space around 3. So we know the three lines of 3 can only be drawn in the remaining three spaces. Next, these lines can only be extended in one direction each. Continue, using the same logic.

**Hints:** Keep eliminating possibilities by marking crosses in spaces between dots where a line isn't possible, i.e., if you have already completed required lines or where a line extension may create a branch or cause a deadend **(Fig B)**.

## THE DAILY CROSSWORD



By Janice Luttrell — 02/11/2026

**ACROSS**

1 "Dancing Queen" pop group
5 "Wish I was there!" anxiety, for short
9 Department store chain headquartered in New York's Herald Square
14 Crystal ball gazer
15 Not of the clergy
16 Anticipate
17 Fix for torn jeans, perhaps
19 Dried beef snack
20 Small brawl
21 "Copperhead Road" singer Steve
23 Near-failing grade
24 Foil-wrapped chocolate drop
27 Election season event
30 Driver's approx.
31 Mined find
32 Cartoon explorer with a talking backpack
36 "No big deal"
40 Gets a single, double, triple, and home run in one game
44 Hay fever sound
45 Unwelcome campground visitor
46 Do some sums
47 __ Angeles Sparks
49 Loves a bunch
52 Accept unintended consequences
58 Abbreviation on a toothpaste box
59 Mexican coins
60 Many a Chopin piano piece
64 Phi Beta __
66 Ideal partners, and what can be found at the ends of 17-, 24-, 40-, and 52-Across?
68 Everglades wader
69 Jai __: fast-moving court game
70 Competes (for)
71 Get to, as a destination
72 Ivy League school in New Haven
73 Baby-voiced red Muppet

**DOWN**

1 Inquires
2 "Molto __": "Very good," in Italian
3 Red root vegetable
4 "Respect" singer Franklin
5 St. Pete's st.
6 Hall's Rock & Roll Hall of Fame partner
7 Old Testament book after Jonah
8 Autumn colour
9 Magnificent
10 Bowl over
11 Rapper __ B
12 "Yowza!"
13 Eyelid sores
18 Ode writer
22 Caustic chemical
25 Upgrade, as decor
26 "Teenage Dream" singer Perry
27 Capital of Qatar
28 "The Little Mermaid" prince
29 "Little Women" sister of Meg, Jo, and Amy
33 Poetic sphere
34 Numbered hwy.
35 "Eureka!"
37 Injury reminder
38 Merrie __ England
39 Sneaker brand since 1916
41 One and only
42 Walking trail
43 Timeline units
48 That lady
50 Day, in Latin
51 Eight-note interval
52 Fraud
53 Pithy bit of wisdom
54 "It's a Wonderful Life" director Frank
55 Writing class assignment
56 Simoleons
57 Typical
61 Gas or elec.
62 Consider to be
63 Gas brand in Canada
65 Chest muscle, for short
67 Fib

### Saturday's Puzzle Solved

| | | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| N | I | G | H | T | M | O | D | E | | B | O | L | T | S |
| I | N | O | R | G | A | N | I | C | | A | D | I | E | U |
| Q | U | A | S | I | M | O | D | O | | S | O | F | A | S |
| A | R | T | | F | I | F | A | | W | I | R | E | D | |
| B | E | S | S | | | | F | L | E | A | S | | F | R | O |
| | | | A | B | S | | | I | T | T | | G | O | E | S |
| | | T | H | A | T | S | T | H | E | W | O | R | S | T |
| | C | H | A | R | A | C | T | E | R | A | R | C | S | |
| Y | O | U | R | E | T | E | L | L | I | N | M | E | | |
| E | M | M | A | | U | N | E | | N | D | A | | | |
| S | I | B | | H | E | E | D | S | | | N | U | N | S |
| | C | R | I | E | S | | A | C | E | D | | N | A | P |
| A | C | I | D | S | | S | N | A | G | A | R | I | D | E |
| N | O | N | O | S | | A | C | R | O | B | A | T | I | C |
| A | N | G | L | E | | L | E | E | T | S | P | E | A | K |

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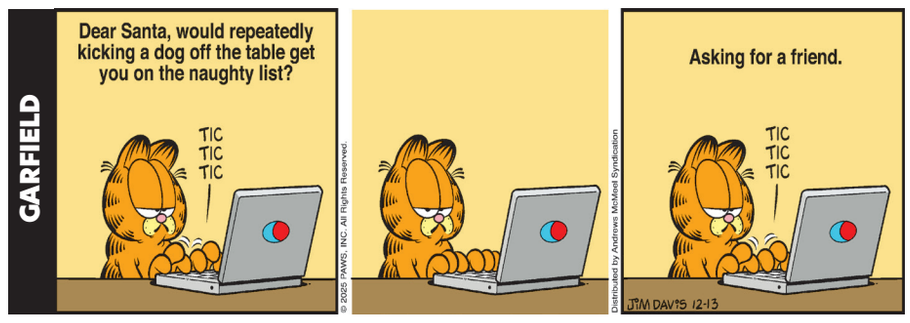



## SCRAMBLE

Rearrange the letters in the four word jumbles, one letter to each square/circle, to make four ordinary words

PVEEE
THROB
OSUMMN
ILLOPW

### HOW TO PLAY

Now arrange the letters in the circles to form the answer to the riddle or to fill in the missing word as indicated

Power can be taken, but not given. The process of the taking is ___ in itself. - Gloria Steinem (11)

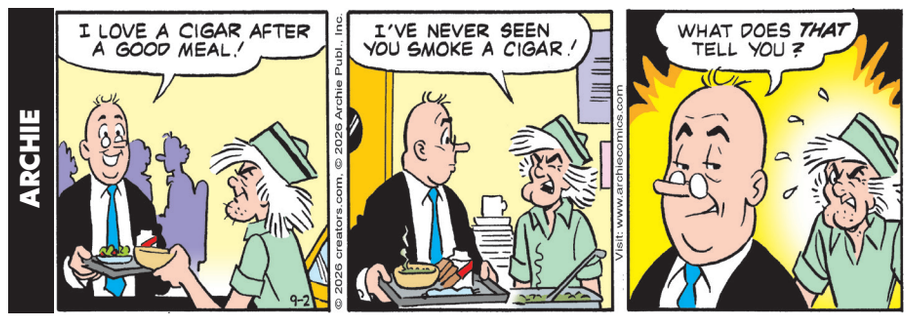
## EVENTS

**WORKSHOPS**

**DIY Halloween Crafts:** Twist, shape and personalise pipe cleaners to make friendly ghosts, pumpkins and spiders at Tealogy Cafe in Koramangala on November 2 from 1 pm onwards.

**Diwali Ka Gharaunda:** Learn to build and decorate your own birdhouse at URU in Whitefield on November 2 from 1 pm onwards.

Email us at bangalore.times@timesofindia.com




**ARIES:** A friendship might leave a bad taste in your mouth. It will resurface later, hoping for a chance to revive. You need to lay the ground rules before reconnecting.

**TAURUS:** You can make changes in the coming days, but act fast. Time is of the essence if you want to revamp your lifestyle and professional circumstances.

**GEMINI:** Forcing someone to love you is wrong. Say less, remain elusive, and let your charm woo them. Playing mind games will only alienate the very person you're trying to attract now. Make time to relish the moment, get away from work responsibilities, and enjoy the connection.

**CANCER:** If the going's been tough, don't give up now or you'll throw out all the previous good work for nothing. The next few days present special opportunities. Don't flog a dead horse if someone isn't cooperating now.

**LEO:** You'll be surprised when you realise a friend can help you with some unusual problem. Connecting with people you wouldn't otherwise have time for will be an interesting departure from the norm.

**VIRGO:** Sharpen your sense of purpose. Analyse what commitments you have now. Reassess where you are going and why. If you have a clear goal, you can expect greater progress in a shorter time.

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**LIBRA:** You'll be making exciting plans with friends. Recent breakthroughs lead to better expression and greater creative output. You'll be participating in conversations that open professional doors.

**SCORPIO:** Take on large-scale projects. It will help either expand your business or at least your imagination. Resolve long-standing problems so you can now raise your salary or station in life.

**SAGITTARIUS:** You will accomplish something important now. Although it took a long time, you're satisfied the task is now complete. Shine the spotlight on your finances.

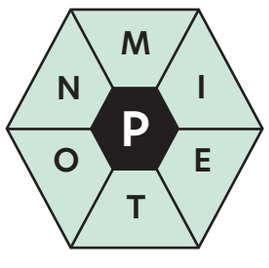
**CAPRICORN:** Focus on things that help you become successful. Forget the past and focus entirely on the now. Things will heat up socially. Be careful how you handle delicate romantic matters, especially when dealing with people who also can't let go of the past.

**AQUARIUS:** Don't embellish what's happening in your current circumstances. It will be easy to think negatively and believe that things are worse than they are. Take things as they arise without too much bias.

**PISCES:** Your mind has a natural interest in financial matters. Don't become obsessive or impulsive about it, though. Don't let your desire for wealth and a better lifestyle blind you to the simple things in life.

## SPELLATHON

**Today's Ratings:**
10-average | 12-good | 14-outstanding




How many words of four or more letters can you make from the letters shown in today's puzzle? In making a word, a letter can be used as many times as it appears in the puzzle. Each word must contain the central letter. There should be at least one seven letter word. Plurals, foreign words and proper names are not allowed. British English Dictionary is used as reference.

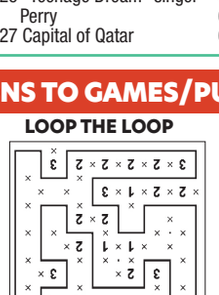
## DENNIS THE MENACE

## SOLUTIONS TO GAMES/PUZZLES

**TIMES SUDOKU**

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | 6 | 5 | 3 | 2 | 4 | 1 | 9 | 7 |
| 9 | 3 | 2 | 7 | 6 | 1 | 8 | 5 | 4 |
| 1 | 7 | 4 | 5 | 8 | 9 | 6 | 2 | 3 |
| 4 | 9 | 7 | 8 | 5 | 2 | 3 | 1 | 6 |
| 2 | 5 | 6 | 1 | 3 | 7 | 9 | 4 | 8 |
| 3 | 1 | 8 | 9 | 4 | 6 | 5 | 7 | 2 |
| 7 | 2 | 3 | 6 | 1 | 5 | 4 | 8 | 9 |
| 6 | 4 | 1 | 2 | 9 | 8 | 7 | 3 | 5 |
| 5 | 8 | 9 | 4 | 7 | 3 | 2 | 6 | 1 |

**LOOP THE LOOP**



**TIMES HITORI**

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | 5 | 2 | 4 | 9 | 7 | 6 | 1 | 8 |
| 1 | 6 | 3 | 8 | 5 | 2 | 9 | 4 | 7 |
| 6 | 7 | 9 | 1 | 4 | 8 | 2 | 3 | 5 |
| 8 | 1 | 4 | 6 | 2 | 9 | 7 | 5 | 3 |
| 7 | 9 | 1 | 6 | 4 | 2 | 3 | 8 | 1 |
| 4 | 6 | 2 | 9 | 7 | 1 | 5 | 3 | 8 |
| 1 | 3 | 4 | 7 | 8 | 5 | 9 | 6 | 2 |
| 5 | 8 | 9 | 3 | 2 | 6 | 1 | 7 | 4 |
| 2 | 4 | 7 | 5 | 1 | 3 | 8 | 9 | 6 |

**SPELLATHON**

inept, mope, open, opine, peon, PIMENTO, pine, pint, pinto, poem, poet, point, tempo, tope

**SCRAMBLE**

Words: Peeve, broth, summon, pillow
Answer: Power can be taken, but not given. The process of the taking is empowerment in itself. - Gloria Steinem

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# Dhananjaya and Dhanyatha to share their wedding film with the world

**What began as a personal keepsake for their first wedding anniversary is now set for an online release as the actor chooses to celebrate the memories as well as the filmmakers behind the project**

Photos from the wedding of Daali Dhananjaya and Dhanyatha Gauraklar; (also right)

Actor Daali Dhananjaya and his wife Dr Dhanyatha Gauraklar are all set to share a rather personal chapter of their lives with the world. The couple's wedding film, *Dhana Dhanya Kalyana*, which began as an intimate documentation of their journey from engagement to marriage, will soon be released online.

In a note announcing the decision on Kannada Rajyotsava, Dhananjaya revealed that the idea took shape after he watched a wedding film made by Shashank Soghal. Intrigued by the cinematic treatment, he met filmmakers Akshay and Sharath Padaru, who proposed documenting the couple's journey and presenting the finished film as a first-anniversary gift.

> Initially it was conceived as a personal keepsake, to revisit occasionally, allowing us to look back at who we were and how we had evolved
> – Daali Dhananjaya

What followed was a little over a year of filming. While Dhananjaya, Dhanyatha and their families were initially conscious of the cameras, Dhananjaya says the filmmaking team gradually became an extension of the family. The result was a collection of moments, emotions and memories, brought together with music to create a film that the couple could revisit over the years.

"Initially it was conceived as a personal keepsake, meant to be watched occasionally, allowing us to look back at who we were and how we had evolved," notes the actor. However, after watching the finished film, Dhananjaya began to wonder if it deserved a wider audience. He felt that keeping the film on a hard drive would deny the filmmakers and technicians the recognition they deserved. However, the couple were hesitant about opening up their personal lives to public scrutiny, especially after their wedding had attracted both affection and criticism.

Eventually, their love for cinema prevailed. The actor felt that the film had captured their thoughts and emotions as they were at that point in their lives, and that the fact that people change and evolve over time was reason enough to embrace those memories. Inviting audiences to watch the film, Dhananjaya likened the experience to family members gathering around to watch an old wedding video when loved ones visit. "We are your family after all," he wrote in his note, announcing that *Dhana Dhanya Kalyana* would soon be available online. TNN

## He is an artist, bro!

POV

And Diljit Dosanjh demonstrated this when he performed for around 80,000 people in Delhi on Friday. Despite the initial hiccups over permissions, the singer made sure Delhi was where he began his tour. Welcomed with roaring cheers, Diljit's concert was like one grand party where different groups came together to have a good time. Families, friends, lovers and solo concertgoers all shared one common thread – *Dosanjhawallah*.

You wanted *bhangra*, you got it. You wanted him to dance, you got it. You wanted him to climb up the stage and make a grand entry, you got it. You wanted him to address the controversy surrounding his comments during the students' protests; you got that too!

"Hate me as much as you can; I only have love for you. I love you all," was the message Diljit kept giving his fans and critics alike.

Celebrities usually try to steer clear of topics that become controversial for them. But here is an artist who has made a phrase that once invited criticism into something he owns with pride.

For the uninitiated, Diljit was asked during an Instagram Live whether he would like to comment on the students' protests at Jantar Mantar over the NEET paper leak. His response was, "Keep me away from all this. Bro, I'm an artist."

He also said that he did not know enough about the matter to comment, while extending his wishes to both the protesters and those at the centre of the protests. His remark, "I am an artist, bro", drew criticism from people who felt he was distancing himself from an issue.

The issue came up again when Abhijeet Dipke took a dig at Diljit during a protest at Jantar Mantar. He mocked the singer's "I am an artist, bro" response while referencing his film *Satluj*. The film, based on human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra, had faced years of delays over certification before finally releasing on ZEE5 in July 2026. It was taken down from the platform within two days. Dipke's remark pointed to the contrast between Diljit distancing himself from the protests by saying he was an artist and his own involvement in a film about a politically significant subject.



Riya Sharma

SOUND CHECK

Diljit addressed the issue himself at the concert. "Don't poke me when I am not poking you. *Punjabiyon nu na sikhao ladayian kidda ladhi jaandiye*," he said. He also reiterated that he supports everyone and loves everyone. Referring to *Satluj*, he reminded the audience that the film was about Jaswant Singh Khalra and that they had fought for a long time to get it made and released.

He didn't wait for someone to bring it up. He addressed it himself, in front of thousands of people, without appearing embarrassed or defensive. He has always been open about issues, and his fans know this side of him. This wasn't a new version of Diljit trying to explain himself. It was the same Diljit being himself.

He has even released a playlist titled *I Am an Artist, Bro*. And the message made its way to the closing moments of the concert, too, with the laser display carrying the same sentiment. It was no longer just a response to a question or a phrase used by his critics. He had made it his own.

You can disagree with what Diljit says, question his choices or criticise him. But he gets to decide how he responds. And if he wants to keep saying, "I am an artist, bro", he can. He doesn't have to say it apologetically or explain himself every time.

After all, he is an artist, bro. And he is going to be himself.

Riya.Sharma@timesofindia.com

There is something haunting in the light of the moon - Joseph Conrad

# Sandalwood's Halloween cool cats serve up some spooky style

**DHANYA RAMKUMAR:** I went with a 1920s-inspired cabaret look this Halloween, opting for a short electric-blue dress with fur and feather detailing. I wanted to channel the glamour and drama of the era while keeping the look fun and playful.



**SAANYA IYER:** I was channelling my inner black cat energy. Cats have played an integral part in my life; at one point, we had 12 indie cats at home! I've always seen them as mysterious guardians, so I had to honour them on Halloween. This was my second Halloween, but my first one as a grown-up. I was in Virginia, where fellow Kannadigas and Indians gathered at a friend's place to celebrate.



**PRANITHA SUBHASH:** My look was meant to be Batwoman, though people seem to think I'm Krish! Arna decided she wanted to be a witch after hearing that her friend was dressing up as a wizard. For Jay, who is obsessed with dinosaurs, a dinosaur costume was an obvious choice. He loved it so much that he's been wearing it all day!

# Serving looks, scares and Halloween glam

@janhvikapoor

"Who could possibly be more iconic than *mumma*, Rishi uncle and Amrish Sir," wrote Janhvi Kapoor as she recreated Sridevi's *Nagina* (1986) look for Halloween

No, that's not AI. It's just Paris Hilton in her Halloween look. The entertainer channelled her inner princess as she dressed up as Rapunzel from *Tangled*

@khushikapoor

Khushi Kapoor took us back to the '80s with her comic-inspired Wonder Woman look

**From the Grady Twins straight-out-of *The Shining* to Rapunzel and Wonder Woman, celebs borrowed from pop culture to create their spooky season looks**

**A TRIBUTE LIKE NO OTHER:** Rita Ora dressed as the Late Dolly Parton

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**POTTERHEADS, ASSEMBLE!** US Vice President JD Vance brought Dumbledore to life, with Dobby the house-elf in his lap

Neil Patrick Harris and husband David Burtka's creepy twins from Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* were scarier than the film itself

# FILM REVIEWS

NOW IN CINEMAS...

## An engaging fantasy thriller elevated by emotional drama

**MR LUCKY**
(Fantasy/Thriller)
★★★½
**Cast:** Raam Tej, Rithi Shetty, Aishwarya Shetty, Raya Aradhya, Srinidhi Bengaluru
**Director:** Harshith Rangaswamy
**Duration:** 2 hrs
**Language:** Kannada (UA)

### Review in short

*Mr Lucky* follows Lakshman, an unlucky IT professional struggling with financial burdens and family responsibilities, whose life takes an unexpected turn when a mysterious man offers him a cap that promises good fortune, albeit at a price. As Lakshman begins to experience the benefits of his newfound luck, he also discovers the consequences that come with it. Tapping into a sentiment many can relate to, the film explores the universal desire for something magical to happen and turn life's fortunes around. Blending fantasy, suspense and emotional drama, it examines the fine line between need and greed, the value of relationships and the importance of understanding what truly matters in life. With relatable characters and engaging storytelling, *Mr Lucky* makes for an emotionally engaging thriller.

– Susmita Sameera

### Should you watch it?

Worth a watch for its engaging mix of fantasy, suspense and drama with a meaningful narrative.

Want a more detailed review? Head to **etimes.in**

**RATING SCALE**
TRASH ★ | BELOW AVERAGE ★★ | AVERAGE ★★½ | ABOVE AVERAGE ★★★ | GOOD ★★★½ | VERY GOOD ★★★★ | OUTSTANDING ★★★★½ | MASTERPIECE ★★★★★

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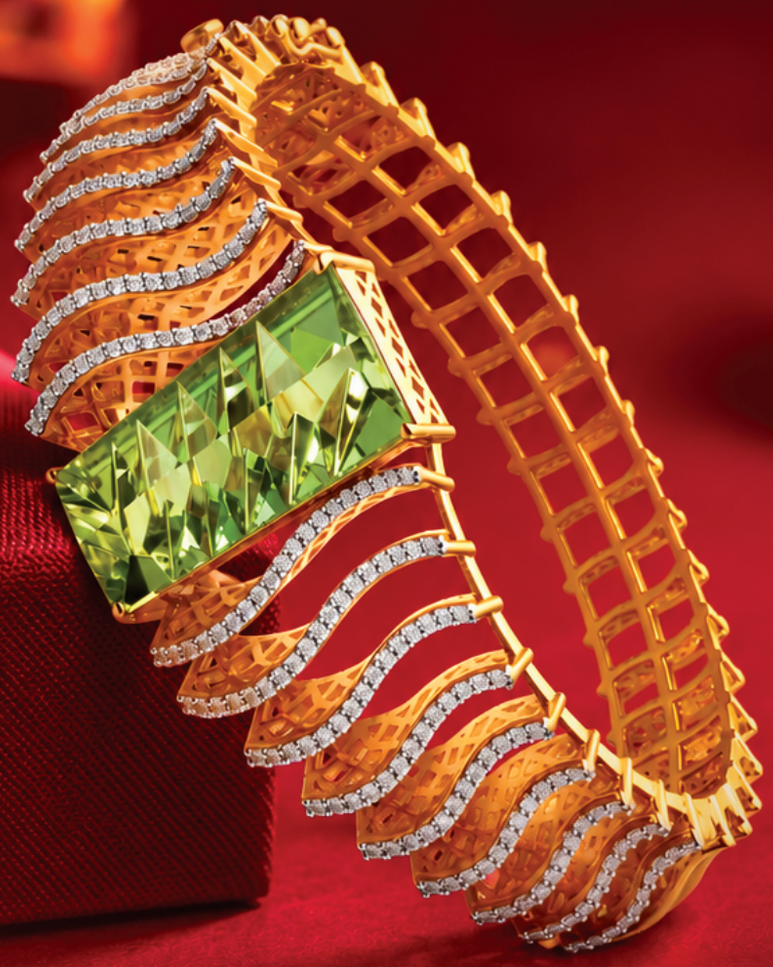

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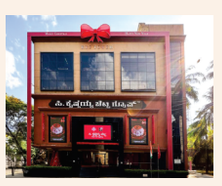

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